Can't Beat Me At Love

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/71461596.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
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Category:
M/M

Fandom:
崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)

Relationship:
Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Characters:
Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Castorice (Honkai: Star Rail), Cipher (Honkai: Star Rail), Cyrene (Honkai: Star Rail)

Additional Tags:
Cyrene and Phainon are Siblings (Honkai: Star Rail), Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Streamer phainon, Baker Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Strangers to Lovers, Mutual Pining, Fluff, Eventual Smut, Phainon is Down Bad (Honkai: Star Rail), Developing Relationship, sickfic for a minute, competition as flirting, Top Phainon/Bottom Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), dates that aren't really dates but sure feel like it, background castocipher, Anal Sex, Hand Jobs, Blow Jobs, Competitive sex, Rough Sex, Light Dom/sub

Language:
English

Stats:

Published: 2025-09-30 Words: 50,051 Chapters: 1/1

Can't Beat Me At Love

by chocolair

Summary

> Mydei is about to close the video when Phainon speaks up after being silent for a while:
>
> "I can guarantee that you're all going to enjoy *Amphorean Chronicles* as much as I do! I can't believe so many of you guys don't know the game, but I'll make sure you get the full grasp of it. Nobody beats me when it comes to it, after all," he says, winking to the camera.
>
> His viewers just leave appreciative comments saying how cute it is for him to be so passionate about the game and encouraging him as a pro, but Mydei's eye has the urge to twitch.
>
> *Ah*. He can't let this slide now, can he?

Alternatively: Phainon is a popular streamer. Mydei enjoys video games. Castorice accidentally plays wingwoman by introducing them.

Notes

(EDIT: some people were having trouble seeing the images attached in the fic [that are chats inbetween characters so kind of important to the plot] due to country restrictions. these teeny bumps do ick me so beneath the images i added the textual transcription so everyone can see it...

▶ like this:

thanks to those that pointed it out!)

okay so THAT just happened

when i started writing this i did not, for a second, think i'd surpass 40k. but shit happens. phaidei took over my life and this is not a joke. though yes this did take me several weeks to write because i've been busy with stuff and all that BUT I PERSISTED!! ok now to the important stuff:

> first, i'm going to highly advice you to keep creator's style ON for the best experience !! it looks very clunky otherwise TT

> on the same note, kudos to cherrari for the amazing twitch chat skin. if u read this, you're a life saver!!! (BTW: the chat boxes are scrollable!)

> just as a disclaimer: i'm not a streamer nor a chef ... so please forgive me for any inaccuracies

> finally, a classic: i'm not a native english speaker. if u find any grammar mistake, please feel free to let me know! i'd highly appreciate it.

alright. enough yapping for now. i truly, TRULY hope u enjoy reading this as much as i did writing it <3

(no beta read. i checked as profusely as i could, but something might've escaped me (●´⌓`●) very sorry if that's the case)

See the end of the work for more notes

It started as nothing more than a silly hobby, really: Phainon enjoyed playing videogames as much as he did going to the gym in his free time. And as much as he too enjoyed his own solitude, sometimes it was almost unbearable to be idle in front of the bright computer screen, having nobody to share his unimportant yet spontaneous thoughts with. He was a restless man, after all, Cifera had said just before suggesting live streaming. Initially he just brushed it off, as his friend had said it with no intent other than jest, but really— would it be such a crazy thing to do?

And so, with little to ponder, he created an account on Genesis and set up all he needed on his desk to begin this new hobby of his: his customized home-built computer and a dusty old camera, courtesy of Castorice. Truthfully, it was nothing he did with much thought, or any expectations at all: but if he could talk at least one person's ear off and entertain them with it, then he'd be satisfied.

Surprising no one but himself, though, his undeniable charisma and easygoing personality was enough to win over the community, and at a relatively fast pace at that. Plus, he was indeed very good at the games he showed: his playthroughs were as smooth and educational as possible. He has hardly processed his sudden and growing sucess in the platform, but one thing he's sure of is that he's grown to love the interaction it provides and the support of his followers.

He starts downloading the game as he reads the incoming messages, wearing a natural grin on his face.

@DeliveringDawn

CastoMiss: Please remember the rules, everyone! Spoilers get you a week ban.

whimsicalthief: thats a little excessive ... don't u guys agree w me?

| In reply to @whimsicalthief: thats a little exc...
StreamServices: You have been timed out for 60 seconds.

King_Bartholos: deserved

🛏️ thetwilightsky: just joining! what are we doing today?



whimsicalthief: just some abuse of power it seems



CastoMiss: Please stop un-banning yourself. It makes me uneasy.

Send a message Chat

Phainon does not attempt to bite down a chuckle. He shakes his head. "Well, everyone, you know Castorice! Please be mindful of the rules," he says, in a more serious voice. "Now, for the new arrivals, today we are trying a new game called *The Garden of Life*. In case you don't know about it, it's a decision-based game set in a dystopical world. I've managed to dodge content related to it, so I'm really asking you all from the bottom of my heart not to ruin this experience for me and everybody else in chat!" He puts his palms together in plea to emphasize his message, and the chat floods with thumbs up emojis. He smiles pleased. "Also, I know this doesn't

really fit in my usual content, but I've been meaning to try it out with you guys since it was announced. I hope you understand."

@DeliveringDawn

whimsicalthief: dont be cute. you own the place

| In reply to @whimsicalthief: dont be cute...
CastoMiss: She's right. Unfortunately.

caeluswasHere: phainon sweetheart you could be streaming pou and id still be seated

stellewasHere: what he said we love you bbg

thetwilightsky: just enjoy yourself, phainon! i'm sure we'll have fun either way :)

Send a message Chat

Phainon relaxes his shoulders as more comments of the same nature go through his chatbox, letting out a gentle laugh. "Alright, alright. Just giving a heads up in case it's not everyone's cup of tea. Now, without further ado, how about we actually play the thing?"

With that, Phainon sinks into the rythm he's now so used to. He casually talks with his chat about everything and anything, but mostly comments over the gameplay as the story begins unfolding. As the trailers had promised, it's incredibly interactive and immersive, forcing him to quiet down after a bit to focus on the premise. Despite him being less chirpy than usual, his viewers seem to enjoy it altogether: they themselves comment on the gameplay, giving Phainon subtle pointers or just answering to rethoric questions he muses out loud. Either way, it makes it easy for a calm atmosphere to settle in, unlike the high-tension rush whenever he plays a particularly hard horror game.

After about two hours of non-stop playthrough, he decides to call a break. He quietly drinks water out of his bottle, eyeing the incoming messages. It's

mostly the usual friendly bickering that comes with discussing certain aspects of the game. His eyes slide towards the *Amphorean Chronicles* poster hanging on his wall, and he sighs, returning his gaze to the screen.

He points a finger to the poster, as if his viewers could see it. "Do you all know I'm a huge *Amphorean Chronicles* fanatic? Like, since I was nine. I used to participate in tournaments, before college sucked my time away."

The chat quickly ceases the debate about wether he should've let the thief get away or not, replaced by various messages related to his comment just now.

@DeliveringDawn

CastoMiss: Oh, he's not lying. I can testify.

whimsicalthief: i remember when some dude wanted to beat ur ass bc u stole his no.1 spot in the championship LOL

333threebbios: what game is that????

| In reply to @333threebbios: what game is...
King_Bartholos: are u ten years old

333threebbios: 12

stellewasHere: whose kid is this

caeluswasHere: i was also born yesterday what is that

thetwilightsky: i'm afraid i don't know that game either...



Send a message Chat

Phainon opens his eyes very widely when all the incoming messages let him know that the majority of his viewers do, in fact, *not* know what he's talking about.

"Come on, are you serious? I'm not that old, guys! *Amphorean Chronicles*, the most competitive fighting game ever?" When the chat just fills up with confused emojis, he audibly gasps. "Oh my god. You all do not know what you're missing. It's like, the best game ever created, I'm so serious. Man, this is why I've been meaning to bring it to you guys, but I've yet to find somebody willing to stream it with me! And, well, you all know I'm really not too keen on random matchmaking." He lets out a defeated sigh, shaking

his head, as if this is truly the worst thing possible. "It's been a while since I've had a worthy opponent."

@DeliveringDawn

stellewasHere: im a pro at any game i touch. i challenge you

rosycelestialmaiden: please do not indulge her

caeluswasHere: right indulge me instead

vidyadharatouch: please do not indulge him

CastoMiss: No one shall be indulged.

CastoMiss: Although, now that I think about it, I have a friend that's also a big fan. Not sure if on the same level, though.

Send a message Chat

Phainon raises a curious brow at Castorice's comment that catches his eye before it's drowned out by others. "Is that so? How come you've never mentioned it?"

Her response is immediate. Really, Phainon has no idea how she types so fast.

@DeliveringDawn

CastoMiss: I just remembered it, when you brought it up.

CastoMiss: He's also participated in some championships, If I'm not mistaken.

CastoMiss: Maybe I could convince him. He rarely backs down from a challenge, even for silly stuff like this.

CastoMiss:



whimsicalthief:



thetwilightsky:



Send a message Chat

He hums, giving the camera the biggest smile he can manage. "That sounds like good news to me. The ever life saver Castorice is at it again, it would seem." She sends a smug emote, and Phainon lets out a giggle. "Well, I wouldn't wanna bore you talking about a game you don't know... yet." He wiggles his eyebrows, earning various reactions from his viewers. "Alright, enough messing around. Back to gaming."

Castorice
Writing as we speak

Phainon
cas

Phainon
cas

Phainon
cas


Castorice
Do I even want to know?

Phainon
thank u for the help with the stream, again!

Phainon
best mod ever, love u


Castorice
I assume this is now the part where you ask me about the friend I mentioned.

Phainon
yes

Phainon
but i mean it


Castorice
Well, I love you too.


Castorice
I can't make guarantees, though. I'm not sure he'll be willing to stream.

Phainon
don't worry about it! just let me know when he gives u an answer


Castorice
Sure.

Castorice

Writing as we speak



Castorice

If you're up for it, I'll give you his contact.



Castorice

What do you think?

Mydei



It's an interesting proposal, I guess.

Mydei



It's been ages since I've had a good match.



Castorice

Haha. He said the same thing.



Castorice

I believe you should give it some thought.

Mydei



I will.

Mydei



What's his genesis account?



Castorice

@DeliveringDawn



Castorice

Will you check it out?

Mydei



Naturally. You got me with the competition.



Castorice

I know I did.

▶

Mydei stares down at his phone and snorts, turning it off and instead shifting his attention to his old laptop. Castorice's proposal came out of nowhere: they don't use to text much, after all, unless it's for a serious matter. So picture his surprise when he got a message for something as trivial as a play date she wanted to invite him to in someone else's behalf. Well, maybe *play date* isn't the right term: more like a showdown between two competitive players of the most unknown videogame ever created (her words, not his). Not that he could deny it: unless you ask an old man from an asylum, not many people will answer positively when asked if they know what *Amphorean Chronicles* is.

Doesn't mean it isn't the best fighting game there is, at least in Mydei's eyes. He tried out its most primitive version in a rusty arcade, and fell in love with it right away. Unfortunately, he never really got the chance to enjoy its competitive and strategic factor— even the championships against veteran players felt all too easy.

So, naturally, when Castorice presented him the opportunity eleven year old Mydeimos would've sold all his stuff for —he was a disturbed kid, now that he thinks about it—, something urged him to go along. It could very well have been his inner child or his prideful ass refusing to deny competition.

He decides that the reason is of little relevance as he opens the Genesis site and browses for the account Castorice has so kindly provided, and his brows soon go up in surprise upon noting that his subscribers well surpass the million. It's a relatively small amount considering there's people on the site that average the ten million, but still. It hadn't crossed his mind that the guy might actually be a little famous.

It's odd, because Mydei does not recall having heard or seen of him— then again, he isn't the most knowledgeable man when it comes to stuff as such. He stops trying to search in his brain for any type of recollection once he opens his profile picture: Mydei hates that the first thing he thinks is that he

is kind of handsome. Like, *very* handsome. So, objectively speaking, if he had seen a face like that before, he probably would still remember it.

He chooses not to dwell on the funny feeling of his belly and instead decides to scroll through his archived streams. He doesn't have to go too far to learn about Phainon's —that's the name Castorice has given to him— style: most of his streams consist of playthroughs of mostly action and fighting games, some horror games and a bit of simulators. As expected, probably. Mydei scrolls all the way back up and plugs in his headphones as he clicks on the most recent one: according to the page, it was recorded as of today.

The video takes a few seconds to load before Mydei is greeted by the same face that was smiling brightly on the account's profile, just that now his expression is a bit more casual, albeit still smiling. Must be his default resting face, he concludes, suddenly very much aware of his own scowl. The guy quickly accommodates the camera before finally greeting his viewers:

"Good evening, guys! Or morning. Or night. For me it's evening still," he says, letting out a soft giggle. Mydei sighs, in a non dreamy way. "I hope you're all set with your snacks and dogs, because today we're down for a long playthrough. As some of you might know, I'm going to be testing a new game with you. Ah, yes, and if you're new, welcome! And please do remember to check the rules." Mydei feels called out. He does not check the rules, instead moving his cursor down to the progress bar and skips near the end of the recording, precisely to the third hour.

Phainon seems to have quieted down, if the way his shoulders are slightly slumped are anything to go by, but he's still as talkative. He doesn't say anything Mydei understands, as it's probably about the game, but he still observes with some attention the behavior of his viewers: though there's plenty of messages going through the chatbox, they seem to be a relatively nice community. Not that he particularly cares, but he does feel a little bit more assured knowing that they'll *probably* not bite his head off.

He's already made up his mind. Not that there was much to think about, really: Castorice is incredibly perceptive despite what others might think,

and if she deemed that extending him the invitation was a good enough idea, then he trusts her judgment. Plus, he was not about to turn down a challenge that was already laid on the table. No way.

Mydei is about to close the video when Phainon speaks up after being silent for a while:

"I can guarantee that you're all going to enjoy *Amphorean Chronicles* as much as I do! I can't believe so many of you guys don't know the game, but I'll make sure you get the full grasp of it. Nobody beats me when it comes to it, after all," he says, winking to the camera.

His viewers just leave appreciative comments saying how cute it is for him to be so passionate about the game and encouraging him as a pro, but Mydei's eye has the urge to twitch.

Ah. He can't let this slide now, can he?

He hurries to shut down his laptop, lest it overheats, and opens his chat with Castorice.

Castorice

Writing as we speak



Castorice

I know I did.

Mydei

Deal



Mydei

Give me his contact, please





Castorice

My, that was quick.



Castorice

Are you always this easy to sway?

Mydei

Just if my pride is somewhat on the line.



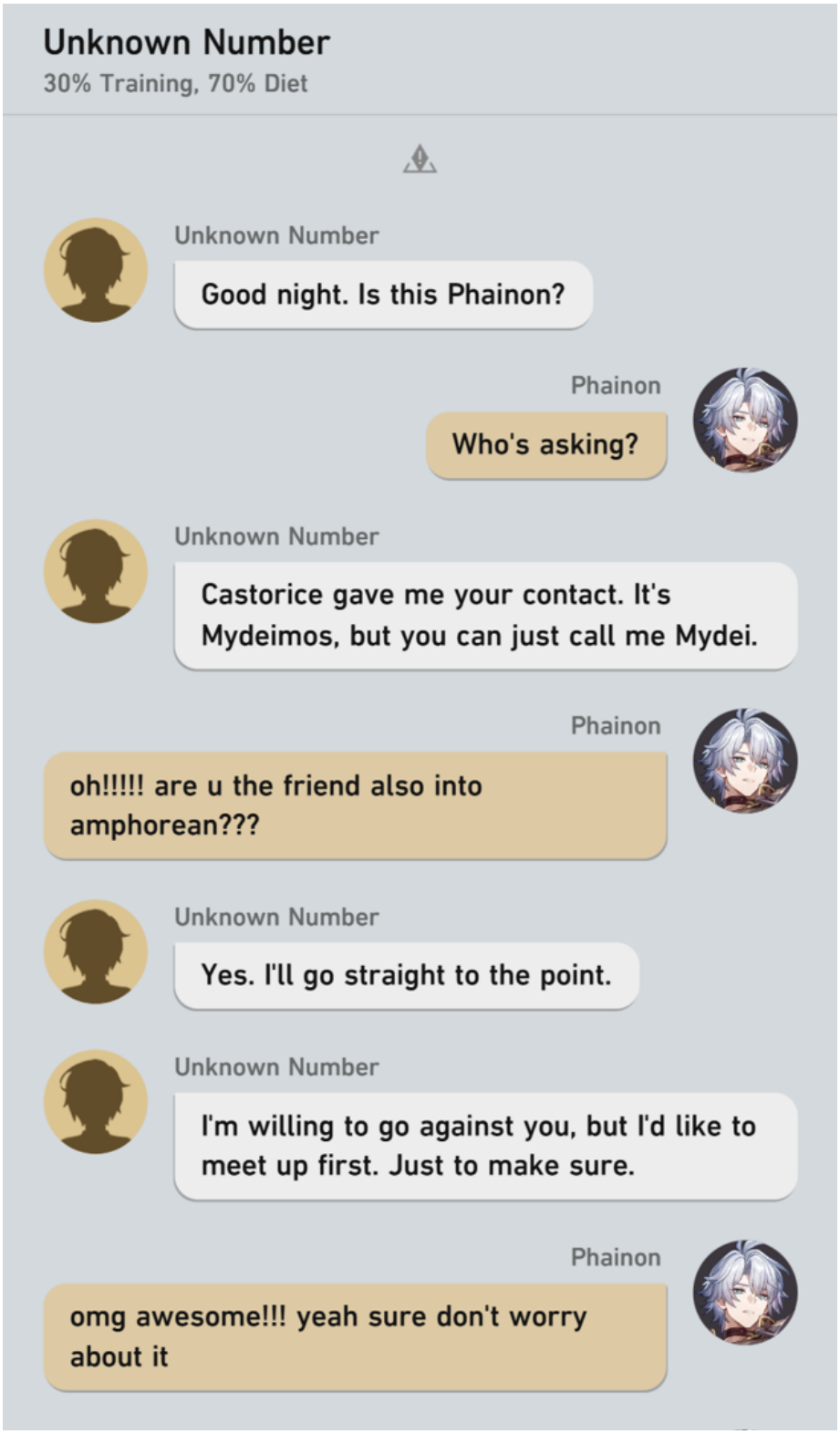


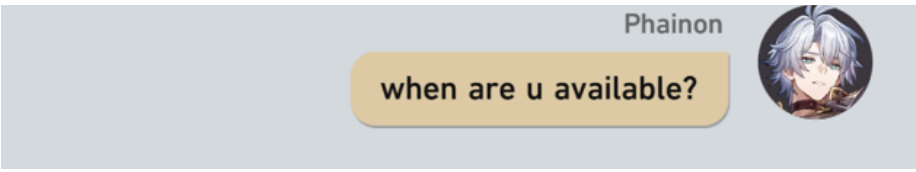
Castorice

Haha, I see. I'll keep that in mind. Here you go.

[Castorice attached a contact]

▶


Unknown Number
30% Training, 70% Diet
Unknown Number
Good night. Is this Phainon?
Phainon
Who's asking?
Unknown Number
Castorice gave me your contact. It's Mydeimos, but you can just call me Mydei.
Phainon
oh!!!!! are u the friend also into amphorean???
Unknown Number
Yes. I'll go straight to the point.
Unknown Number
I'm willing to go against you, but I'd like to meet up first. Just to make sure.
Phainon
omg awesome!!! yeah sure don't worry about it



▶

Phainon does a double check to make sure he's indeed at the right location. He also checks the time for good measure, although it's impossible for him to have messed that up. He sighs with relief when everything seems to be in order, and checks himself on his phone's camera if only out of instinct to know he looks at least presentable.

After discussing it with Mydeimos —Mydei, he repeats to himself—, they agreed on meeting up in a quiet coffee shop near the city downtown. Mydei had said it was small and not really frequented, therefore making it a good place to talk. In any other situation Phainon would've had his doubts, but if Castorice trusted the guy, he trusted him too. Still, Phainon has been a bit of a nervous wreck since he awoke. Alas, he can't help it: he always gets a little anxious before meeting new people, afraid he won't make a good impression. Plus, this guy is a potential special guest on his channel, so he wants to make an extra good impression. That, and the fact that Castorice didn't said much at all besides the fact that he can be hot headed sometimes.

So, yeah.

He forces himself to ease his gut with one deep breath before he steps inside the shop, the bell on top of the door loudly announcing his presence. Behind the front desk is a man, probably in his thirties or so, and speaking to him is another. Phainon immediately guesses that must be Mydei, if the dawn-colored hair serves as a clue. That's the only pointer Castorice provided. He gives a little wave to the one he presumes is the shop owner, and just as he's about to speak, Mydei turns around.

And, *oh*, this is the most beautiful man Phainon has ever laid eyes on.

He feels stunned for a fraction of second before he reminds himself to keep his composure. But, truly, he's not exaggerating in the slightest— amber

eyes with a feline touch, delicate yet sharp features and, God, are those tattoos adorning his *very* prominent muscles? Phainon feels his mouth go dry and a funny tug on his abdomen when his eyes get caught up in the slight contraction of his biceps when he folds his arms underneath his also *very* prominent chest.

Phainon hurries to drag his eyes up in embarrassment, but he soon catches that he is oggling him as well. Mydei tears his gaze away from Phainon's toned legs —he wasn't judging him for the shorts, was he?— just in time to meet his.

"You're jacked," is all he says, voice rough and so pleasant. "Phainon, right?"

He nods, clearing his throat in a pointless attempt of looking casual. "Yep, that's me. You are, uh, also jacked, thank you. I guess Castorice forgot to mention that we could be gym buddies." He lets out a giggle that hopefully comes off as friendly and not creepy.

Mydei seems unimpressed. "I guess she did."

The shop owner shifts his gaze between the two of them, sensing the awkwardness. He quickly comes to Phainon's rescue. "You're a new customer, I believe?" The question is directed to Phainon. He nods with gratitude in his eyes, and the man gives him a tiny smile. "Welcome, then. I'm Kyros. I presume you're already acquaintanced with Mydeimos."

"Yeah, something like that," he responds, avoiding Mydei's gaze.

"Very well! I hope to see you become a regular, too." Kyros winks at him, and he returns a smile. "Alright, boys, go sit down. Menu is at the table. Just call me when you're ready to order."

"Thank you, Kyros." Mydei barely spares a glance at Phainon before walking towards one of the tables away from the window. This is maybe going to be a little harder than he thought, but he keeps calm: he's charming enough. He knows that at least.

He takes a seat in front of Mydei and flashes his best smile. "Sorry about the awkwardness. I tend to get a little bit nervous when meeting new people."

Mydei seems taken aback, but his expression softens a little. "Is that so? You don't look like it."

"I know it's kind of ironic, but really. I care about first impressions a lot." When he only raises a questioning brow, Phainon decides to change the topic. "Anyways, that's irrelevant. Castorice explained the idea to you, right?"

"She wasn't too specific, but yes."

"Alright. She did mention the live streaming part, yes?" Mydei nods and Phainon smiles wider. "Ah, great. You have no problem with that? I'll make any accommodation you need. If you're not comfortable showing your face, we can—"

Mydei cuts him off with a scoff. "Though it's considerate of you, there's no need for any of that. I want people to see the face that's going to beat your ass."

Phainon's mouth opens in surprise, and then he lets out a genuine laugh. "My, you do talk big for someone that has yet to test my hand. Are you sure you're not getting ahead of yourself?"

"Not at all, *Deliverer*." Phainon raises a brow at the nickname. Mydei pays him no mind. "I'm as confident in my abilities as you apparently are in yours."

Mydei is grinning, which unfortunately does make a pretty sight. Infuriatingly so. Phainon leans over the small table, closer to Mydei, and shoots him an equally confident smirk. "I'm yet to see if yours are up to par, though."

His now nemesis squints his eyes, and he's about to retort when someone clears their throat by their side, shattering whatever bubble had formed

around them.

"Ready to order, gentlemen?" Kyros gives them both a patient, knowing smile.

Phainon feels very self conscious all of the sudden and he straightens his back. "Oh, uhm, one lactose free latte for me, please."

"I'll have the usual. Thank you," comes Mydei's now softer and polite voice.

Kyros nods and quietly walks away. Then Mydei's defiant eyes are back on his, now glinting in amusement. Oh, Phainon knows what's coming. He braces himself.

"I win this one. My system can perfectly digest lactose," he mocks, in a tone so serious it makes Phainon wonder if he's joking or not.

Still, he scowls as his face flushes slightly. "That's unfair! I can't control my bowel, genius." Mydei laughs short and low, but it's enough to brush Phainon's pride. "What is it? Are you so sure you'll lose you're trying to seize a petty victory?"

To that, Mydei folds his arms, and Phainon forces his eyes to stay on his face. "No way. You're just delusional."

Phainon chuckles softly. "Alright, alright. Seriously. You have no problem with the arrangement, then?"

Mydei shakes his head. "No. Are you okay with it, though?"

"Why wouldn't I be? I'm looking forward to it like crazy. Plus, I'm the one inviting you."

"Well, it's your space. I wouldn't want to overstep," he explains, and he sounds genuine enough for Phainon to soften his own smile.

"Don't worry about it. All I'm going to ask is for you not to reveal any type of personal information and to not fight with the viewers. People can get crazy, but it's better to ignore them, really."

Mydei nods. "That goes unsaid. Rest assured."

When he doesn't say anything else for the following seconds, Phainon starts digging in his head for conversation topics, but Kyros comes to rescue the situation once again with their drinks.

Something tells him it's a planned intervention. Not that he's about to complain.

They thank him and quietly drink their beverages, accompanied by some courtesy cookies. Phainon observes Mydei's glass and decided that a minute of silence has been enough. Mydei seems to think otherwise, the indicative being the look he gives him when he opens his mouth.

"So, what did you order?" he asks, resting his chin on his palm.

"Pomegranate juice with added milk," he answers plainly, taking a long sip.

"Sweet. Can I try?"

Mydei pauses and looks at him like he just grew a third head. He tilts his head, confused, which makes Mydei sigh. "I didn't mention I'm Kremnoan, right?"

Phainon's eyes widen. "Oh. I'm sorry. Was that rude?"

"No, not rude. Just odd. But don't sweat it. I don't expect a local to be familiar with our traditions anyway," he answers, waving it off. Phainon keeps looking at him with curious eyes, though, and Mydei takes a deep breath. "In Kremnos, we save drinking from the same glass for special occasions. Commemorating an alliance, for example. It's an intimate gesture."

Phainon nods slowly. "I had no idea. Sorry."

"I said it's fine. They are really old traditions anyway. I'm not even sure if people respect them as of today."

"Still. Kremnos is a very beautiful city. And I'm not a local, by the way," he corrects, feeling his chest swell with nostalgia like it always does when he talks about his hometown. Mydei raises a curious brow. "I mean, I doubt you know the place, but I'm from Aedes Elysiae. It's a rural town about three hours from Okhema."

Mydei squints his eyes and then opens them just as fast, as if he had an idea. "Ah. The one with the wheat fields?"

Phainon smiles wide. "Yeah, that one! Man, everytime I mention it, nobody knows what I'm talking about," he says, shaking his head.

"I used to be really into geography when I was a kid, is all," Mydei mumbles, looking away. If Phainon knew any better, he'd notice the subtle flush on the tip of his ears.

"That explains. I was the math obsessed kid myself."

Mydei hums. "Thirteen times fifteen?"

"Easy, one hundred ninety-five." He takes in Mydei's surprised expression and smiles in amusement. "Was that the hardest one you could think of?"

"Spare me. I was never good at math."

Phainon decides not to tease him lest he risks being asked something outside his area of expertise. They fall back again into a comfortable silence, the only noise being the occasional clatter of stuff in the kitchen and the background jazz coming from the small speakers. Mydei wasn't lying when he said it wasn't too frequented. That's fine, though. The place has its charm.

Once they finish, they quickly split the bill and drop a generous tip by the front desk, waving goodbye to Kyros. The man responds in kind and reminds them to visit again.

When they step outside, the sun still shines bright, and the air carries with a gentle yet cold wind. Phainon appreciates the breeze. Mydei scrunches up

his nose when the sunlight hits him straight into the eye, and Phainon bites down a childish giggle.

"So, Mydei," he starts, fully turning around to properly face him. "Does this saturday work for you? Around four in the afternoon."

He thinks for a moment, ultimately deciding he has no plans at all. "Sure. Just send me the location and I'll be there."

Phainon gives him a thumbs up. "Great! You're not as hard to talk to as I thought."

Mydei frowns. "What's that supposed to mean?"

"You give off a totally intimidating vibe, that's all," he says, raising his hands as surrender as Mydei's frown deepens. "Anyway, better get going before it gets too late. Goodbye, Mydeimos! I'll send you the details once I get home. Be safe!"

"You too. I'll see you around," says Mydei with a sigh, as he turns around and begins walking away.

Phainon does the same, but before he can manage too many steps for it to be considered a lengthy distance—

"Hey, Deliverer."

He whips his head around, his eyes meeting with Mydei's. The latter smirks.

"I'm also looking forward to it."

Castorice

Writing as we speak

Phainon



ur friend is interesting



Castorice

In a good way, I hope?

Phainon



haha yes ofc

Phainon



we're doing it this saturday

Phainon



i'm trusting your banning abilities!!!



Castorice

I'm glad to hear that. And yes, rest assured.



Castorice

I'll make sure things go well.

Castorice

Writing as we speak

Mydei



Your friend is weird.



Castorice

He is, and so are you. Everything went okay, then?

Mydei



Yeah. He's not what I had in mind, but we got along just fine, I think.

Mydei



We'll do it saturday. Will you be there?



Castorice

Of course. I'll be rooting for both your downfalls.

Mydei



Why, thank you. How kind of you.

▶

Mydei runs a nervous hand through his damp hair, praying to the gods above that once it dries out it doesn't end up looking like a lion's mane, as always. *Not today*, he pleads. Perhaps going to the gym just a few hours before his meeting with Phainon was not the brightest idea, but could he be blamed? No better way to calm his system when feeling anxious. Not to be mistaken, though— his nerves are far from being the bad, nausea inducing ones, but rather exciting and thrilling that always make his belly flutter in the best way possible. Should his teacher see him now, he would with no doubt reprimend him for his childishness, but he's way past that.

He needs to wipe that infuriating, confident smirk off Phainon's face.

When the elevator finally opens up, he hurries inside and presses down the button with the number twelve engraved on it. Mydei looks at his reflection in the mirror and grimaces at the sight of his hair— it resembles wet car fur. Not that he can do anything about it now. His eyes trail down and he flexes his arm in autopilot, satisfied with the way the shirt clings to the muscle. That really hadn't been an intentional pick: he was only aiming for a casual look, going with a short sleeved red shirt and a pair of jeans. But then again, he *had* bought all his shirts a size smaller so it would accentuate his physique.

He just hopes not to come across bold. He's heard enough of Hephaestion's teasing for a lifetime.

Once he makes sure that the elevator did stop at the right floor, he wastes no time striding out and looking for the apartment number Phainon told him. It's a really nice building, really, and if he wasn't running a bit late he'd stop to admire the spotless marble floor and neatly painted walls. He stops that train of thought as his legs settle in front of the door with a fancy plate on the side, the number 496 carved into it. He pulls his phone to verify one last time before he finally rings the doorbell, giving a step back.

He waits for no more than two seconds before the door swings open, revealing Phainon's expectant face. It quickly turns into a grin as his eyes meet Mydei's.

"Mydei, hi! I'm so glad you finally made it," he says, stepping aside. "Please come in."

He does just as told, shoulders stiff. "Thank you. And sorry for the tardiness. Transport got stuck in some traffic."

Phainon laughs it off, closing the door shut with a click. "Hey, don't worry! There's no pressure. Plus, it's only been, what, ten minutes?"

"Still. I don't like making people wait." He shifts his weight between his legs uncomfortably, his eyes quickly taking in the sight. He can't help but feel a little out of place, but that's just because he's such a homebody. He can never really get too accustomed to a home that isn't his.

Phainon seems to sense his unease, for he gently drops a hand of his shoulder. "Make yourself comfortable. I bought snacks, so feel free to grab something from the kitchen. I'll be in my room setting everything up. First one on the left."

He frowns slightly, turning to meet his gaze. "Are you sure you're fine with that?"

"Of course. Go ahead, I mean it," Phainon insists, moving his hand away. "I swear I don't bite." And to that, he winks. Mydei cringes, but he finds himself relaxing a little either way.

Phainon gives him one final look before disappearing into his bedroom. Mydei's eyes linger on the spot for a moment before his stomach surprises him with a subtle growl, stealing a defeated sigh out of him. He decides that Phainon's offer is not too bad after all. He makes his way towards the kitchen, a very stylish open concept if he says so himself, and tentatively opens the fridge, feeling like an intruder more than a guest.

He shakes his head, pushing that thought away. Phainon said it was fine.

As he scans the contents, Mydei notes with amusement that at least three quarters of it consist of protein supplements, the same brand he uses, with just the quarter left being occupied by actual ingredients. Mydei guesses he must not cook for shit. He takes a bag of beef jerky, and just as he grabs a canned soda, his eyes get caught in a brand new package of pomegranate juice, perfectly stored in a corner. He puts the soda back immediately, reaching for one of the juice boxes like your average college student reaches for a beer. Just great.

He makes sure to properly close the fridge before mimicking Phainon's steps, taking only a quick peek inside the room before walking in. The lights are dimmed out, most illumination coming from the blue leds set on the desk and the computer itself. Phainon is idly scrolling through his phone, lifting his gaze only just as he hears his footsteps. When his eyes fall on the juice, his expression brightens impossibly more.

"Ah, great, you found them. I went for some quick grocery shopping this morning, and I couldn't help buying some of those when I saw them. I know it's not exactly what you drink, but good enough, right?" he says, all to fast for Mydei to catch all of it. But.

"You bought these for me?" he asks stupidly, even though Phainon already pretty much said so.

"Yeah! You were really enjoying yourself the other day, at the coffee shop, so I made a mental note about it. Is that alright? You don't have to—"

"No, I mean, it's more than fine," Mydei hurries to say. He sits next to Phainon, on the rather comfy chair he set for him. "It just surprised me, that's all."

"Oh, don't be. You're doing me a big favor here," he responds.

"You think I'm doing you a favor," Mydei grunts, more as an affirmation than a question. "You'll stop believing that when you start losing."

Something flickers in Phainon's azure eyes, and he just shoots a crooked smile. "We'll see about that. I'm ready to roll as soon as you are."

Mydei slides his gaze towards the chatbox, where people are already leaving many, *many* messages as they wait for the livestream to begin. He's never been too keen on cameras, and yet despite the fact he should be feeling at least a little nervous, he feels nothing but his pleasant and steady heartbeat.

"Do your thing, Deliverer," is all he answers.

Phainon needs no other cue to click the start button. He stays silent during the first couple of seconds it takes for the recording to begin, but once it does, it's like a switch has been flipped— he beams when seeing their faces on the screen, and Mydei can swear he sees the energy radiating from him. He stifles a laugh, if only to be polite.

"Hello, you all!" Phainon waves enthusiastically, and Mydei notes the way his viewers answer pretty much in the same manner, flooding the chatbox with various stickers and emojis. The flow is so fast, though, that he can barely catch what any of them say. He doesn't understand how Phainon does. "Well, as you can see already, I have a pretty special guest with me here! Say hi, everyone."

Mydei gives a little wave to the camera, deciding to leave the talking to Phainon.

Phainon disagrees. He elbows him, teasing smile. "Come on, introduce yourself. Don't tell me you're shy?"

He scowls at him, elbowing back. "Of course not." He schools his face once again as he looks at the camera. "Hi. It's Mydei. Nice to... meet you all," he mumbles, side eyeing Phainon.

"*I'm incredibly happy to be here! So glad for this opportunity, Phainon is the best. He's going to sweep the floor with me*!" Comes Phainon's voice, in a forced and exaggerated low voice. Mydei merely rolls his eyes, deciding not to indulge him.

@DeliveringDawn

caeluswasHere: oh he's a PRETTY special guest alright i see that

stellewasHere: woah ever see a man so beautiful u wanna cry

CastoMiss: Hello, Mydei. Happy to see you here.

whimsicalthief: myyyy ... im definitely rooting for you, new guy



vidyadharatouch: what are we doing today?

| In reply to @vidyadharatouch: what are we...
caeluswasHere: L+ratio read the captions

Send a message Chat

Phainon lets out a hearty laugh as he scans the chat. Mydei can't catch any of it.

"Alright, I can't have you liking my rival more than me, so I'm going to conveniently change the topic" he says, and Mydei can't help but feel a little smug. Phainon then grabs one of the two controllers plugged to the computer and shows it to the camera. "You may remember what I mentioned last stream about *Amphorean Chronicles*, yes? Well, Castorice delivered! As she always does. Everybody thank Cas, now."

The chatbox fills with thank you messages directed to Castorice, and Mydei allows himself to smile at that. Phainon has trained them well, apparently, unlike other communities he has seen. People can be *really* mean, he knows that alright. But it's hard to imagine that someone like Phainon could breed an evil army of minions. He's too nice for that.

"Now, I don't think you can imagine my excitement, but I do hope I can transmit it to you. Let's just hope Mydei isn't all bark no bite, eh? No pressure, of course," he pats his shoulder in mock sympathy, to which he chuckles in amusement.

"*You* bark too much. Just start the game, Deliverer," he retorts, grabbing the other controller.

"My, don't be so rude, Mydei. We have to give our viewers a proper welcome, don't we?" Mydei tries to communicate his sentiment with an unimpressed look, and Phainon laughs. Mydei is slowly starting to get used to that sound. "But, yes, he's right. I'm going to start the game now. I'll give you all a thorough explanation of the basics so you don't get lost."

@DeliveringDawn

 reavingflames: damn phainon got that sass

neikoslove: why do i feel like im interrupting something here



King_Bartholos: do they rlly not know each other..?

CastoMiss: They do now, but they truly did not until I sort of introduced them.

whimsicalthief: thats how chemistry works, little bartholos!

| In reply to @whimsicalthief: thats how chem...
StreamServices: You have been timed out for 60 seconds.

CastoMiss: Cifera.

whimsicalthief: finally got on ur nerves?



Send a message Chat

Mydei squints his eyes. "How can you read their messages so fast, Deliverer? I'm finding it quite difficult."

"Well, it's always a hard task in the beggining, but you do end up getting used to it, believe me," he offers, picking the *free fight* option in the menu. "Alright, guys, so. This game has the following mechanic: before you can cast any form of ability, you have to get a determined amount of points. These points can only be achieved through perfect combos of regular attacks, which are different for each character. Also, each character can choose certain personalized buffs from a rooster. These buffs serve as the base of your strategy, for they can completely change the playstyle."

"The number of different combinations you can experiment with is vast," says Mydei, nodding appreciatively.

"Precisely. There's a reason behind my fanatism, after all," Phainon follows, smiling almost timidly. "Tell me, Mydei. Do you believe a five-minute round is enough to beat me?"

Mydei scoffs. "Certainly not enough to beat *me*. Make it fifteen."

"So confident. But I agree." Phainon does as told, leaving all the other settings untouched. The game goes straight to the character selection, and Phainon picks Kephale as fast as one can blink. "This one is my main. Best character ever."

"Not when Nikador exists."

Phainon quirks a brow. "Really? Last time I checked, all Nikador has is good base damage. They're really unbalanced."

"So they say. But that's because people don't know how to use them. You'll see." Mydei's confidence only grows by the second, and Phainon seems to sense as much. He shakes his head.

"As you wish. Now, before the match starts, we need to build our characters. It's pretty simple, but it's a real game changer, similar to the buffs. I assume you already have something in mind, Mydei?"

"Of course." He quickly picks his signature build as if to prove his point.

Phainon does the same, messing around with the various resonances available. "This is a little tricky to explain because it totally depends on the player and their prefered playstyle, but I'm going with a regular build. Mydei here seems to be more inclined to the preservation aspect. Smart."

Mydei sighs. "Less talking, more doing, Deliverer. By the time we actually start playing, Kephale will long have stepped down the ranks."

To that, Phainon giggles. "Right. As if that would ever happen."

Still, he quickly selects the basic arena and the match finally starts. They both lean forwards, eyes glued on the screen and suddenly very quiet.

Mydei never thinks his matches much— he acts, decisive and relentless. His character immediately pounces towards Phainon's, all his hits landing perfectly and granting him enough points to cast a shield just as Phainon releases his counter, the sneaky little shit. Both their health bars decrease by the same amount, and so do their scowls deepen. Mydei's Nikador jumps back just in time to dodge Kephale's quick succession of attacks. He smiles, aware of his upper hand.

But then Phainon finally takes advantage of Kephale's passive and successfully stuns Nikador. Mydei grunts as his character gets beat up, finally granting Phainon some points. Whatever. He frees himself before Phainon can launch his comet, and hurries to deliver a combo of his own. But he can't even begin casting his lance when Phainon summons his shield, best one in the damn game. He curses under his breath.

The match continues at the same rythm, none being able to unleash a damaging ability without the other countering it: by the ten-minute mark their health bars have barely decreased an inch, with neither of them having enough points to at least defend themselves. Their characters dance all across the screen trying to deliver punches, and they fail spectacularly.

They are both tightly gripping the controllers when the timer reaches zero, rendering their characters idle.

@DeliveringDawn

 PhaiBot: FIRST ROUND— zero to zero.

stellewasHere: that was so lame im crying

CastoMiss: I can feel both their egos hurting.

King_Bartholos: it cant be THAT hard cmon

whimsicalthief: streamer delivering dawn delivers NOTHING

| In reply to @whimsicalthief: streamer del...
StreamServices: You have been timed out for 60 seconds.

Send a message Chat

For the first time, Phainon doesn't even glance the chatbox. He sets his eyes on Mydei instead. "Another?"

"How dare you even ask."

Second round goes as expected: the same.

Third round: story repeats itself.

Fourth round: change in strategy. Phainon switches to Zagreus. But the result is the same.

Fifth round: Mydei tries out Thanatos. It does not work.

"Fuck, man," Phainon groans when the sixth round ends, still no winner. "We're too good at this."

Mydei runs a hand through his hair. It's completely dry by now. Spongy, even. "Agreed. How long we've been at this anyway?"

Phainon checks the stream's timer. "Over an hour and a half."

"Damn. And are they not bored?" He frowns, gesturing to the chatbox.

Phainon hums and quickly scans the upcoming messages: if anything, they all seem pretty thrilled to see who ends up winning after so many ties. "They are not. Are you?"

"No, of course not. It's been a while since I've had this much fun," he admits, feeling a little bashful suddenly.

But Phainon lights up. "I can absolutely relate to that. I'm glad you're enjoying yourself too, Mydei."

"Sure." Mydei allows himself a tiny smile. He bites it down just as fast, though. "Now hurry up. I still need to beat you."

Phainon returns a smile three times wider.

Seventh round: a little improvement. They manage to get more points, at least.

Eighth round: they each go back to their initial picks, making slight adjustments to the builds. Same result.

Ninth round: they land a considerable amount of succesful combos, but still not much different.

And finally...

@DeliveringDawn

 PhaiBot: TENTH ROUND— zero to zero.

caeluswasHere: this is so unserious

thetwilightsky: that was intense



whimsicalthief: almost three hours of stream and no winner in sight... are they fr

CastoMiss: A surprising outcome.

PhaiBot:







Send a message Chat

Phainon leans back on his chair, letting out a defeated sigh. "It seems I overestimated myself."

Mydei mimics him, leaving his own controller over the desk. "So did I."

"But you were amazing, Mydei," Phainon says, turning his head to properly look at him. "I've never seen someone handle Nikador's clunky playstyle like you do."

"Well. They're my main since I was ten," he offers, shrugging. "You were not too bad yourself. You have some bite after all."

"Is that a compliment? I'll take it as a compliment." Phainon smiles smugly, much to Mydei's demise. "It's getting late, but... I think we should totally do this again, some other time. It was so exciting."

Mydei hums. "I'm not opposed to that idea."

Phainon's stare lingers on him just for an instant before he quickly draws his eyes back to the chatbox. "So, what do you guys think? I know this was a different stream and all, but I'm hoping you enjoyed it as much as we did. And that this convinces you to get the game. Seriously, you won't regret it."

The messages from his viewers all kind of differ regarding the game, but the one common factor is that they seem to like Mydei very much. Phainon rolls his eyes playfully.

"They all want you back, *prince*," he teases, and Mydei gives him a look. "Hey, their words, not mine. Listen to this one," he clears his throat, and when he speaks again, he does so in a dreamy voice: "*Mydei looks like the prince I used to picture when reading fairy tales. He's so handsome*". His voice now goes back to his usual deep edge. "What do you think?"

He snorts and shakes his head. "I think I'm far from it, but I'm nevertheless thankful to you all for having me."

"Duh. My community is the coolest." He says it like a proud father, Mydei notes. "But anyway. You will definitely be seeing my guy again. Anything else you want to say before we close up?"

"Stage's yours, Deliverer." He folds his arms, and does not miss the way Phainon's eyes follow the movement for a split second before looking back to the camera.

"Well. As always, thank you all so much for being here and watching the whole thing. I'm glad to resonate with you, or to at least serve as good background noise! Whatever reason, I hope to continue to cheer you up," Phainon says, making a heart with his fingers. "Remember to check my socials, if you want. I'm always posting stuff there. But anyway, I've taken enough time out of you. I'll see you next stream!"

The messages on the chatbox are pretty much just people saying their goodbyes and sending emotes, and Phainon reads some of them before ending the stream. He lets out a deep sigh, and turns his chair around. His gaze is soft, less intense, and Mydei feels seen through.

"Would you be up for this again?" Phainon breaks the silence, standing up.

Mydei does the same. "I don't see why not, as long as you have me."

"I'd love to. And, well, it doesn't always need to be for a stream. We can always just, you know, hang out and all."

That's an offering, Mydei knows. "Sure." There's a pause a moment too long for him to start feeling the awkwardness in the air. He starts to slowly walk backwards, gesturing towards the door. "I'll, uh, get going now."

Phainon flinches as if pulled out of a trance. He nods and quickly gets ahead, opening the door for him. "You could stay for dinner, maybe? I mean, you've barely eaten anything. I feel like a terrible host," he says, accompanied by a nervous laugh.

Out in the hallway, Mydei frowns at him. "Don't be dumb. We were both too entranced to even think of eating. I'm not really that hungry anyway." A lie. But he's perfectly capable of feeding himself once he gets home. "Besides, it's never been my plan to overwelcome my stay."

"Are you sure? I really don't mind." He sounds concerned. Mydei sighs.

"I'm certain, Deliverer. Stop worrying so much."

Phainon still looks unsure, but drops it. "Well... do you want me to at least walk you to the station?"

"I am not a child. I assure you I won't get lost."

"You know that's not what I meant," Phainon mutters with a roll of his eyes.

Mydei laughs short. "Alright then. Thanks again for the invitation and the good time."

"Likewise." He opens the front door carefully and steps aside. "Please do tell me when you get home," he adds once Mydei has walked a few steps away.

Mydei shakes his head, biting down a smile.

Castorice

Writing as we speak



Castorice

Did you enjoy yourself, Mydei?



Castorice

You two seemed very in the zone, so it was hard for me to tell if you were actually having fun or not.

Mydei



I did, very. Thanks for extending the invite to me in the first place.



Castorice

I'm glad to hear that. I was a bit worried that Phainon's energy would throw you off.



Castorice

I know he can be a bit much sometimes for us introverts, but he always means well.



Castorice

He's a great guy.

Mydei



I'm well aware of that, Castorice. Don't worry.



Castorice



Mydei
30% Training, 70% Diet

Phainon



hey mydei u got home?



Mydei

Yes. I was making myself some food, sorry I didn't let you know.

Phainon



so u WERE hungry after all



Mydei

Spare me. I prefer to eat at home.

Phainon



whatever u picky ass

Phainon



anyway i was thinking

Phainon



since we r both gym rats n stuff

Phainon



why don't we go together some of these days ??



Mydei

That would be interesting. For that I'm available any day.

Phainon



great!! there's a discount on tuesdays for single day passes at my gym so??



Mydei

Sure.

▶

"Hey, Chartonus!"

The man in question looks up from the computer, and smiles in acknowledgment.

"Phainon. You are early."

"Yeah, I'm meeting up with a friend today, so." He shrugs, and Chartonus nods in understanding. Phainon leans over the counter. "Remind me how much is it for a day pass?"

"Today, three thousand credits."

"Nice. He should be here anytime," Phainon says, checking his smartwatch. No soon as the words leave his mouth the automatic door slides open, and the blond mane he's waiting for walks through it. He immediately straightens, a grin settling on his face. "Speak of the devil. Hey, Mydei!"

He waves his hand around to catch his attention as if Mydei couldn't see him from outside. He sighs, but waves back.

"Deliverer. I didn't make you wait too long, did I?" he asks once he's stopped next to him, checking his cellphone with a frown.

"Not at all, I just got here too." Phainon gestures behind the counter. "This is Chartonus. He's the gym administrator and like, the chillest guy ever."

Mydei shifts his gaze and smiles politely in Chartonus' direction. "Good evening. Name's Mydeimos. Any special procedure I need to follow for the day pass?"

"Not at all, sir. I just need your finger here," Chartonus points to the fingerprint reader on the desk, "some personal data and the pay, which for today's special discount will be a total of three thousand. Is that alright?"

"Sure. Just give me a moment," says Mydei, pulling out his wallet.

Phainon takes in the sight of him while he waits: Mydei's usual messy hair is now pulled back in a neat ponytail, with his signature braid being the only strand free, which gives his face an even more alluring touch. There's not much to say about his running shorts and tank top, other than the fact that it leaves little to the imagination. Phainon notes with both awe and surprise that his red tattoos go all the way from his arms to his shoulder blades, and possibly lower. He wishes the cloth was see-through.

Wait, no.

"Did I grow a second face in my back, Deliverer?"

Phainon forcefully tears his eyes away when Mydei turns his whole body, looking at him strangely.

"I was just appreciating your tattoos. That's all." He feigns nonchalance. Mydei sees right through it, so he lets out a sheepish laugh. "Do... do they go all the way down your back? Just out of curiosity."

Mydei snorts. "Yeah. For the most part."

"Oh, that's. Cool. Badass."

Chartonus shifts his gaze between them, uncomfortable. "Ah... gentlemen. You may go inside now, if you wish."

Mydei looks away, thank God, and he lets out air he didn't know he was holding.

"Thank you, Chartonus," he says, and begins walking away towards the actual entrance. Phainon follows. "So, Deliverer. Are you up for a whole body work out?"

"Hell yes. I'm gonna beat you this time, Mydei." He doubts it. They both seem to be pretty equal in this regard as well, but anything to fuel the competition.

Mydei scoffs. "You really should talk less. How about we start with chest press?"

He points to the bench, that is surprising but luckily empty. Phainon finds himself nodding before he even thinks about it.

Mydei sits on the bench, placing a towel where his head will rest and carelessly dropping his phone and bag on the floor. He does some lame stretches, and Phainon raises a curious brow.

"Is that your warm-up?"

"This? No. But I prefer to warm up with the bar," he says, tapping with his fingers the empty barbell. "I don't need spotting for this, so why don't you warm up in the meantime?"

And he does just that. He puts his things next to Mydei's and starts stretching his body, arms thrown back and then in circles, as he watches Mydei's movements. The weight is clearly nowhere near enough to actually put a strain on his muscles, but he admires anyway.

"So, what's your personal record?" he asks absentmindedly, half-crouching to feel that painful pull of his quads. Mydei looks at him sideways for a brief moment before returning his eyes to the ceiling.

"I once managed three hundred and fifty-five pounds, but my average rounds the three hundred and forty," he answers casually, and Phainon can almost feel his eyes popping out of their sockets.

"What the fuck? Are you on steroids?"

Mydei puts the barbell in place and scoffs. "It's an achievable weight if you are patient enough. What's yours?"

"*Your* average is my P.R. My average is about three hundred and twenty."

"Still great. But I win this time," he says, patting his chest proudly. "Now, would you help me fetch the weights?"

Phainon nods and bites his inner cheek. Alright. He can grant him that one. But there's no way he overpowers him in squats.

Once they are done sliding the discs in place Mydei lies down on the bench, while Phainon stands right behind, his hands beneath the barbell on each side of Mydei's head.

He smiles down at him. "Impress me. But don't push yourself, yes?"

Mydei tsks. "Whatever."

He firmly grabs the bar as he slightly arches his back, feet planted strongly on the floor. He takes one deep breath and pulls the barbell out of the rack, and carefully lowers it to his chest. Phainon's hand follow the movement, hovering and ready to act should he need his help. But he doubts that will be necessary: Mydei's control over the weights is flawless, so much that he makes it seem easy despite the tensing of his muscles and reddening face. He's grunting just loud enough for both of them to hear, yet his breaths remain as steady as his perfect technique.

Phainon swallows, suddenly feeling incredibly aware of the barely existing distance between his crotch and Mydei's face. *God, no*. He urges himself to focus.

Thankfully, he needs not to worry about that once Mydei hits the sixth repetition, sweat already running down his forehead as he puts the barbell back in place with Phainon's help.

He attempts a lighthearted laugh. "You were not lying, huh?"

Mydei is taking a long sip out of his water bottle, trying to catch his breath. "Of course not. Are my gains not something you can see, Deliverer?"

Phainon folds his arms. "Mydeimos, are you trying to fish compliments?"

"Don't be ridiculous."

"But, if you truly need reassurance, your pecs are amazing," he says, his brain not fast enough to stop his mouth. He realizes that far too late.

Thankfully, Mydei doesn't seem to think much about it. He just snorts and shakes his head, leaving his bottle on the floor once again.

"Why, thank you."

After resting for two minutes, Mydei does another series, and another one after that, with Phainon taking the same spot behind his head. He barely completes his last repetitions, his muscles clearly strained by now, but mantains a spotless form. He then helps Phainon arrange his weight plates and they switch positions, now Mydei hovering over him as his hands mimic the ghost of Phainon's. And doesn't Mydei look even more stunning from this angle, looking at him from above with blond hair sticking to his sweaty forehead and a piercing gaze.

"Ready?" His voice pulls him out of his own mind. Phainon says nothing as he nods, pulling the barbell down.

After three series, Phainon finds himself with his heart rate over the charts and reaching for his own water bottle like a man on the desert would. Though he did not lift as much as Mydei, he did a few more repetitions, which counts for something.

"What now, Deliverer?" he asks, extending a hand to help him get up. He accepts gladly.

"Squats," comes Phainon's immediate response. "P.R?"

"Three hundred and sixty. You?"

Phainon smirks. "Three hundred and ninety."

Mydei's brows go up in surprise, much to Phainon's delight. "Impressive. How long did it take you?"

"Like three years. I've always had strong legs," he says, squeezing his hard thigh. Mydei follows the movement with his eyes, humming.

"I can see that."

Phainon just laughs to disguise his fluster.

They rapidly take over the squat ring, setting up all the equipment necessary, and Phainon closes the belt around his waist with a single click. Mydei frowns.

"Are you sure you want to go first? I've been resting for a while now."

Phainon waves him off, securing the weights with the clips on one side while Mydei does so on the other.

"Don't worry about that. Different muscle, different timer."

Mydei sighs. "If you say so."

Phainon positions himself, with the barbell supported on his upper back. Mydei stands right behind him, hands extended out. Phainon meets his eyes in the mirror, and he looks away bashfully when Mydei squints his eyes.

"Don't let me get crushed, yeah?" he mumbles as he pulls up the bar.

"Do not tempt me," is what Mydei answers.

He supresses a smile. He lets his legs get accustomed to the heavy weight before inhaling deep and going down, knees bending just until his butt is slightly beneath. Then he tightens his core and pushes back up, feeling that delicious burn on his quads and glutes. He lets out a grunt before repeating, checking his form in the mirror— Mydei bends slightly, just so his hands remain protectively under the barbell, while shamelessly staring at his ass.

Phainon will make sure to tease him for that.

He completes five repetitions with ease and then two more with struggle before he puts the bar back in the rack, his lungs urging him to take various deep breaths and his throat begging for water. He listens to his body just as he turns around to face Mydei, who is looking at him arms crossed.

"Your technique is perfect, Deliverer. Admirable."

Phainon feels his face heat up even more at the sudden praise. He takes another sip of water just because.

"Thank you, Mydei. By the way, were you oggling my ass just now?"

Smooth deflection, Phainon!, whispers his conscience. Mydei's expression resembles one of a cat being caught doing something bad, and he purses his lips not to cackle.

"I... didn't know where to look," he says, sounding almost remorseful. But then he seems to remember something, for he sterns his face. "But, hey. Aren't you always staring at my chest?"

Phainon almost chokes on his water. Ah, so much for playing dumb.

He quickly recovers, though, and retorts in a smartass way: "Actually, I am looking at your heart. Your chest just happens to be in the way."

Mydei playfully punches him in the arm, but he's smiling.

"Whatever, you idiot."

"Hey. I'm just a guy that knows how to appreciate another man's natural beauty. What can I say? I'm a romantic after all." Mydei pinches the bridge of his nose, but Phainon can tell he's trying not to laugh. Still. He schools his face and clears his throat. "But if it bothers you, I'll stop."

"It's fine, I don't mind it. Do you?" asks Mydei, quirking a brow.

Phainon grins. "Not at all. Spot me again, Mydeimos?"

After five minutes, Phainon sits with a heavy groan on the floor, gulping down half of his bottle. Mydei takes off the plates he won't need, and hums appreciatively.

"Three series of seven repetitions each, with no decrease in the weight... you must really like squats to subject yourself to such torture. Either that or you're the one on steroids."

He snorts. "Not that I love them, but I enjoy them the most. Plus, It's absolutely worth it."

Mydei says nothing else. Phainon allows himself to rest for only a minute before he's back on his feet, standing behind Mydei. He extends his hands, and sighs.

"My man, you better be able to pull this off, because in the state my legs are in I'm not sure I'll be much help," is what he says, earning a frown from Mydei's reflection. "Just kidding."

Mydei shakes his head and carefully lifts the barbell in the same manner Phainon did, and fills his chest with air before going down— and Phainon realizes, regrettably too late, that he's standing too close just when his crotch brushes Mydei's hard butt. He immediately backs away, still in reach, and prays to whoever is above that Mydei did not notice that; but the fact is that there's no way he didn't, so he does his best to pry his eyes away from the mirror.

Man, isn't the ceiling in this gym so cool?

After six perfectly done repetitions, Mydei puts the barbell back in place, sighing in relief as he does so. He takes small sips of water, and his eyes do not leave Phainon's awkward lean against the rack.

"Just so you know, Deliverer," he begins, and Phainon swallows nervously. "When spotting squats, you have to bend alongside the person."

"Y-Yeah. My bad," he stutters

Mydei cracks a mocking smile.

"D-Don't mention it," he fake stutters.

His repetitions go fairly quick —and this time Phainon minds his distance — as Mydei doesn't seem to be one to need a long resting period before going at it again, the lucky one. Phainon barely registers the duration of

their whole routine, but by the time they are done he notes that a little over three hours passed, the sun gone off to hiding.

And he notices with disbelief that they are currently facing a familiar predicament.

Phainon scans his screen again just to be sure before letting out a dramatic groan. "We tied."

Mydei frowns. "What? No way, you must have something wrong," he says, sliding his towel over his shoulder as he scoots next to Phainon.

"Just look," Phainon tilts his phone so he can see better, "you won chest press, I won squats. Then I won bicep curl and deadlift, but you won military press and lat pulldown. After that I won hip thrust and you won with the barbell rows. And we tied on abs."

"Fuck," is all that comes out Mydei's mouth, followed by a sigh. "Well. We can settle this with cardio sometime. But not now. I'm wasted."

He begins walking to the dressing room, and Phainon quickly trails behind him. "You know, some other day I'd tease you, but I don't think I'd last more than two minutes on the treadmill," he says, feeling his legs trembling with each step.

Mydei says nothing in response, but Phainon takes that as agreement. When they finally make it to the showers, each enters a different stall, locking the doors with a single click. Phainon wastes no time taking off his sweaty clothes, piling them on the little stool that's in the corner.

"I can't help but feel my gym is a little lacking," Mydei mutters from the other side.

"Well, you could always switch here, no?" Phainon offers, turning on the faucet.

Mydei does the same on his stall. "I could afford it, I guess, but I've been going to the same gym since I moved to Okhema. It's already a familiar

place. And the administrator is Kremnoan, so."

Phainon nods, and soon realizes Mydei cannot see that. "That makes sense, yeah."

He steps under the running water and lets out a pleased moan when the warmth envelops his aching body. He stands still beneath it, letting his muscles rest for a few more moments before he starts to rinse himself properly. He'll treat himself to a proper shower once he gets home, though.

"That was a good workout," he says, and Mydei only grunts in acknowledgment. He speaks again after a beat. "You know, Mydei, I'm actually curious. What do you dedicate yourself to? Like, for a living."

Phainon can almost picture his frown. "And where did that come from?"

"Just a shower thought, I guess. Plus, I've never asked you, I think."

"Yeah, you haven't." He hears him sigh deeply. "I went to culinary school, and took many cooking courses after that to polish my skills. Right now I'm working as a sous chef in a bakery, but it's among my goals to open a restaurant of my own."

Phainon feels himself smiling big. "That's so cool, Mydei. I'm gonna have to put those cooking abilities of yours to test someday, yeah?"

Mydei laughs short, genuine and barely audible under the water's noise, but Phainon is lucky enough to catch it. "Cooking for others is what I enjoy the most, so I wouldn't have an issue with that."

Phainon settles with a playful giggle and hurries to finish washing himself before the free fifteen minutes are up. He dries himself with the towel kindly provided by the gym and grabs the extra set of clothes he packed in his bag, quickly dressing up. When he comes out of the stall Mydei is already done, arranging his hair in a quick braid. He looks very pretty like this, with his face flushed and hair dripping wet. Objectively speaking, Phainon's mind supplies.

"Let me walk you to the station. It's pretty dark outside."

Mydei only looks at him sideways, checking himself on the mirror. "You don't have to."

"I know. But I want to. I mean, I like talking to you and stuff," he says, walking outside the dressing room next to Mydei.

Mydei seems thoughtful for a moment before he shrugs. "Well. As long as it isn't because you doubt my self preservation skills, I'll allow it."

To that, Phainon snorts. "Ah. If anything, when looking at those muscles you have, I can but pity anyone that could try to go against you."

Mydei gives a side smile. They make their way out of the gym in a peaceful quiet, making sure to wave Chartonus goodbye before facing the hot summer breeze outside. The walk to the station isn't more than five minutes, really, and Phainon feels a little embarrassed by the disappointment that settles in his stomach— but really, what's a man to do? Mydeimos' company it's incredibly pleasant, even if the man himself may not think so.

Phainon clears his throat after deciding that the silence has stretched for far too long. "So. Halloween it's just around the corner. Do you celebrate it?"

"If by just around the corner you mean two months, sure. But yes. At least I used to celebrate when I was a child. Now I just stay home watching horror movies, or cooking for my friends," he says, a touch of sweet nostalgia in his voice.

Phainon smiles gently. "That's kind of you. I bring this up because I plan to do a special stream that night, with a marathon of horror games. I'd love for you to join me."

He hums. "I highly doubt I'll have plans, so sure. I'm in."

"Great! Looking forward to it." Phainon is beaming already. *Oh*, it'll be so fun to tease Mydei.

They don't talk more. Usually, Phainon feels the urge to fill the silence with everything, and tends to feel incredibly uneasy if the other person doesn't go along— but with Mydei it's somewhat different. He'd still rather be making small talk, but the silence isn't all too bad. At the very least, Mydei seems to enjoy himself that way, and that's enough for him to feel comfortable and just relax.

Once they make it to the station, they do a fist bump in a friendly manner and Mydei gives him a nod. "Be safe on your way home, Deliverer. Wouldn't want you to drop dead before I get to do it myself."

Phainon laughs out loud. "My. I guess I'll have to watch my back, then, if only to grant you that."

Mydei just shakes his hand and walks away, past the entry zone. Phainon keeps his eyes on him until he's out of sight and he physically can't anymore.

They haven't seen each other since then, that with Phainon's schedule never lining up with his —because apparently he has an *office* job besides his streaming one— and Mydei working overtime to be able to save up money quicker. But they have texted. A lot. Phainon hasn't let a single day go by without texting him, even if just to send a silly video of whatever, and it doesn't fail to have Mydei feeling somewhat fuzzy. He is hardly accustomed to such attention, after all, and it's helped take off a little weight off his back in the tough shifts.

Speaking of which.

"Clocking out early, Mydeimos?"

He startles, looking over to his boss as he pats his hands on the apron. The woman stands tall, arms folded with her signature side bun looking as neat as always. Her expression remains unreadable, as usual.

"Miss Ruan Mei. I believe I had let you know this morning that I wouldn't be able to cover the evening. But I can compensate this weekend, if necessary." He forces himself to stop when her lips curve into a smile.

"Please, do not fret. It suits me just fine, in fact. I have some... business to attend to." She emphasizes on the last sentence, and he swallows. "Don't take too long, yes?"

Mydei is alreading taking off his apron by the time she leaves the kitchen. There is something so off about the woman, but he can't quite put his fingers on it— one thing he's sure about, though, is that she's involved in some shady stuff and that the bakery is nothing but a facade (and he sure as hell doesn't want to know more than that). But, she *is* a kind boss, so if the police ever go ask him, he'll just say he never saw it coming.

He hurries to clean the counters and then his hands, making sure to leave everything as shiny as it was when he walked in. When he steps out, the woman is by the register, taking out some money. She gives Mydei a half smile, and he responds with a nervous one.

"Do you have plans for tonight? I know you youths enjoy these type of holidays," she asks, slowly counting the wad of bills in her hand.

"I, yeah, I do." His answer makes her smile grow bigger, and his unease deepens.

"Are you not going to ask me?"

"Ah, well, I believe that would be inappropriate of me," he says.

She giggles short. "You're right. It wouldn't be fitting of me to answer, either." Mydei purses his lips and nods. Then, very unexpectedly, she extends the wad in his direction. "Here. Treat yourself and your friend to something nice."

Mydei blinks, confused, but takes it nevertheless. "Thank you, boss. But why?"

"You're my only employee, that's why. Plus, you're great at what you do, and I believe good behavior should be as much rewarded as bad behavior punished," is her answer, her voice flat but charged as she rests her chin on her hand.

Mydei grips the door handle tightly, but smiles politely. "Of course. Thank you a lot for this."

When she only nods, he decides it's time to swing the door open and walk the hell out— but just when he's about to, there's a thought.

"How... how did you know I was meeting with a friend?"

She shrugs. "I didn't. It was just a safe bet."

She sounds sincere enough, at least. He gives her one final, stranded smile before finally walking out and pushing that entire conversation out of his brain, for his own sake.

Right on cue, his phone vibrates in his pocket. Right, Phainon.



▶

Mydei turns off his phone and puts it back in his pocket after briefly checking the time: barely four past noon. That gives him enough time to go to the grocery store, cook something nice and prepare a backpack with the essentials— they had ultimately decided on a sleepover, as it will be far too late by the time the livestream ends for Mydei to go back to his home alone. That's what Phainon had argued, at least, but Mydei didn't disagree.

His trip to the supermarket is supposed to be brief: he only grabs a few ingredients that are beggining to run low, like flour and eggs, and also takes

the opportunity to buy a couple of cartons of lactose-free milk. But before walking towards the checkout he stops his own tracks, suddenly realizing something very important— he still doesn't know what to make. He frowns at the thought, looking down at his basket. It should preferably be something savory, he decides, for he doubts Phainon will make dinner. Mydei begins flipping through his internal recipe book, tapping his foot. What does Phainon even like? He hasn't bothered to ask him for his food preferences, and he mentally kicks himself for it. How could he have forgotten the most important thing? Well. It's too late to dwell on that now. He'll have to follow his gut.

Something light is probably the way to go. Crispy meatballs are too light. Anything with fish is a little risky, since he doesn't know if Phainon is a picky eater. Braised chicken or stuffed pitas are always a safe bet, but he's not really feeling it. His scowl deepens for a moment until he remembers the pastitsio his mother used to make. *Right*. Nobody dislikes pastitsio, and it's neither a very simple nor a very difficult dish to prepare. Just perfect.

He returns to the dairy aisle and grabs a package of lactose-free parmesan, and along the way he grabs a package of penne pasta as well —he unfortunately has no time to make it himself—. Finally, and confident that he has enough pomegranates at home, he resumes his walk toward home. *Home*, for him, is a small condo located downtown, much larger than he really needs. It's the only good thing he can attribute to his father: the roof over his head, which he's become so familiar with.

But really, it's the least thing the old man could do after all the harm done.

Mydei carefully opens the door and hurries to let the things over his counter, checking the time again: he has about three hours to prepare the dish. For him, that's more than enough.

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As always, his timing is impeccable: when he pulls the steaming tray out of the oven, he still has an hour and a half to prepare. He gently places it on the counter, smiling proudly as the pleasant smell fills his nostrils.

The rest doesn't take too long: he takes a quick shower and packs his backpack, taking only what's needed for one night: a change of clothes, his pajamas (which, to be fair, only consist of an old tank top and shorts), and a small bag with his toothbrush and hair oil. He trusts that Phainon will be kind enough to lend him the rest. He puts on a jacket, as it's now cold outside, and carefully wraps the pastitsio in a tupperware. He made exactly four servings, so he hopes that's enough for the both of them.

By the time he makes it to the station, his phone is buzzing again.

Phainon

Praise the sun!



Phainon

bought more of ur juice



Phainon

this one is supposed to be 100% natural



Phainon

i have fresh milk too so u mix it or whatever it is u do



Phainon

i was gonna surprise u but im impatient HURRY UP!!

[Image Attached]

▶

Mydei opens the photo with a hint of a smile on his lips, and it only grows bigger when it turns out to be proof of what he's saying. He'll always prefer the juice from freshly squeezed fruit, but the brand showcased in the picture is pretty close to the real thing. Good. Has to give him those points— but this one is going to be a tie too, as per usual. His pastitsio is always the highlight of holidays. He texts nothing back, as his hands are full, but sends a sticker in response. He hopes Phainon gets the message.

Thankfully, there's not many people on the train, so he can allow himself a seat. The remaining fifteen minutes of the trip are peaceful: after getting off at the right station, his walk toward Phainon's building is just as quiet. There aren't many people on the street either, so he doesn't run the risk of someone pushing him *and* his magnum opus, but he still prefers not to risk tripping and walks looking down at the damaged cement.

When he finally reaches the familiar lobby, he politely greets the woman behind the counter and heads for the elevator. Before he knows it, he's standing in front of the apartment 496. He knocks with his feet.

He can't help a sense of deja vu when Phainon finally opens the door, wearing the same smile on his lips and welcoming glow he did last time— only this time Mydei feels less out of place and comfortable enough to smile back, so naturally and sincere it almost catches him off guard, if not for the fact that he's now accepted the fact that Phainon is just one of the people that manages that.

"Finally, you're here. I was getting impatient already," is what Phainon says, stepping aside. Mydei walks straight towards the kitchen like he owns the place, and lets out a scoff.

"This time I'm early. I thought we had agreed to meet at nine?" He places his palm over the tupperware. Hm. It'll definitely need some reheating.

Phainon lets out a sigh, joining him. "Well, yes, but you know. I get bored and all. What's that, by the way?" he asks, pointing a finger in the tupper's

direction.

Mydei folds his arms, all too pleased with himself. "I made us dinner."

His grin gets impossibly wider, teeth shining brightly. "Am I going to finally taste your cooking, Mydeimos?"

"Well, yes. You like pasta, right?" When Phainon just nods enthusiastically, he lets out a relieved sigh. "Alright, great. Then how about we eat first and start the livestream after? Unless you already have everything set up."

"Please, let's. I'm dying of hunger anyway," Phainon says, dramatically patting his belly. Either way, Mydei shares the sentiment, so he only removes the aluminum wrap from around the tupper in response.

Phainon looks at its contents curiously, and Mydei smiles. "Pastitsio. Have you never tried it?"

He pouts slightly. "No, but I'm sure I've seen it before."

Mydei's brows go up. "That's surprising. It's a pretty popular dish all over the region, as far as I know."

"Well, my small town had its own cuisine, and I haven't really tried much other than your typical pita sandwich," comes his explanation.

"That makes sense. I suppose it's a good thing that the first one you're going to try it's mine, but I'm also afraid any other you eat after this just won't hit the same," Mydei says, smugly. One thing he's allowed to brag about? His cooking.

"Right. We'll see about that." Phainon smiles knowingly, maybe with some intent. Mydei ignores it. "Should I reheat it, then?"

"Let me do it. Just hand me two plates, please."

"Do you not trust me to use a microwave, prince?" Phainon teases, doing what he says anyway.

Mydei scoffs. "Don't misunderstand. I just want to make sure my dish is my own work of art until the very last moment before it graces somebody else's palate," he answers flatly, putting one of the portions in the microwave and setting it for three minutes.

Phainon is already sitting at the island, tableware out and ready.

"How come you took over my kitchen? Should I realy let you? Am I not being an awful host right now?" he muses out loud, supporting his chin on his hand.

Mydei rolls his eyes. "Relax, Deliverer. This is what I enjoy doing. And I prefer when people stay out of it either way, so don't worry about that." Phainon still seems somewhat unconvinced, so he hurries to add: "Unless I'm overstepping?"

Phainon frowns and shakes his head furiously. "No, not at all."

"Alright. Then just allow me. You're already letting me stay over, the least I can do is help out a little." His tone is definitive, and Phainon thankfully says nothing else.

When the timer hits zero, Mydei carefully takes out the dish and places it in front of Phainon, hurrying to put in his own before turning to see his reaction. What he likes the most about cooking is watching people try his dishes— wether their eyes light up in satisfaction or their brows knit together in confusion. But Phainon doesn't even lift the cutlery.

Mydei gives him an encouraging nod. "Come on, try it. It's gonna get cold"

Phainon smiles almost teasingly, as if sensing his eagerness. "That would be rude of me. Besides, I don't like my food too hot anyway. Don't mind me."

He takes a deep breath. *Fine. Fair point.* He taps his foot impatiently — already quite hungry himself— and takes his food out just ten seconds before the timer runs down. He feigns nonchalance as he slowly places his steaming dish next to Phainon's, sitting on the stool just beside him. "Alright. Can we indulge now? I'm starving," he says.

"*Yes*, please. Man, this looks delicious." Phainon wastes no time cutting down on his food and taking one big bite. Mydei's brows go up in mild surprise, but feels himself smiling just as quickly when Phainon lets out a delighted moan. "Oh. *Oh*, Mydei, this is *good*."

He laughs short, taking a smaller bite. The familiar taste immediately takes him back Kremnos, to the aroma of spices that always filled every corner of his house when his mother prepared the same dish now on his palate. His version is damn good too, but nowhere near as good as his mother's.

"Thank you," he says, pushing the nostalgia away. "But I've been mastering this dish for years now. It's only natural it comes out great."

"*Great?* Mydei, this is like the best thing I've ever tried," Phainon repeats, taking another big bite.

"You should raise your standards. This is just pasta," he grunts, feeling his face hot. Phainon sure is smooth with his praise. "Also, eat slower. I don't want you choking."

"Would be worth it." Phainon winks at him and Mydei rolls his eyes, stuffing his mouth with food not to smile. "And who cares if it's just pasta? Doesn't make it less awesome. But you *have* to show me what else you've got, Mydei. If this is good, then the dishes you are proud of must be a piece of heaven."

"Hey, I'm proud of every recipe I master, including this one. What I meant is that is pretty simple compared to other things I've made," he responds honestly.

Phainon shrugs. "Point still stands. Oh, and of course, thanks for this. Excluding the fact that I'm *absolutely glad* you did, you shouldn't have bothered. I was planning on ordering something."

Mydei waves him off. "I like homemade food better. Plus, I enjoy cooking. Let that sink in." He flicks his forehead.

Phainon feigns hurt and Mydei snorts. They eat the rest of their dinner in silence, other than the occasional and sudden praise from Phainon, who seems to be enjoying himself even more than Mydei. They do end up eating the remaining pastitsio, just as Mydei predicted, and after the rather fulfilling meal Phainon puts the dirty plates and cutlery inside the dishwasher.

"I can barely breathe," he says, sighing. "I'm so full."

Mydei opens the fridge after an approving nod from Phainon and takes out the crate of pomegranate juice. "You know what's great to down the food? This." He lifts up the crate for emphasis, and Phainon lifts a brow. "Did you try it?"

"Not yet. It felt wrong to do so without you," he answers, shrugging, and grabs a pair of glasses out of the cupboard.

"You're ridiculous," says Mydei, even as an uninvited warmth spreads all over his chest. He does his best to ignore it, though, pouring juice on both glasses. It's cold, and when Mydei takes a sip, he feels in heaven.

Phainon, on the other hand, grimaces. "Jesus, Mydei, this is bitter as shit."

Mydei laughs. "Well, yes, that's why I usually add milk. But after a heavy meal, just the refreshing taste of the fruit is enough."

Phainon puts his glass down, still twisting his mouth funny. "Yeah. I think I take water over this anytime."

"Suit yourself." Mydei takes what's left of Phainon's juice and pours it into his own, gulping it down in one go. Phainon is looking at him with a glint of amusement, and he frowns. "What?"

"That's probably the happiest I've seen you. Is the way to your heart pomegranate juice, Mydeimos?"

He scoffs. "Try all you want." He nods towards Phainon's bedroom. "Better get this thing started now if we don't want to keep your viewers waiting."

Phainon laughs softly. He grabs a couple of beers from the fridge and then they make their way inside. Just like last time, Phainon already set up everything, but now Mydei notices that instead of the leds, what keeps the room lit are the little jack-o'-lanterns spread all over the desk.

"I wanted to decorate, but you know, since we'll be streaming in the dark and all the audience wouldn't be able to see them anyway," Phainon says as he sits on his chair, leaning back so Mydei can sit on his. "You don't have a problem with that, right?"

"'Course not. What are we playing, anyway?" He sinks into his chair. *So comfortable*.

Phainon shoots him a sly smile as he starts his computer. "You'll see."

Mydei rolls his eyes. He waits for Phainon to open Genesis and link all the apps he needs —which he doesn't bother registering— before starting the livestream. He sets the intermission screen and then proceeds to accomodate the camera right above the monitor, same angle as last time. Mydei looks down at the screen. Plenty of viewers already joined, and are messaging between themselves in the chatbox as they wait for the stream to start.

"Either no one in your community has a life, or they are willing to sacrifice trick or treating with friends for you," Mydei says idly.

Phainon snorts. "Come on, Mydei. It's barely ten. Most halloween parties start well past midnight. And anyway, that wouldn't make them any different from us, right? We, too, are doing this instead of going out."

Mydei bites down a smile. "Fair. So, will Castorice be here as well?"

"Of course. She's the only one I trust to tame these people," he responds, placing his hand over the mouse. He looks at Mydei. "Ready to go?"

Mydei clicks the start button for him as an answer, Phainon's laugh being the only acknowledgment he gets before their dimmed out faces are displayed on the screen.

"Hello, people!" Phainon says as in command, getting his face closer to the camera.

"Hi again," follows Mydei, waving his hand from behind Phainon. The chatbox quickly floods with incoming messages.

@DeliveringDawn

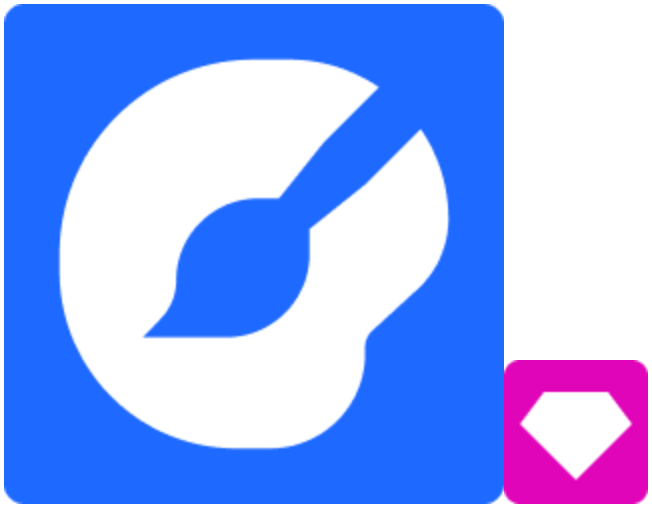
CastoMiss: Hello, Mydei! Great to have you here again.

whimsicalthief: the people yearn for the prince

King_Bartholos: ohh him again ... this is gonna be a funny stream



 reavingflames: is that my beautiful glorious charming prince

 neikoslove: MYDEI MYDEI MYDEI

thetwilightsky: hi, prince! : 3

Send a message Chat

Phainon stifles a laugh, biting his lip. "Seems like 'prince' is now your official nickname, Mydei. Do you like it?"

Mydei folds his arms, sighing. "Not the worst."

"Don't worry, everyone. In Mydei language, that means he likes it," Phainon says, all too smugly.

"And how about we start playing? In Mydei's language, this means I'm going to lose my patience soon," he retorts.

Phainon laughs openly. "So petty. Well, for tonight I have three games in mind, so you all better get comfy. And as for you, Mydei," he dramatically points at him, leaning back so the audience can fully see his face, "I hope you brought a clean pair of pants, 'cause you're going to be shitting all over yours."

Mydei can't help the cackle that leaves his throat. He cuts it down before it gets to Phainon's head, seeing as he's already smiling teasingly. He punches him in the arm, and Phainon yelps. "You should know by now not to act so confident, Deliverer. If anything, *you* are going to be the one clinging to me."

He doesn't say it with an ulterior motive, but Phainon seems to think so, for he begins batting his lashes exaggeratedly, taking his index finger between his lips in a seductive matter. "You are so charming, Mydeimos."

Mydei lets out a pained groan and forces himself to look away from Phainon's puppy eyes, lest he gets lost in them for longer than considered normal. "Stop being ridiculous."

Phainon finally drops the act with a playful snort. "Sorry, guys. Messing with this man is way too fun. Back to business." He schools his face as he opens his games' library. "So, the first one is *Five nights at Bubbles'*. It's incredibly popular, so I think I'll skip the explanation. Then we'll play some rounds of *Phantomphobia*: it's a very simple ghost hunting game, that relies more on the thrilling ambience than on jumpscares. It's really good. Finally, to close up the night, we're playing a short story game. I've tried not to read much about it, but the premise is that you visit an abandoned building. It looked creepy as shit, so yeah, why not?"

Mydei takes a deep breath. He isn't too good with horror, contrary to what people may think— he isn't the type to be so scared he gets nightmares after, but he's definitely the person whose screams are the loudest. For the sake of his pride, he prays Phainon is just like him in this regard.

Phainon seems to read his thoughts, for he wiggles his eyebrows teasingly. "You ready, Mydei?"

He scoffs. "You know the answer to that."

During the first game, Phainon is the one with keyboard privileges, with Mydei instructing him. Just like he said, the game is ridiculously popular— a classic, even. Naturally, both of them have played it numerous times before, but that doesn't make it any less thrilling.

Especially not when Phainon keeps doing everything he tells him *not* to do.

He does that on the first two nights, for they are relatively easy, and Mydei is perfectly aware that is a tactic to annoy him, if his crooked and barely hidden smile is anything to go by— and Mydei doesn't really understand why he goes along with it, but he would be lying if he said it isn't amusing. He finds himself biting down smiles of his own more times that he can count.

Weird.

"Okay. You all know that shit starts to get serious now," Phainon says as the third night starts.

"Please, Deliverer, don't forget the music box," Mydei pleas, his eyes fixed on the screen.

Phainon only gives him a loopsided grin. Still, he follows Mydei's commands more obediently this time, and that helps them easily go through the fourth night uneventfully as well. Phainon stretches in his chair as the fifth night loads.

"Y'know, this game used to be way harder when I was a kid," he muses out loud, eyes scanning the chatbox. "Not to jinx it, of course, but I used to die at least once per night."

Mydei mimics Phainon, stretching his strained neck. "Well. I suppose it's way easier when you have someone else reminding you what to do," he offers, pointing at himself.

"Oh, whatever. Let's see how you do on the next game."

"Probably not as good, considering it isn't child's play like this one."

"Already making excuses for yourself, Mydei?" says Phainon, fake mockery in his voice.

Mydei ignores him and points to the screen. "Honey Brew will kill us in five seconds if you don't wind that damn music box, Deliverer."

Phainon is quick to go back to streamer persona, eyes glued on the screen. "What do you all think? Will our streak end now?"

Mydei eyes the chatbox. Just like Phainon said, he's slowly starting to get used to the rapid flow of messages, and manages to catch some.

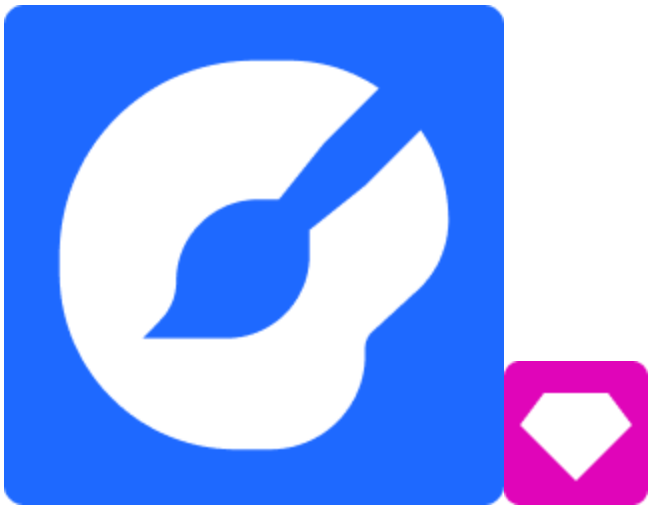
@DeliveringDawn

whimsicalthief: watch them die because of cat thief

caeluswasHere: y'all remember to check on nanus

stellewasHere: and oatmeal. u don't fear them too much early game but they are crazy on the fifth night

King_Bartholos: y'all sleeping on fig stew when he's the most annoying one since night 2


neikoslove: wait fr

Send a message Chat

"Deliverer, have you been flashing Fig Stew?" Mydei asks, the random viewer reminding him of it.

"Oh. Shit, no," is what Phainon answers.

Mydei braces himself. Phainon seems to do so too, because as soon as he closes the camera system he tries to cover his eyes. But it's too late. The robotic chimera immediately jumps, its scary and distorted face engulfing the screen, and they both scream in unison in a manner that not many would describe as manly.

"Fucking idiots," Mydei mutters, eyes still closed shut. "How did we forget about him?"

"Man. I forgot how well made the jumpscares are in this game," Phainon says, taking a deep breath. "Lesson learned, I suppose. Don't talk too soon."

"Speak for yourself. I knew not to get too cocky," Mydei retorts. "Should we try again? Or do you prefer to move on to the next one?"

Phainon taps his chin. "You know, I hate to quit on a game. But I'm excited for the next one. I'd say is the most thrilling one. You're gonna be the one playing, so you make the call."

He hums. "Well, I'd say we move on. My fingers are urging for some movement."

"Is that so?" Phainon squints at him, a knowing smile on his lips.

Mydei grimaces. "You're gross. Now scoot. Give me my keyboard privileges."

Phainon laughs, but does as told. Mydei notes with curiosity that Phainon's chair is far less comfortable than his. Either the Deliverer has weird preferences, or he did it on purpose. Mydei doesn't ponder on that and instead closes the game, scrolling through the library. He scrunches up his nose.

"Jesus. How many games do you have here?"

"Please, Mydei, this is my job. Don't judge me."

"Not judging. I just thought you stuck only to one gimmick, is all." He decides to look up the game directly on the search bar.

"I do! But I love trying out other games as well. It's fun," is what Phainon says, shrugging.

"Yeah, fair. And how about you give me your account information?" It's a joke.

But Phainon nods. "Sure. Just remind me to send it to you."

He's reading through the chatbox, expression completely devoid of teasing. Mydei raises a curious brow.

"Seriously? Just like that?"

Phainon finally turns to look at him. He laughs, confused. "Why are you so surprised? I like you."

He blushes furiously against his will. "What?"

"What?" Phainon's brows come together. After a couple of seconds he opens his eyes wide in surprise, his face flushing as well. "*As a buddy!* I like you a lot as a buddy. Like, I trust you. You get me. I get you. You know."

Mydei nods slowly. "Oh. Yeah, of course. I know."

"A-Anyway, did you find it?" Phainon immediately changes the topic, *thank God*.

@DeliveringDawn

CastoMiss: Omg...

whimsicalthief: even castorice broke character hell naw

caeluswasHere: what was that hello

thetwilightsky: that was... interesting... ?

 reavingflames: starts with g ends with ay

| In reply to @reavingflames: starts w...
CastoMiss: Please, behave. Avoid making these comments.

Send a message Chat

Thankfully, none of them become aware of the brief discussion that starts to take place on the chatbox.

"Just so you know, I'll hold you to that," Mydei mumbles, opening the game.

Phainon snorts. "As long as you don't sell my account on the dark web, feel free to use it as you wish."

"How kind of you. Is this bribery of some sorts?"

"Maybe. How about this: each game you download using my account equals to one free dish of yours." Mydei blinks. Phainon turns to the camera. "Just so you guys know, Mydei is an amazing cook. He made us dinner tonight, and man, that was hands down the best thing ever. You know, maybe one day we could do a cooking show off."

To that, Mydei laughs. "Absolutely no way. That is not a battle you can win, Deliverer."

"Probably. But hey, it would be fun. You could teach me a thing or two about cooking." He sounds genuine. The thought makes Mydei's chest flutter uncomfortably.

He scoffs. "I can think about it."

Phainon lights up. "So you'll do it. Great! That's gonna be fun."

"For me. For you, it will be tortuous."

"Whatever you say, prince."

@DeliveringDawn

whimsicalthief: not helping your case LMAO

caeluswasHere: this is so domestic fluff coded omg i shed a tear

| In reply to @caeluswasHere: this is so...
vidyadharatouch: all i see are two good friends. don't be weird.

rosycelestialmaiden: u mean like u and cae? yea sure lol

stellewasHere: CLOCK IT

CastoMiss: What a mess.

Send a message Chat

"Enough idle chat. Let's start our second round," Mydei says, starting the run.

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The third game ends with a perfectly executed jumpscare that has them both loudly screaming at the screen.

He'll be surprised if nobody in the building files a complaint against Phainon.

After a few moments of awkward silence, Phainon speaks up:

"That was it?" He sounds incredulous. Mydei sighs.

"Don't try to make sense of it. These games never have much plot. They only seek to serve as horror, nothing else," he says.

"Doesn't mean it has to be absolute dogshit. I mean, it was enjoyable and thrilling, but the ending definitely could use some improvement. Like, we went through all that trouble restarting the system just so the protagonist ends up dying *just* as she was about to escape? What was the point of that?"

"Shock value, maybe. Or just so they could sneak one final jumpscare."

"Whatever. Did you enjoy it, at least?"

Mydei thinks he's asking their audience, but his eyes turn to meet his instead. And it is only at this moment, with his nose barely a few inches away from Phainon's, that he realizes how close they are: his body must've shifted towards Phainon during the past hour without him even being aware of it. Phainon seems to just notice this as well, for his eyes widen almost imperceptibly upon the unexpected proximity. Mydei stays very still, and so does Phainon— but then his blue gaze falls to his lips, and just like a startled animal, Mydei immediately backs away. He feels his face hot, potentially mirroring Phainon's flushed one.

Whatever. *Whatever*.

He clears his throat. "Yeah, it was great. The game itself, I mean. The graphics were so laughable it kinda made it even more scary." Is he *nervous*? He is *not* nervous. He forces himself to school his face into something less strained.

Phainon nods, folding his arms in an awkward manner. "Yeah, exactly. It was really immersive, somehow. I would recommend it, probably. If you're just looking to have a good time with friends, then definitely give it a go. What do you guys think?"

One of the things Mydei likes about him is his ability to turn awkward situations around in the blink of an eye. He mentally thanks the distraction the chatbox provides, as Phainon's attention is quickly drawn to it. Mydei doesn't bother to read anything: instead, he pretends to do so while he composes himself.

"I'm glad you enjoyed the stream, guys!" Phainon's chirpy voice serves as a perfect background noise, Mydei decides. "How long we've been at it, anyway? Just look at the time! One in the morning. Still not too late for you all to catch up with the halloween parties, eh?" He lets out a soft laugh as he reads through the messages. Mydei really likes the sound of it. "Anyway, I believe is time for us to say our goodbyes. As always, thank you all so much for the support! It means the world to me that you enjoy my content. Anything to say, Mydei?"

Mydei blinks, pulled out of his own train of thought, but recovers quickly. "I share the sentiment. Thanks again for having me, everyone."

Phainon gives him a tiny smile and then returns his eyes to the camera. "You know he's not a man of many words, but he loves you, I'm sure." Mydei snorts and rolls his eyes. "See you next stream, everyone!"

He allows his viewers to send a couple more of emotes and farewells before he shuts down the stream. He leans back on his chair, letting out a shameless moan as he stretches his legs.

Mydei folds his arms in amusement. "Finally ran out of energy?"

"As if. I'm just a bit tired. That was a long one," he answers, letting his arms fall by his side. "Wanna watch a movie?"

He quirks a brow. "Isn't it a little bit late for that?"

"Don't be a grandpa, Mydeimos. The night is still young. Also, I bought some popcorn."

"The greasy and overly sugary one?"

"I think so."

Mydei stands up from his chair, cracking his aching back. "Perfect. My pick, though."

Mydei is quick to settle on the very much comfortable couch of Phainon's living room while the latter prepares their snacks. He has a blanket over his

legs, Phainon's courtesy, while he scrolls idly through the platform looking for an horror movie that doesn't look too cheap but also not too scary. He'd very much like to sleep tonight, thank you.

Phainon comes back carrying a big bowl of popcorn with one hand while the other holds a beer six pack. "Find anything yet?" he asks as he plops down next to Mydei.

"Yes. This one has an interesting premise," he answers.

"And what would that be?"

He rolls his eyes and points the controller towards the TV. It's a bit smaller than the one he has at his own house, but still pretty nice. "Read," is all he says.

Phainon sighs and takes a fist of popcorn. Then, he begins to read out loud in a somber voice: "One girl, three faces. Tillie is a smart, kind-hearted young woman, and people have no reason not to love her; however, there's more to her that meets the eye, for unexplained and tragic events would strike the small town of Janusopolis the moment she stepped foot in it." He scrunches up his nose. "*Tillie*? Is that supposed to be an intimidating name?"

"Do you have any objections?"

Phainon waves his hand. "Nah. It looks decent. It can't be too bad."

With that, Mydei clicks play and Phainon turns off the small lamp on the auxiliar table, leaving them only under the dim light coming from outside the windows and the TV. Mydei sets the volume to his liking and hands the controller to Phainon, reaching for a beer and taking a handful of popcorn himself.

He purses his lips at the sight of Phainon's naked legs, barely covered by a pair of pajama shorts. "Do you want the blanket?"

Phainon just moves closer to him and adjusts the blanket over them both. He smiles sheepishly. "We can share, right?"

Mydei blinks and nods absentmindedly. It's hard for him to focus on the movie, that with Phainon being so close to him— he can so perfectly feel the warmth radiating off his body, almost tempting him to reach out; of course, he drowns those thoughts away as fast as they come. It must be the sleep depravation talking, he knows, and he ignores every little voice saying otherwise by taking long sips of the cheap alcohol and sweet popcorn.

But because he's unlucky, when he intends to grab some more popcorn his hand meets with Phainon's halfway through— and to make matters worse, he doesn't immediately take it away: he only does so after feeling Phainon stilling next to him. He bites down on his popcorn harder than possibly necessary, and Phainon gulps down what remains of his beer before opening another one.

Mydei manages to tune out his own heartbeat and the funny feeling on his belly by forcing himself to pay attention to what's happening on the screen. He grabs another beer as well for good measure.

After an uneventful hour, with the popcorn and six cans of beer long gone, Mydei starts to feel the tipsiness settle in, both his face and body flushing uncomfortably. He long since lost interest in the movie, but the same cannot be said about Phainon: his brows are furrowed in suspense, utterly immersed in the plot. Mydei takes advantage of his trance-like state to steal a glance: his nose is mildly crooked, he notices, and his sun-shaped tattoo is a bit asymmetric. He also has three moles just next to his ear, a spot his hair usually covers.

Phainon must feel his stare, for he turns his eyes to him. He tilts his head like a confused puppy. "Something wrong?"

Mydei feels almost caught. "Just sleepy," he says in a low voice.

"Don't force yourself to stay up for my sake. We can finish it some other day." Phainon smiles gently, and that's all it takes for Mydei to tear his gaze away.

"It's fine," he mumbles, bringing the blanket up to his chin.

Phainon lets out a soft chuckle and returns his attention to the movie. "Suit yourself."

Mydei soon realizes that he's not going to be able to keep his eyes open for much longer. He yawns, feeling his eyelids heavier with each blink. The couch is just so soft. And the blanket is so warm. And Phainon looks so comfortable. Before the rational part of him can stop him, he listens to what his tipsy and barely conscious brain tells him and supports his head on Phainon's shoulder.

Much to his surprise, Phainon doesn't push him away: he merely startles a bit, but then quickly relaxes back into the cushions. He tugs on the blanket so it's properly covering Mydei's body and puts an arm around him, slowly, as if testing him. But Mydei doesn't protest, and Phainon's hand ultimately settles on his arm, pulling him impossibly closer. "Comfortable?" he asks.

"Very," he whispers in response.

Phainon says nothing else, only turning down the volume a little. Mydei allows himself to close his eyes, and he falls asleep before he can even register it.

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When Mydei wakes up, the first thing he notices is that he's still on the couch: his head is comfortably resting over the edge, a small pillow placed beneath his neck that he can only asume was Phainon's doing.

The second thing is that the man himself is also on the couch— more exactly, sprawled on top of *him*. His face is resting against his chest while his arms are thrown to the side in a manner that will definitely make them hurt after, but looks perfectly comfortable nevertheless. Mydei urges himself to stay calm despite feeling a little panicked. The reasonable thing that comes to mind is that Phainon must've also fallen asleep sometime after him while watching the movie.

Mydei simply stares down at the man: he's very much still sleeping, his breath steady and showing no intent to move at all. And he's drooling. Over *his* shirt. Mydei grimaces and decides that he can't allow himself to lay down much longer: he's sweaty, hungry and feels his mouth disgustingly dry. And God knows how desperately he needs to drink one big glass of water before his headache intensifies.

And, of course, he needs to get away from Phainon's warmth before he starts to feel too comfortable about it.

He very carefully attempts to move away from his weight, moving slowly not to startle him— but his attempts prove to be futile when Phainon pushes him back against the couch, his arm pressing over his abdomen to keep him down.

Mydei sighs and swallows both his shame and nerves. "Deliverer. Move."

He gets only a grunt in response. He's not too eager to wake up, it seems.

Mydei tries again, this time with a little bit of force, and manages to stand up before Phainon can do anything about it. He feels bad for just a moment, when Phainon's head falls flat over the couch, but the man keeps on sleeping like a log. Still, Mydei gently places the pillow beneath his head, and Phainon hums appreciatively.

He has to tell himself that the smile tugging at his lips is one of amusement and not of fondness.

Mydei treats himself to Phainon's bathroom —if he can even put it that way, as Phainon had told him he could use it however he needed— and quickly washes his face with ice cold water before brushing his teeth. The guy staring back from the mirror looks absolutely disheveled: face puffy, hair frizzy and in all the wrong places and prominent eyebags. He's used to looking like shit in the morning, but he's thankful Phainon wasn't awake to see it.

... Not that he cares about what he thinks. It would've been embarrassing, is all.

After a much needed hot shower, Mydei leaves the bathroom with his dirty clothes in hand, only a towel wrapped around his waist for wear.

He finds Phainon in the kitchen, gulping down a full glass of water. Though, he still looks half-asleep.

"Morning," is all Mydei says.

Phainon startles as he turns to look at him. He opens his mouth to say something, but only a choked sound makes it out when his eyes meet Mydei's torso. With him oggling him in such a poorly concealed matter, Mydei can't help but feel a little flustered. Maybe he shouldn't be walking around half-naked in a house that isn't his. Still, Phainon doesn't seem to mind— at least not in a bad way. When his gaze finally returns to his own, Mydei does his best to appear unbothered, raising a brow.

Phainon clears his throat, putting down the glass. "Good morning, Mydei. Why didn't you wake me up?"

"I tried, but you didn't budge." When Phainon pouts, he rolls his eyes. "Anyway. Can I dress in your room? The bathroom is full of steam."

"Go ahead. Did you bring clothes? I can lend you some of mine if you need."

"Thanks, but I brought my own." When Phainon just nods in response, a thought comes to mind. "Should I make breakfast while you shower?"

Phainon blinks. "Shouldn't I do that? You already made dinner last night."

Mydei shrugs. "I'll download games with your account and I'll cook for you. Deal still stands, right?"

"I mean, I was joking about the cooking part, but I'm not complaining either." Phainon gives him a smile as he walks past him towards the bathroom. "Use whatever you need."

By the time Phainon comes out showered *and* dressed, Mydei's signature pancakes are already sitting on the table, split in two generous portions.

"Perfect timing," Mydei says, placing the cutlery on the table. Then, he points at the improvised pomegranate sauce resting over the pancakes. "This is the best I could do without honey. You really need to buy ingredients, Deliverer."

Phainon blushes and scratches his neck. "Sorry. I don't usually eat home, so. Yeah."

Mydei huffs and sits down in front of Phainon. The table is really small, but it's enough for just the two of them. "I'm not judging you. But if we do a cooking challenge, we are doing it in *my* house."

To that, Phainon chuckles. "I can't believe you're actually considering it."

"Don't make me backtrack," he warns and takes a bite out of his breakfast. *Perfect*. "Now shut up and eat your food."

"Yes, boss."

Just like last night, Mydei looks at Phainon expectantly as he finally tries the pancakes— and just like last night, the reaction is immediate: Phainon hums in delight, shaking his head approvingly. Mydei smirks with satisfaction.

"God, Mydei, how do you manage to make even the simplest dish taste like heaven?" he says, his mouth full. Mydei decides to excuse his bad manners given the flattery.

"It is my job, after all. I'm glad you enjoy it," he answers, trying his best to sound casual even when his face flushes a little.

"When you open your restaurant, I'll be there every day. I'll be your number one customer."

Mydei laughs short. "Great. I have guaranteed clientele, then."

They eat their breakfast rather quickly, their bites only interrupted by idle chit chat about last night's stream. Once they're finished, Mydei helps Phainon lift the table.

"Do you need help with the dishes?" he asks when Phainon puts down the last plate.

"Don't worry. I've got this," he answers, smiling brightly.

He checks the time on his phone: eleven in the morning. He sighs.

"In that case, I think I'll get going."

Phainon hesitates. "You don't wanna stay for lunch? I can order some. Your pick."

"I already overstayed my welcome enough. Plus, I promised my boss I would cover today's early shift. I need to open the store and all that," he explains, waving his hand.

Phainon purses his lips. "I see. Should I walk you to the station?"

Mydei smiles. "No need. I can walk from here. But thanks."

"If you say so." Phainon extends a hand. Mydei shakes it with no second thought, but then Phainon pulls him into an awkward hug. He stays very still. When Phainon pulls away, he's grinning again. "Thanks for coming, Mydei. And for the food. It was great, I mean it, but next time let *me* treat you." Mydei raises a brow, and Phainon laughs. "Goodbye, Mydei. Be safe."

"Likewise," is all Mydei says before making his way towards the door, picking up his bag from the couch. He places his hand on the doorknob, but before walking out, he turns around one last time. His eyes meet Phainon's, and the latter tilts his head in inquiry. Mydei smiles. "You drool, by the way."

Castorice

Writing as we speak

Castorice

Mydei

Castorice

What do you think about Phainon?

Mydei

? Why do you ask?

Castorice

Curious. You two seem a lot closer.

Mydei

I wouldn't put it that way, but yeah, I guess.

Mydei

I consider him a good friend.

Castorice



Castorice

I see. Thanks. I'm glad to hear that.

Mydei

You're welcome (???)

Mydei
30% Training, 70% Diet

Phainon

MYDEI

Phainon

CHECK THIS OUT

[Location Attached]

Phainon

LET'S GO THERE !!! PLS

Mydei

A funfair.

Phainon

it'll be fun!! ill make it worth your while, promise

Mydei

Will you ride the rollercoasters?

Phainon

duh!!! only if u ride with me tho ;)

Phainon

unless ur scared???? ;))))

Mydei

As if. Just let me check my schedule.

Phainon



▶

Phainon paces anxiously around the ticket booth, checking the time every two steps.

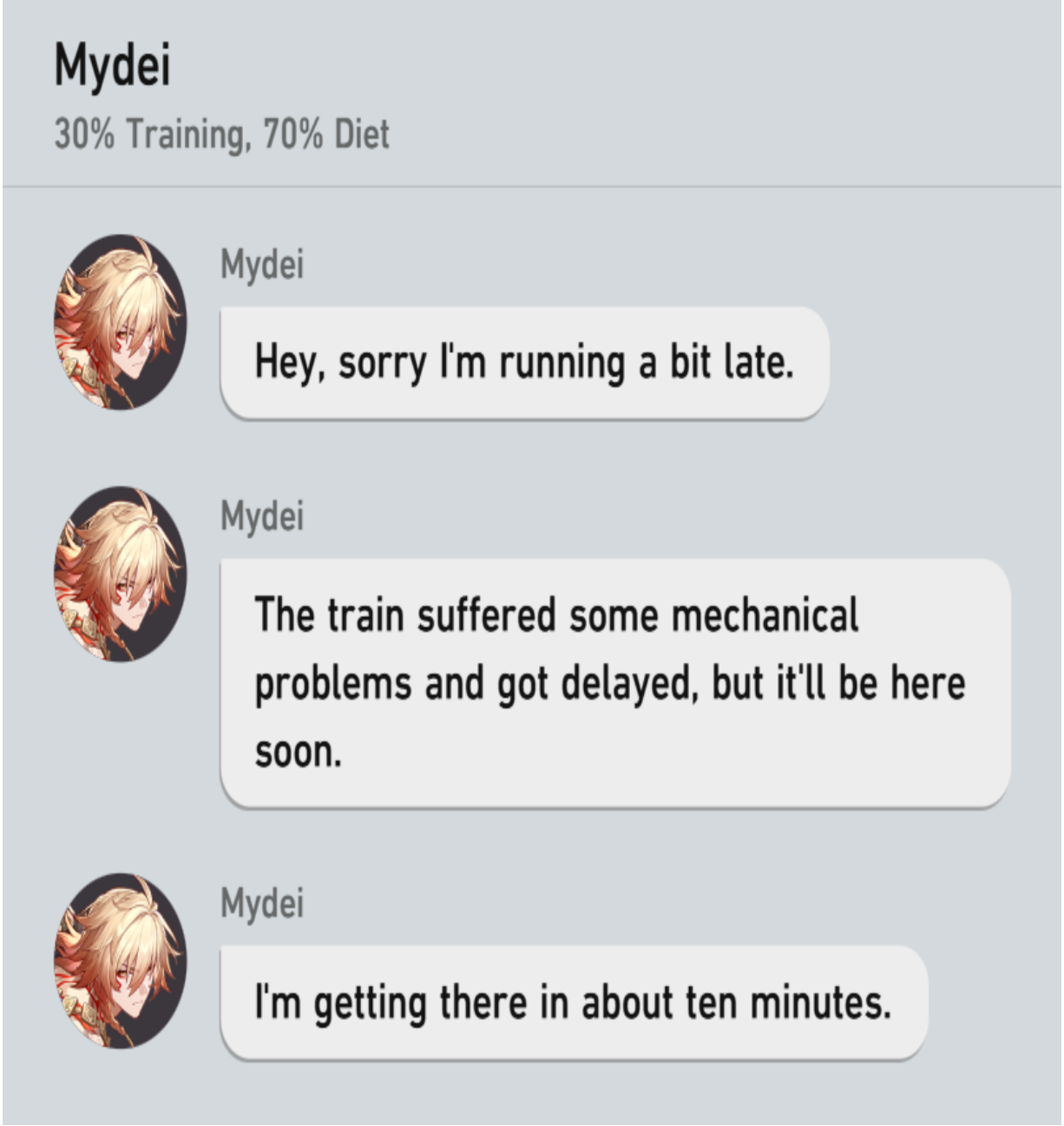
It's not a date, he reminds himself.

It's not a date. It's obviously not a date. Just a friendly hang out.

But then just why on earth is he so nervous?

He forces his legs to still and takes a deep breath. If he checked himself in the mirror more than usual, or sprayed far more cologne on him than possibly necessary, then it's because he did it without realizing. Why else? Surely not because it's a date, *because it's not*.

His phone buzzes in his pocket and he takes it out faster than one could blink.



▶

Phainon lets out a relieved sigh. While he's been looking forward to seeing Mydei, this gives him enough time to compose himself.

"Is there anything you need help with, sir?" asks the lady from the booth, giving him a concerned look.

He suddenly feels very self aware. "I'm just waiting for someone. Don't worry."

When she returns his nervous smile with a knowing one, he feels even more embarrassed. "I see."

"It's not a date," he blurts out, defensively. The lady merely quirks a brow, an amused glint on her eyes. Thankfully, she says nothing else and pretends to be busy counting coins.

He wishes nothing else than for the ground to open and swallow him whole.

Just what is wrong with him? Phainon bites his inner cheek in frustration. He's hardly been able to take Mydei off his mind ever since he stayed over, and he wishes he could explain why. Was it the physical closeness? The way Mydei had looked so flustered when his food got praised? Maybe it's how his soft sleeping face awakened in him a tenderness that he didn't know possible. How comfortable he felt occupying Phainon's space like it was his own.

He forces himself to push away those thoughts when he feels his face growing hot again. He's useless, and will lamely have to give his sister a call only to get mercilessly teased to death. What a life.

During the arduous ten minutes or so that follow his inner turmoil, Phainon mindlessly scrolls through the puppy videos his social media so kindly provides in an attempt to distract himself. It barely works, but it's enough for him to cool off.

He quickly puts away his phone when the corner of his eye catches the honey mane he's now so fond of. The sight alone is almost enough to send him into a panic again: he's wearing a simple leather jacket and a pair of loose ripped jeans, but what catches his eye is the tight shirt enveloping his chest. Gods above, he can see the outline of his pecs if he squints hard enough— actually, no, he doesn't even need to squint. He can see them just fine.

He audibly gulps when he meets Mydei's piercing eyes, who just look at him curiously. "Something wrong?" he asks, extending a hand.

Phainon takes it nervously. "You're, like, smoking hot," he tries. Mydei blinks, and he immediately regrets his existence. "I mean, you look *cool*. Like, super cool."

Mydei folds his arms. "I'll take it. Thank you." He must notice Phainon's embarrassment, for he quickly changes the topic: "Did you buy the tickets?"

"I was waiting for you," he answers, clearing his throat. When he dares to turn his gaze towards the lady, he tries to look unbothered. "So, uh, how much for two tickets?"

She's not even trying to hide her smirk. "That would be ten thousand credits. Though, we do have a ten percent discount for couples. How about it?"

Phainon blushes furiously. "Uh. We're not—"

"We'll take it," says Mydei, leaning against the counter. He then turns to look at Phainon, squinting his eyes. "Right?"

He avoids his gaze and smiles awkwardly at the girl. "We're not a couple. It wouldn't be right." He tries not to grimace when Mydei stomps his foot.

She shrugs. "Suit yourself."

After paying the *rightful* amount of money, they finally make it inside the park. Once they're out of earshot, Phainon turns to look at him.

"What was that about? Do you want us to go to jail for fraud?"

Mydei rolls his eyes. "*She* offered, even though we are *evidently* not a couple." Phainon ignores the awkward twist of his belly at the fact and says nothing. "Plus, she's working for probably not even minimum wage. Do you really think she cares?"

Phainon pouts. "Probably not. But still. I'd feel bad."

With a sigh, Mydei playfully punches him in the arm. "I know. Anyway, where do you wanna head first?"

Phainon immediately regains his grin as he points to the rollercoaster. "There, of course."

"Right." Mydei purses his lips. "Are we sure these things are safe?"

"They better be. But, well, if they're not, at least we'll die together."

"How reassuring."

Phainon lets out a short giggle. "Sorry, I'm just messing with you. Yes, these are safe, don't worry. I made sure to run a background check."

Mydei nods."Alright. Then let's go."

They make their way to the long line in silence, and the air is thankfully not hot enough for the sun to be a bother as they wait in place. Phainon's eyes go up as they wander through the rails. This close, it looks a lot bigger. He swallows nervously as his stomach contorts inside of him.

He's pulled back when Mydei snorts next to him. He's looking at him mockingly. "Having cold feet, Deliverer? It's still not too late to backtrack."

Phainon plays it cool. "No need to project yourself, Mydeimos."

"Please. Do you know why Kremnos is such a touristic destination?" Phainon tries to think of something, but ultimately shakes his head. "Well, it's because of the various intense activities it offers. It's considered paradise for adrenaline seekers."

"That so? Then you should definitely take me there someday." The comment comes off flirty in a way Phainon hadn't intended. He ignores it for the sake of the conversation.

Mydei doesn't seem to catch it anyway. "Maybe. When I was kid, my mother and I used to go to an amusement park near my home, every weekend. We always rode the same coaster, no matter how much time we

had to stand in line. I don't remember if I was even tall enough to be riding it, but no employee seemed to actually care."

Phainon feels himself smiling widely at the mental image of a little and always stubborn Mydei bypassing security just like that. "That sounds cool. Back in my hometown, all we had was a cargo train that occasionally stopped by. And whenever it did, my sister would drag me and we'd sneak into one of the cars. Our parents grounded us for months every time, but it was worth it."

"You have a sister? It's the first time you mention her," Mydei says, quirking a brow.

"Yep. Older by three years, but still somehow more childish than me for some things. She will deny it, of course," he answers, and immediately pulls out his phone to look for a photo. He finds one he's particularly fond of —it displays them both in the airport when she left for college, their eyes clearly puffy— and shows it to Mydei. "Her name is Cyrene. I think you two would get along, given that you share the same passion for making fun of me."

Mydei snorts at that and leans in to see better. "She's beautiful."

Phainon sighs. "Oh, I know that much. Back when we were both in high school, countless of guys tried to be friends with me only to score with her. Little did they know, she's for the girls only." He turns to look at Mydei as he pockets his phone, and he's smiling strangely. "What is it?"

"You two actually look very alike," he says.

"What? Really?" He blinks, utterly confused. He can't really see it. Then something clicks. "Wait, are you calling me beautiful?"

Mydei rolls his eyes. "That's not what I said."

"You said she is beautiful and that we look very alike. So that means I'm beautiful too."

"That's a bit of an overinterpretation, don't you think?"

"Oh. So you're saying I'm ugly, then." He forces a deep sigh.

Mydei opens his eyes very wide. "I didn't say that either."

He feigns hurt and pouts. "Am I ugly, Mydei?"

"You're definitely not ugly."

"So I'm beautiful."

"I don't know if that's the word."

"Horrendous, then."

"Hot," Mydei ultimately blurts out, snapping his lips shut as soon as the word leaves his mouth.

Phainon opens his in surprise. "Really?"

His cheeks are tainted a pretty shade of pink, despite the frown he now wears. "What are you acting shocked for?"

"Oh, nothing. I know I'm irresistible, but I wasn't expecting you to take the bait," he says, all too smugly to mask his own fluster.

"You know what? I actually can't wait to meet your sister to torment you." He sounds so definitive about it Phainon can't help but feel fuzzy.

"I can't wait either." Mydei squints and he laughs short. "Anyway. Do you have siblings?"

"Only child. My father always made sure to remind me I was a handful, enough for them to decide that they didn't need more than one kid."

"Ah. No wonder you're such a brat," Phainon notes, entirely serious. Mydei's eye twitches, much to his delight.

By this point, the line has already moved quite a lot. He notices with a gulp that they're up once the next cart comes back.

Mydei must sense his unease, for he bumps their shoulders together. "Relax. Remember, if this thing goes down, we are dying together."

Phainon snorts at his own words being used against him. "It's been a while since I've been to a coaster. Will you hold my hand if I get scared?"

"Oh, *baby*."

"Woah. Are we in pet name territory now?"

Mydei grimaces. "I meant it as an insult."

"If you insist, *babe*."

"I'm never going out with you again."

Phainon lets out a giggle that quickly dies down when a cart comes to a halt just in front of them. The people getting off are pale as paper, hair in all the wrong places. A lady quickly makes her way to a trashcan. He can't help but start feeling a bit nauseous himself at the sight.

Once they are seated together and the security bars come down, Phainon begins panicking.

"Oh. Fuck. I'm gonna throw up. I need to get off this thing."

Mydei gives him a pointed look, though he's also breathing faster. "It's the adrenaline starting to kick in. You'll be fine."

"What if I get a heart attack and die?"

He slaps his arm. "I'm gonna need you to shut up."

"But—"

"Everybody strapped in?" asks one of the employees.

He starts checking every bar, pushing them up. Once he's made sure everything is alright, he steps out of the cart and Phainon takes a deep breath.

"This was your idea," Mydei says.

And just as he's about to retort, they are launched. Phainon barely registers the speed at which they set off, but he does scream. He barely breathes in, all the air escaping his lungs with every yell, but the feeling of emptiness in his gut quickly turns into raw excitement— yet even amidst all the thrill, he doesn't forget about his companion. He manages to turn his head to look at Mydei, and while he's not screaming, he's laughing openly, without a care in the world. And if he had a breath to spare, Phainon is sure it would've caught on his throat at the sight.

He can't ponder on it much as his head hangs upside down in a turn and he's forced to straighten his gaze, leaving his eyes feeling a little disappointed at the change of scenery.

Just after, the cart slows down as it begins the steep climb. He takes this opportunity to catch his breath, and he turns to Mydei as he does— the latter is no longer smiling, lips instead pressed together in a thin line.

"You okay?" Phainon asks, still a little breathless.

"I hate drops," is what Mydei responds, shutting his eyes closed.

"Want me to hold your hand?" Phainon offers, half-teasing half-serious.

"I don't need such thing." Yet his hands tightly grip the bar, making the foam sink a little.

"Suit yourself," he mumbles just as they finally reach the top.

Phainon would love to admire the landscape, but the cart starts racing down before he can even take it in— the air gets sucked out of his ribcage once more, and he's giggling as the breeze combs his hair backwards, all the effort he put into taming it gone to waste. Next to him, Mydei lets out one

single terrified scream that lasts until they are back to surface level, and he notes with amusement that his eyes remain closed until the cart finally stops.

They both take a deep breath when the bars go up, and Mydei is the first one to get off. Phainon follows right after, with a little bit of struggle as his center of balance hasn't quite stabilized yet.

"Boy, that was fun," it's the first thing he says as they walk out the ride towards nothing in particular.

"The drop was horrendous. Too steep for my liking," Mydei adds, turning his body to face Phainon. He looks pale, and his hair is messed up in a way that somehow makes him look even prettier. "My pick now?"

"Sure. Where to?"

"I wanna check out the games. You know, those that are absolutely rigged," he says, starting to move in the direction a wooden sign points to.

"So you admit they are rigged and want to give it a shot anyway?" comes Phainon's lighthearted question. Not that he blames him. He falls for the same dirty tricks himself.

"Well, that's the thing. They can never get *me*." He smirks confidently at Phainon, and he raises a brow. "My mother taught me all the ways to cheat the cheater. Works like a charm every time."

"She sounds like a very interesting woman," he says. For some reason, he has the feeling that Mydei takes his personality after her. "That aside, are you trying to challenge me?"

"Depends. Are you lucky with these things?"

Their legs stop next to a mini golf station, where a ton of very ugly plushies hang from the awning. He hums. "This one's more about skill than luck, right?"

"I guess. Still, out of all the balls they have available, only a few actually fit through the hole. And they tend to have different weights. They'll usually hand you the light ones, making it way harder than it really is."

"Out of all the things I expected you to be knowledgeable about, this wasn't among them," Phainon says with genuine astonishment.

Mydei only shrugs. "It's not that impressive, given that I used to visit amusement parks quite a lot when I was a kid."

"This might as well be your ideal date then, huh?"

Phainon does not know why he said that: in fact, he doesn't even realize he said it until the words echo inside his head. He opens and closes his mouth in quick succession, attempting to excuse himself and failing miserably, all while Mydei gives him an odd look. If Mydei now thinks of him as a weirdo —if he didn't since way before, that is— he wouldn't even blame him.

When nothing comes out his mouth, Mydei ultimately decides to save Phainon the trouble of breaking the awkward silence. "Yeah, sure. Date."

Phainon huffs, his face both embarrasingly and rightfully red. "You know what I meant."

Mydei lets out a blissful snort, albeit mortifying for him. "I get your sister. Teasing you is hilarious."

He rolls his eyes, forcing his shoulders to relax into something more casual. "I hope you know that statement makes you a bully. You are a *bully*, Mydeimos."

"Whatever you say, Deliverer. Wanna give this a shot or not?" He nods his head towards the golf course.

Phainon feels his competitive spirit ignite right on, shame forgotten. "You better swallow that cockiness after I win." Perhaps he's barking too much. He hasn't played golf in his life.

Mydei ignores him and instead approaches the worker. "Good afternoon. Are these included in the ticket, or do we have to pay an additional cost?"

The guy, who has apparently heard all their conversation, points obnoxiously to a small cardboard with a price list. "Additional cost. Check them out yourself."

Mydei turns to look at him. "You okay with it?"

"Of course," he answers without even checking the prices himself. No matter. He has money to spare.

The guy counts the billets with bored eyes before handing them a pair of golf sticks, alongside five balls each. "Y'know the rules already. Just stand in that red circle. May the best win." He says it so depressingly it almost takes the joy out of Phainon.

Mydei steps into the circle before Phainon even gets the chance to blink. He looks too confident for his liking. "Don't take this too personally, yeah?" is what he says.

Phainon hits his ribs with a playful punch —that would nevertheless be enough for anybody else to lose their balance— and snorts when Mydei lets out a grumble. "You better not lose too easily, or I'm going to laugh really hard."

He shakes his head and Phainon steps back to give him space, eyes glued to his hand placement over the stick. As expected, his first play is flawless and the ball falls into the hole. The second is not, as Mydei puts too much force into the swing (cursing under his breath, of course). He manages both the third and fourth. Fails the fifth by a mere inch.

"Three out of five for the gentleman," says the guy. Phainon does not know why he's acting involved, but whatever. He can be the referee.

Mydei looks mildly satisfied as he folds his arms and steps aside. "That's an easy score to beat. Can you?"

He's really not feeling too confident. "Hell yes."

Phainon mimics Mydei's grasp on the stick and positions himself. Then, he swings his arm gently—or so he thinks, until the ball goes straight past the hole and over to the end of the course. He frowns.

"The fuck?"

"I told you the balls are light. You aren't supposed to give it more than a little push."

He hums. "You're such an honorable rival, Mydei. I might actually feel a little bad if I win."

"I doubt you will if you keep swinging the stick like that," comes Mydei's simple retort.

Right. Phainon clears his throat and goes at it again— he gives the ball a little push with the stick, and the damned thing barely moves now. He sighs deeply.

"So, we're looking at a tie," Mydei points out. "That, or I'm the unsurprising victor."

Phainon shrugs as he puts another ball on the tee. "I can take a tie. We can settle it with another game, yeah?"

Mydei says nothing to that, standing next to the employee. He takes a breath and swings the stick very softly, trying to measure his strength as best as possible and, thankfully, the ball falls into the hole. Phainon lets out a whistle while Mydei hums from his position. He repeats the same movement for the other two balls and successfully manages to score three out of five, too.

"An undeniable tie." The employee now looks a little less sad, probably because they're done with the game. He eyes them both head to toe, and nods to himself. "You two are quite bulky men. Want to settle it? There's an arm wrestling station just a few steps from here. You just follow the path

and turn right. There's always a bunch of people, so you'll catch it quickly. Enjoy yourselves!"

He takes the sticks out of their hands, but they barely register it, only exchanging a look. Phainon's neck tingles with excitement when Mydei turns around and exits the small course, his legs trailing just behind.

They follow the guy's direction and soon enough they reach the place, signaled only by a poorly drawn illustration of two guys arm wrestling. It is indeed fairly crowded, but no person in the bunch looks like they could take either of them. They exchange another look.

"Wouldn't it be kinda unfair for them?" Phainon asks, nodding to a large group of teenagers in line.

Mydei scoffs. "Most of these kids are far too cocky for their own good. They'll either learn a thing or two or accept defeat gracefully."

To that he laughs. "Are they even worth it?"

"If they don't chicken out, sure. I used to get into a lot of brawls myself when I was a kid," he pauses, and a fond smile takes over his lips. Phainon's chest almost misses a beat. "Funnily enough, me and those boys ended up becoming friends after middle school. To this day, even, though we don't see each other as much for obvious reasons."

Phainon hums thoughtfully. "So violence is just your love language, then."

Mydei scowls. Phainon laughs openly.

"Alright, sorry. Maybe you could introduce us sometime. And I could introduce you to my friends," he says giddily, already imagining it. "You already know Cas. There's also Cipher and the express quartet." Mydei raises a brow, and Phainon waves him off. "They come like a package. Don't mind it. But, anyway, they are great."

"I wouldn't mind it. Though I'm not too sure you'd get along."

"Why not? They're your friends. I'm your friend."

For some reason unbeknownst to Phainon, Mydei flushes a little. "It's different."

Phainon tilts his head in confusion. He's curious, really, but he wouldn't want to pry either. So he backs up and changes the topic.

"Well, I trust you know better. Anyway, are we signing up with our names or what?" he asks, seeing as there's only one guy left in line before they're up.

"With what else?"

"A cool nickname, maybe."

Mydei rolls his eyes, but Phainon knows by now that he's actually supressing a laugh. "You don't get to talk about nicknames, *Delivering Dawn*."

"I don't see how that's an insult. It's a great username. Where's your whimsy, Mydei?"

"*Deliverer* is a great nickname. And I came up with it."

"I'm actually curious about that. Why do you never call me by my name? You only did, like, once."

Just as Mydei is about to answer, a third voice joins the conversation. "You participating or not, lads?"

They both turn to the lady at the booth and mutter some half-assed apologies before signing up —with their real names, per Mydei's request— and walking towards the circle that's formed around the table. They watch the match with folded arms, as if studying the situation: truly, there's nothing particularly interesting about it other than the fact it ends in less than a minute.

The teens walk away, faces red —out of the effort or embarrassment, Phainon does not know— and the ref forces out a half-mocking laugh.

"That wasn't too exciting now, was it?" No one laughs. She shifts uncomfortably and clears her throat. "Well. Who wants to go next?"

Phainon and Mydei immediately raise their hand alongside some other unlucky contestants that are widely ignored once she sees them. Her gaze shifts between them and the rest of the public, and then proceeds to smile awkwardly. "I believe there's a bit of an imbalance here, gentlemen. You wouldn't mind going against each other, right?"

They eagerly sit at the table, feeling all pair of eyes on them. They're staring, no doubt. Phainon gives the girl a thumbs up. "That was the plan. Thank you, miss."

She flushes a little and waves him off. "Just doing my job. Get ready to start, yes?"

Mydei gives her a quick nod as he takes off his jacket, exposing his deliciously toned arms for everyone to see. Phainon does the same with his own, though his eyes never really leave Mydei's body. Objectively speaking, it's too good a view not to admire. If anything, everybody else seems to think alike, if the way they are not so discreetly looking is anything to go by.

An uncomfortable *something* tugs at his chest. He ignores it.

They put their arms in position, and he makes sure to lock eyes with Mydei as they brusquely clasp their hands together— and unlike what he had expected —not that he was thinking about it—, Mydei's palms are actually not so rough; definitely not soft either, some calluses here and there, but not enough for it not to feel soft around his. Warm. Pleasant.

"You keep zoning off and this won't last more than a few seconds," Mydei suddenly says, snapping him out of his involuntary reverie.

Phainon decides to keep his mouth shut for this one time, for he has no retort.

The referee stands right next to them with a mic in hand, and wiggles her eyebrows. "Are you ready?" They both nod their heads, holding their gaze. "Three—"

They don't even wait for the countdown to finish before they start wrestling each other. It's surprising how easily Phainon adjusts to the pressure Mydei is applying to his own hand, forcing it back with a force that would knock anyone else off their feet. Phainon is, of course, not just anyone else. Mydei is very much aware of it, Phainon knows by the way he doesn't look impressed at all.

Despite the fact that he wants to taunt him, or just say anything at all —his tongue is restless, he knows—, he chooses to save every breath he takes in for himself. This is unlike any other arm wrestling match he's participated in, and those are a handful: even though he's putting all he has into it, Mydei's arm barely budges, twitching ever so slightly due to his own struggling.

It excites him to no end.

Mydei's brows furrow in concentration when Phainon squeezes his hand a little tighter, letting out a small grunt. "*Haikas*."

Phainon will have to ask him about that later. Right now, his focus is entirely on the ripple of Mydei's muscles and his sweaty palms, the way he's now slightly angling his body to better counter his own push. Phainon does the same.

He doesn't really know how long they're at it, loosening and tightening their grip in a fruitless attempt to gain some advantage over the other, until the girl speaks up. "It's been five minutes, you all! And they're barely breaking a sweat! Are these guys our universe's Batman and Superman?"

Phainon hears it all like background noise, too lost in Mydei's face to care, but he catches the audience loudly whispering to each other. "Putting on a great show, are we?" he manages between breaths, attempting a grin despite the burn on his arm. Mydei only gives him a look through his stupidly long lashes and grits his teeth.

He reasons that he won't receive as much as a peek from Mydei, so he keeps his mouth shut. His arm is just about to give in, but he know Mydei's is too— so he must seize an opportunity as quickly as possible. Phainon takes advantage of his now weak grip to push with a little more force and try to create an opening for himself.

And it's working fantastically.

Until Mydei groans soundly.

It goes straight to Phainon's dick, and only then he realizes he's hard.

Before he can even blink, his arm is being roughly slammed against the wooden table. It should hurt, maybe, but he's too numb to feel anything at all.

He just stares.

Mydei releases his hand like it burns and stretches his fingers, letting out a relieved sigh as he does so. "Fucking finally. I thought you'd never give in."

Phainon wants to retort that he didn't really. But he chooses to return Mydei's smirk instead. "You know my forte is my lower body." And it just betrayed him just like that. He quickly thinks of any turn off. Recalls embarrassing experiences from high school. The family dog, Mem. His dead grandparents. Sad, staged videos of social media. Puppies.

A loud round of applause forces him out of his head. The girl is holding Mydei's arm up, grinning amply as she talks into her mic. "So, Mydei. What's your secret? Are you a wrestler? A boxer? I really want to know."

Phainon can't help a giggle when he blushes a little at the question, his little problem suddenly turned irrelevant when Mydei is looking this shy. "I'm actually a chef."

The crowd all do surprised noises, and Phainon folds his arms. "He's a *great* chef, that I can testify."

Mydei shots him a look for feeding the conversation. He shrugs innocently.

The girl asks him a few more irrelevant questions that he answers very briefly before she ultimately lets him off the hook, though rather begrudgingly.

As they walk away, Phainon gives one glance back. "I think she liked you."

"I think she just wanted to get off her job for a little longer," Mydei objects.

Phainon snorts. He's still moving stiffly on instinct, but he can thankfully no longer feel his boner. "You're so modest I might sob a little."

Mydei rolls his eyes. "Sure thing. What do you wanna do now?"

Phainon quickly pulls out his phone to check the time. "It's barely five. C'mon, let's settle some more scores."

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The rest of the evening is spent in a similar rythm, alternating between casual games and rides and, of course, slipping silly competitions wherever and whenever they could: they even betted on who screamed the less in the haunted house —which Phainon surprisingly won by a landslide— and who managed to keep their eyes open for the longest on the frisbee —Mydei won, naturally—; the ring toss, darts, knock down and bowling were all ties. Phainon is growing more and more accustomed to the phenomenon, really.

By the time the sun sets, they're well spent and have one plushie each— Mydei's is a white and blue seal, while Phainon's is a lion. They are, admittedly, very ugly, but Phainon already holds his dear; when he pointed out its resemblance to Mydei, though, he had looked genuinely offended.

While they queue for the ferris wheel, he squishes the seal's face with his hand. "This one kinda looks like me. See? I have a plushie of you while you have one of me."

Mydei grimaces down at the lion and then at the seal. "Your self esteem can't possibly be this low."

It kinda is, but whatever. "Hey. The seal is very cute. Just like me."

"Not falling for the same trick twice." Mydei elbows him and Phainon lets out a dramatic sigh. Then, Mydei spins his head around as if he just remembered something. "Hey, by the way. Thanks a bunch for lending me your account. It's proven to be my newest entertainment when I have free time."

Phainon blinks and then blushes for no real reason. "Oh, that. That was nothing." He scratches the back of his neck awkwardly and then remembers something himself. *Right*. "But. If you really want to thank me, maybe we could do that cooking showdown we talked about?" It comes out unsure, maybe even coy. He mentally slaps himself for it.

Mydei tilts his head, a subtle smile tugging at his lips. "Are you sure you want to do this, Deliverer? That win is not one I'm going to be able to brag about, you know."

"I mean. You can guide me through it. Maybe I'm a natural." He definitely is not, something long ago proven by his failed attempts at baking with Cyrene. But he won't say that out loud. The prospect of Mydei guiding his every step in something he's so amazingly good at fills him with a raw and unfamiliar excitement he doesn't really want to name just yet.

Unaware of his thoughts, Mydei hums. "If you don't mind it, then I'm absolutely down for it. But remember what I said back at your place. We're doing it at mine."

Phainon raises a brow. "It's gonna be a live stream. Are you sure?"

Mydei shrugs. "Yeah. I don't care all that much if people see my kitchen. Not like I'm home that much anyway," he says.

Phainon nods and with that they fall back into quiet, accompanied only by the bustle of the people still in the fair; even as they climb into the cabin, he doesn't feel the need to speak up, like he usually does. It's odd, how quickly he has grown accustomed to Mydei despite being so different yet also

identical in so many ways. It's weird to have such presence, he notes. But far from unpleasant.

He doesn't want to name it. Not really.

The familiar sound of Mydei's voice startles him. "Okhema is a beautiful city."

Phainon blinks, a little taken aback at the iniciative. He quickly recovers and smiles, following Mydei's gaze; they aren't that high up, but they are high enough for the buildings and skyscrapers in downtown to be fairly visible. "It is. I had an incredibly hard time adjusting. I mean, Aedes Elysiae is a *very* small town. The switch up from small houses to glass buildings of at least fifteen floors each was not easy to process. Like, back home I only had to walk a block or even less to get whatever I needed. Here it's a completely different story."

Mydei laughs softly. It's different, new. Phainon makes sure to carve it well into his memory bank.

"Kremnos is a huge city, and I'd say even bigger than Okhema. It often reminds me to it," he says, voice heavy.

"Getting homesick?" Phainon asks, turning to look at him.

Mydei mimics him, eyes meeting his. There's something almost indecipherable in his face, and Phainon wants nothing but to unravel it. "What is homesickness to you?" he asks.

Phainon purses his lips. "Nostalgia. Missing your place, I suppose."

"I wouldn't call it homesickness, then. Kremnos was my home, but not one I'd go back to." There's a long beat. Phainon says nothing, trying to communicate with his eyes what he can't with his words. Mydei looks away, doubt written all over his face. "I don't even know why I felt the need just now to talk about this."

"You don't need a reason. If there's anything you want to talk about, whatever it is, I'm your guy." He gives a lame thumbs up, but it serves its purpose of lifting Mydei's face a little. He smiles, small but very much visible. That's enough for him.

Mydei sighs. "Every other month I get this sudden rush of nostalgia that reminds me of my childhood for all the wrong reasons. My father was an asshole. Always there, somehow never there. There's too much to unpack about that man, if you could even call him that, but nothing worth mentioning. He can rot." His words are laced in venom, and Phainon feels his own face hardening as a mirror to Mydei's. He takes a deep breath before speaking up again: "My mother, though... I couldn't have asked for a better woman to raise me into who I am." He smiles fondly. "She passed when I was twelve."

Phainon's brows contort into a frown. "... I'm sorry, Mydei."

He waves him off. "It's fine. That wound has long closed, and I remember her with nothing but adoration and respect. My point is, Kremnos stopped being a home for me the moment I no longer had my mother with me. And Okhema hasn't really felt like it much, either. Not until recently." Mydei pauses for a moment. Phainon holds his breath. "All of my close friends stayed back at Kremnos, and here I didn't really have anybody asides Castorice and some barely reliable colleagues. You know. All I'm saying is that I'm glad to have you as a friend. Whatever it is that means."

Phainon finds nothing but sincerity in those honeyed eyes of his. He finds himself laughing softly before he can even register it. "That's quite the bomb to drop in a ferris wheel, don't you think?"

Mydei gives him a middle finger, but he's smiling nevertheless. "Fuck you. I'm never telling you shit again."

Though he attempts to hold it back, he laughs soundly. Mydei snorts. "You know I'm just messing with you. If you want me to be serious, I can be it."

"I like it the way it is," is all Mydei answers, looking through the glass. They must be around the fifth spin, their cabin halted just at the top. He

sighs. "I suppose Okhema does have its charm."

Phainon leans his head against the metal, but he refuses to tear his gaze away from Mydei's face. It's hypnotic. It shouldn't be.

"It really does," he finally says after a beats of silence.

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When Phainon makes it to his apartment, it's well past nine. He only checks with Mydei to make sure he also got home safe before he searches for another contact in his long list, sitting on the same couch he shared with Mydei only but a couple weeks ago.

His feet tap the floor anxiously. The call is picked up after a few seconds pass.

"My, you never call this late. Is everything alright?"

"I need advice with something."

She hums disapprovingly. "Of course, that's the only reason you ever deign to call your big sis."

He sighs. "I *think* I have feelings for someone."

There's a long stretch of silence before she chirps up again, tone shifting into something giddier: "Tell me all about it."

Phainon looks down at the red lion for support, but it does nothing to ease his nerves. "I won't bore you with the details, but—"

"Oh, please do bore me with the details."

"It's unnecessary."

"It's absolutely necessary. If you want my help, I need the full context." He can almost sense the scolding through her voice. "Plus, if my baby brother is about to date, I want the details."

He groans in embarrassment. "Don't— Don't put it like that yet."

"Gee, alright. So?"

"So... Castorice introduced me to one of her friends. You know how I was, and still am, obsessed with Amphorean Chronicles?" She only hums in acknowledgment, so he proceeds: "Well, this guy turned out to be as obsessed as me. And, you know. I invited him to my channel and we ended up doing a long ass stream. We're friends since."

He hears some noise, and he can only assume Cyrene is pulling out her laptop to stalk his Genesis account.

"And now you're catching feelings?"

"That's the thing, I don't know. He just sets me off. Not in a negative way, just— just does. He's so unique. Everything feels different, somehow. Like learning things all over again."

Cyrene hums thoughtfully. "He's very handsome as well."

Phainon flushes. "Yes, I know. I know. He's the prettiest man I've ever seen. It's ridiculous. And he's hot too. I mean, we went to the gym one time, and I just couldn't stop staring."

"So. Are you attracted to him?" He hadn't wanted to admit it up to this point, but he knows it's true. So undeniably true. If anything, today's occurence had made it all the more evident— despite the mental gymnastics he did to justify that very much unwanted boner, he couldn't conclude anything that didn't put him in a position he wasn't mentally ready to acknowledge. His silence must speak volumes, for Cyrene lets out a playful giggle. "I'm taking that as a yes. Well, then, how do you feel when you're around him?"

He ponders for a moment, but ultimately decides there's no way he can put it simply. "I guess it's as if my heart doesn't know at which pace to beat. My whole body feels funny in the best way possible."

"Do you enjoy his company?"

"So, so much. He matches me in ways no one else has been able to. It's really refreshing."

"Can you see yourself seriously committing to him, flaws and everything?"

Phainon says nothing, but when Cyrene calls him name again he forces out an answer: "I don't know."

"That's fine. You don't need to know, not just yet. But it does sound to me like you have more than just a little crush," is what she finally says.

Phainon frowns, even though she can't see it. "Do I? I've had crushes before. This isn't like it at all."

"Okay. But it's not platonic either, that I can tell you." When Phainon falls quiet again, she sighs. "Hey. You don't need to have it all figured out. Just give yourself some time to think about what these feelings truly mean to you. If you think my opinion might be biased, you could ask in some online forum. What matters is that you act responsibly and consequently, yeah? You better remember all I taught you about how to treat a partner." There's some subtle severity in her tone, and Phainon smiles.

"Of course I do. I wouldn't dare to hurt him in any way."

"Good. Do you feel a bit more at ease?"

He forces his shoulders to relax. "I suppose, yeah. At least I know where to aim now. Thanks."

She giggles. "I'm that good, huh? Well, is there anything else you need of me? I was in the middle of something."

"No, it's fine. That was it. I didn't take much of your time, did I?"

"Don't worry. It's nothing too important anyway. Are you sure there's nothing else?" she asks again, cautious.

"I'm sure. Don't be too nagging."

"You called me first, brat," she retorts, and he laughs. "Since you don't appreciate my charm, I'll be hanging up. It should be late for you, anyway. Go to sleep."

He rolls his eyes fondly. "Yeah, okay, will do. Goodnight, Cyrene."

"Likewise. Love you, Phainon. Just call me if you want to talk, yes?"

"I'll be in touch. Love you too."

When she hangs up, Phainon leans back into the couch and lets out a deep breath, eyes lingering on the spot Mydei's head had been resting awkwardly. His hands had barely hesitated, then, brushing Mydei's neck gently as he put a pillow beneath it. It felt natural, somehow, like he had done it a thousand times before. He didn't question the feeling.

But if anything, he has a lot of questioning to do now.

When another sneeze resonates throughout the office, Castorice hands him the tenth tissue of the past five minutes, brows furrowed. Phainon takes it wordlessly, only nodding his head in appreciation.

"Why didn't you call in sick? You know Lady Aglaea can be flexible," she asks, adjusting her glasses.

He shrugs. "I didn't think it would get this bad." Gosh, his voice is already rough as shit. It's going to be an awful week.

She grimaces. "You really need to rest. Go home. I'll talk to her, she'll understand."

Throwing a crumpled tissue into the trashcan, he gets up from his chair, barely bothering to turn off the computer as he grabs his bag. "I'll catch her on my way out, but thanks."

"Your stubborn self isn't protesting? That's new," she muses, smiling small.

"Just keeping it real. I feel like shit." And he does. No surprise there, given that the last time he got sick was early this year.

"Be safe on your way home, Phainon. I'll cover for you."

He smiles. "Sure thing. Let me know if anything interesting happens."

She snorts and waves him off. He heads straight to Aglaea's office, his whole body feeling stupidly heavy on his legs. He really, really shouldn't have left the gym without his sweatshirt on a rainy day. How sweet are the consequences of his own actions.

He gives one soft knock on the door before he's allowed to step in: the room is rather big, but neatly organized into shelves and small piles of papers. Her eyes, though absent, pierce right through him nevertheless. There's a brief beat before she finally speaks up.

"Phainon."

Phainon smiles to himself. How does she always manage to know, *he* knows not. "Lady Aglaea."

Her brows go up, mouth twisting into an unpleasant grimace. "You sound... beaten up."

He attempts to laugh, but only manages a few coughs. "Uh, yeah. I catched a really bad cold."

"And I presume you request to go home?"

"If possible."

She hums. "How many days do you need?"

"Give me two days and I'll be back in shape like a newborn, granted."

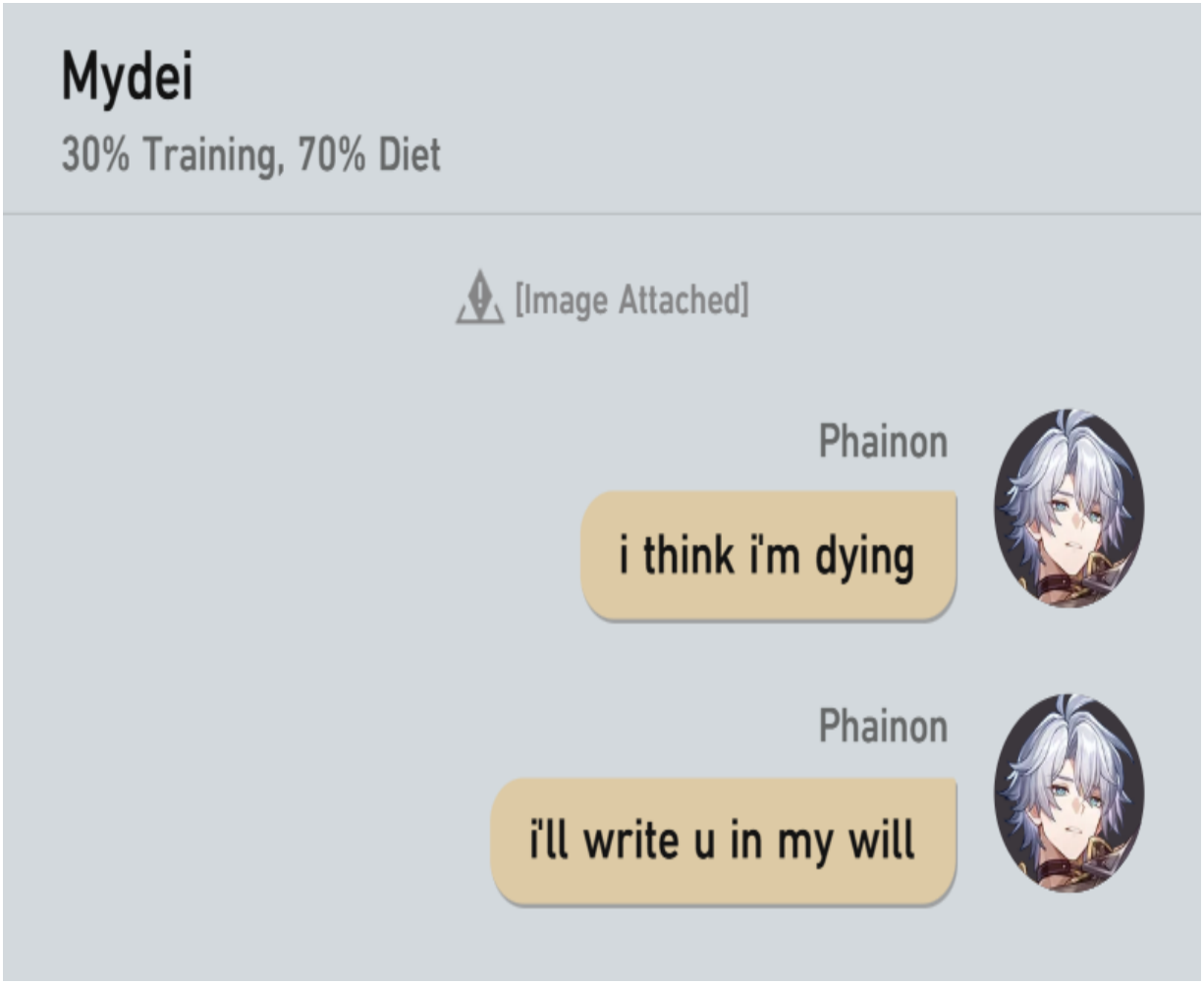
"Three days, then." Her fingers go back to the book she was reading, gaze falling. "Go. And please do rest, Phainon. Don't be the stubborn child you always are."

He'd be offended if it were anyone else saying it, but well. "Of course. Thank you very much."

She only nods her head, and he interprets it as the dismissal it is. He wastes no time calling a cab as he takes the elevator down, taking a quick peek of himself in the mirror— and to say he looks haggard is an understatement: deep dark circles under glassy eyes, skin somehow paler than usual and nose slightly red from the constant friction with the tissues. Not to mention he's starting to feel feverish, as shown in the flush on his face.

So, he looks miserable. Not flattering in the slightest. But there's a thought.

He opens the camera app on his phone and snaps a quick mirror-pic, making sure to at least catch a nice angle of his body, and sends it to Mydei before he can begin to regret it.



▶

Is that flirty? He can't tell. It's been a while since he's attempted courting somebody (if he can even call it that, because he frankly still does not know what he should do about his crush).

He pockets his phone again, as he does not expect an immediate answer: it's a monday before noon. And, *well*, it's not like he's starting to learn Mydei's schedule, but he knows he's at the bakery right now. If he wasn't feeling so bad, he may even be tempted to go buy something as an excuse to see him. Hell, he *is* really tempted to do so, but his body yearns for a bed more than anything as of right now.

Thankfully, he waits for no more than five minutes for his cab to arrive. He politely greets the driver but makes sure to sit in the back seat after, unfortunately too tired to engage in friendly conversation like he usually does. The man thankfully gets the message as he sets the volume of the music a bit higher, and Phainon leans his head against the window, greatly appreciating the cold if offers.

Still, before he can get too comfortable, his phone buzzes against his thigh. He pulls it out right away, smiling inevitably as he reads the notification.



▶

His fingers tap rapidly against the screen, childish excitement fluttering in his belly. He almost feels like a dumb teen.

Mydei

30% Training, 70% Diet

Phainon



is that what u would say to a dying man? how harsh



Mydei

Sorry, let me rephrase:



Mydei

Your face shows that you're going through a rough, rough patch



Mydei

Pardon my rudeness.

▶

He can't help a laugh that he cuts short lest the driver thinks there's something wrong with him.

Mydei

30% Training, 70% Diet

Phainon



ur funny i'll give u that

Phainon



ok srsly tho i catched a nasty cold and i feel super bad : ((



Mydei

Are you at work?

Phainon



was, now im going home to rest



Mydei

Good. That's all you need, so you better stay put.



Mydei

Take some meds too, and check your temperature every few hours.



Mydei

Try not to use your phone too much.



His smile widens as the warmth in his chest fills every drop of blood circulating throughout his body. He's so caring.

Mydei

30% Training, 70% Diet

Phainon



yes boss ty

Phainon



tho ... u know what could make me feel better rn??



Mydei

I'll let you know I sighed very loudly. But, okay.



Mydei

What?

Phainon



pic of ur face... as i just humbled myself with the one i sent

Phainon

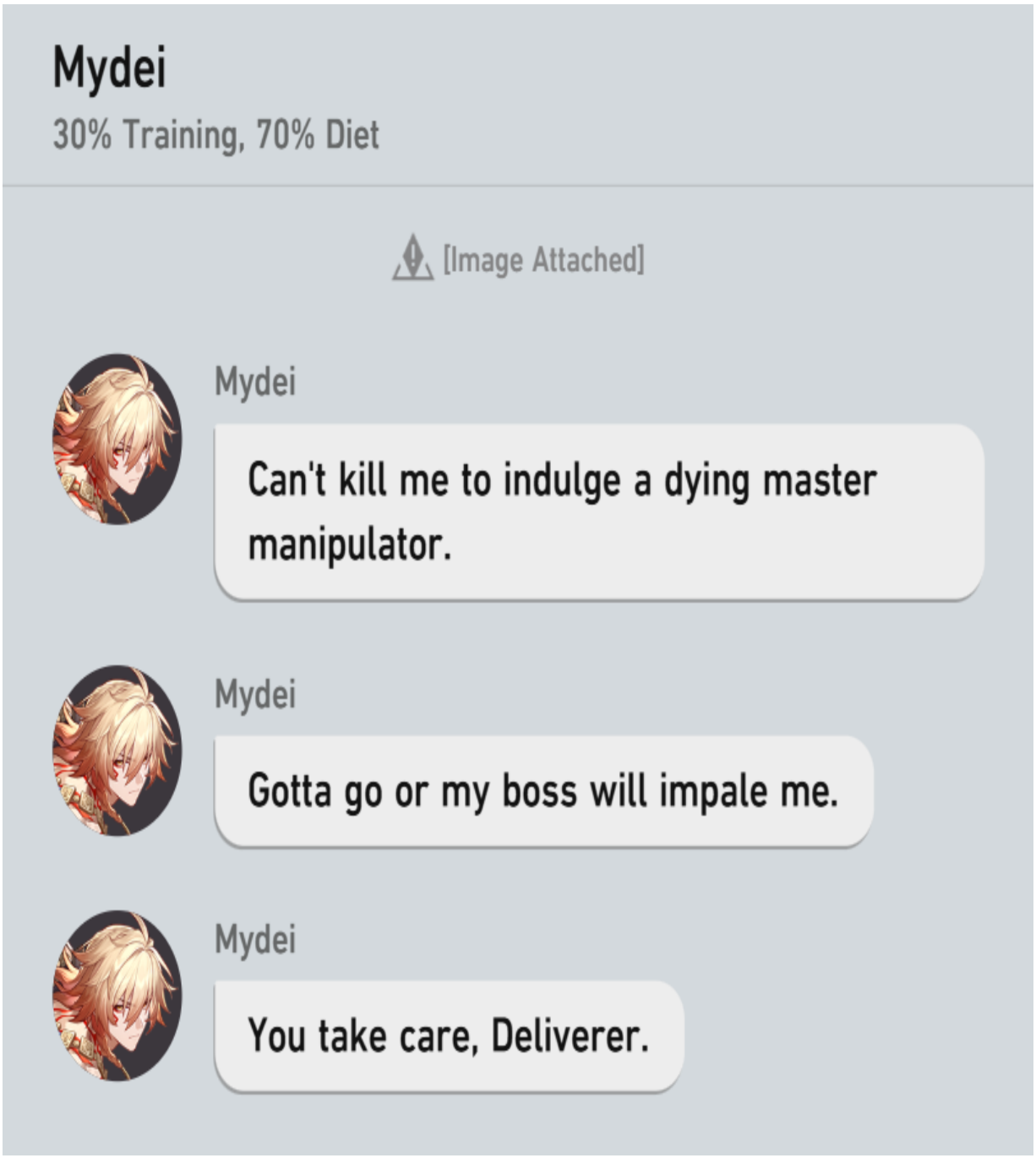


equivalent exchange :P



Bold, bold movement. If Cyrene saw him, she'd be so proud.

Three dots appear and disappear until they finally cease. Then, after less than ten seconds, a photo loads: it displays Mydei in a cooking apron —his chest should have *no* right to look so prominent— with his hair pulled back in a messy ponytail, contained in a net. He's giving a middle finger to the camera with an unimpressed expression, but Phainon catches a very faint pink tainting his cheeks. Cute.



▶

Phainon responds with a dog sticker before turning his phone off, unwipeable grin still tugging at his lips.

That *did* make him feel better. Incredibly so.

⋯⋯ • ୨ ✦ ୧ • ⋯⋯

After a blissfully long nap, Phainon wakes up to loud banging on his door.

He grunts and checks his phone: five in the afternoon. Meaning, he slept for about six hours. Still, he does not feel much better: in fact, he somehow feels worse, clothes clinging to his sweaty body and his head hurting like it hasn't in weeks. He startles when there's another knock and gets up annoyed, taking his sweet time as he puts on some comfortable dog-shaped slippers.

He doesn't even bother to check his appearance —which must qualify as more than a little disheveled— before opening the door in one big swing, barely stiffling a yawn as he does so.

And oh, how quickly he regrets his actions when he finds Mydei's gorgeous self standing on the other side.

Phainon immediately cuts his yawn short and runs a hand through his hair in a lame attempt to tame it. "Mydei!"

Of course, Mydei sees right through his apparent nonchalance, eyes squinting suspiciously. "Were you still sleeping?"

He laughs sheepishly and rubs the back of his neck. "Eh. Just napping. But it was about time I got up anyway." His eyes wander down to the bags Mydei is holding, and he nods at them. "What, brought me supplies?" he jokes.

Mydei looks very serious as he clears his throat. "Actually, yes. Can I come in?"

Phainon says nothing and steps aside to let him in.

Mydei walks over to the dining table and drops off the bags. "I got you a couple meds, just in case you're lacking. Also, I made you some chicken soup with extra protein and fiber. Turned out pretty alright, I think," he says, taking out a big airtight tupperware. "Have you eaten?"

Phainon blinks, a little atonished. Either his brain has already been fried by the fever or he has it *bad*. Maybe it's both. But he knows for a fact that the dizziness and warmth he feels is not a product of his illness.

"You didn't have to," he forces himself to say when Mydei cocks a brow at him. "Who would've thought you're this sweet, Mydei?"

He rolls his eyes. "Just my good action of the day. Have you eaten or not?"

"Not since last night," he confesses, his stomach embarrassingly protesting in cue.

Mydei frowns. "Have you no brain? If you want to get better quickly, you need to eat. What do you have all those protein yogurts for?" If he means to sound scolding, he succeeds splendidly.

Phainon sits down in a chair, wondering if he'll ever be free of people that love nagging him. He realizes he doesn't want to be free of them.

"I wasn't hungry. But I am now. Hand me a spoon, pretty please?" He knows Mydei is immune to puppy eyes, but he tries anyway.

As expected, he only receives an unimpressed look before Mydei turns around and gives him the stunning view of his back muscles pressing against his shirt, a very much appreciated distraction. Just a few seconds later, he hands him a spoon and slides him the tupper.

"Eat just what you can, but don't force your stomach. I'll take no offense," he says, softly, sitting down in the chair in front of him.

"Don't you want some?" Phainon asks, blowing on the spoon. He hurriedly slides it into his mouth, almost burning his tongue, but also filling him with delight. It no longer surprises him that Mydei can transform the blandest of meals into something worthy of Memchelin stars, really.

Mydei smiles, supporting his chin on his hand. "I already ate before coming, thanks. Is it good?"

Phainon only gives him a look. "You know the answer to that."

"It's nice to hear anyway."

"You're such a proud parent with your food. It's cute," he points out, stiffling a giggle when Mydei blushes.

"I guess I am," is all he says in response. His free hand goes up to Phainon's forehead, fingers brushing gently against his skin. Phainon almost drops the spoon, flinching involuntarily at the cold touch. Mydei tsks. "You're burning up, Deliverer. Did you check your temperature like I told you?" He feels very embarrassed as he shakes his head, stuffing his mouth with more of the soup. Mydei sighs. "I brought some antipyretics, so you should be fine. But you're going back to bed after this."

Phainon pouts. "Ordering me around in my own home, huh?"

"Hush. It's for your own good." Phainon knows he's right, so he says nothing and keeps eating in silence. Mydei takes out a honey jar out of the bag and goes over to the kitchen, and he can only asume he's going to prepare an infusion of some sorts.

Phainon smiles, feeling rather lightheaded. He really can get used to how comfortable Mydei acts around him. It's a bliss.

Clearly, his appetite isn't big enough to finish the entire generous portion he was served, and after a few minutes of filling his stomach, he decides he's had enough. "This is really delicious, Mydei, but I'm afraid I'll have to finish it tomorrow."

From where he's standing, steaming teacup in hand, Mydei gives him an understanding nod. "That's fine. Now, to bed."

Phainon does just as told, blushing in self awareness as Mydei trails right behind him. "Uhm, my room is a mess right now, so I'm awfully sorry you'll have to see it."

"I really couldn't care less, Deliverer."

He grimaces. "Okay. No nagging, then."

Mydei does thankfully not say anything at the scattered paperwork on his desk and shirts very uncarefully thrown into the clothes-designated chair. He leaves the teacup on his nightstand and immediately turns to Phainon, who can only let out a pleased sigh as his aching bones hit the matress. Mydei shakes his head and helps him with the blankets until he's perfectly tucked in.

He takes the spoon out of the teacup and places it gently on the plate. "This infusion will make you feel a bit less like you've been ran over by a bus, so drink it. Not too fast, though. Small sips."

Phainon snorts. "That's one way to put it, yes."

"I'll go get you an ice pack and some water. Stay put."

Phainon nods, gaze lingering over Mydei's figure as he steps out his bedroom. Physically, he still very much feels like garbage. Emotionally, though, he feels better than ever. Is it the Mydei effect combining with his state of vulnerability? Probably. The man is so stunning that a mere glance at him would be enough to make any sick man feel hopeful again, really. But it goes beyond that, and he knows it very well. Because he's so caring, so gentle without even trying hard.

And he's given Cyrene's advice a lot of thought, he truly has. But there's no way he can name it. Anything he comes up with feels unfitting but the one word he doesn't dare to consider yet.

It's just so, *so* unfair how Mydei has managed to spin his world around in a matter of months. How he's made him feel things he knows for a fact no one else will be able to. How perfectly flawed he is.

Phainon forces that train of thought to halt when the object of his affections walks back in, a pack of frozen strawberries in one hand and a glass of water in the other.

Mydei frowns, placing the glass right next to the teacup. "You okay?"

Curse his sharpness. "As okay as a man on his deathbed can be," he jokes, coughing dramatically.

He sighs. "You're fine, then. Here," he hands him a small pill alongside the water glass. Phainon swallows it down without even asking what is is. "You should feel better with that. Now lay down."

Phainon does just that, and Mydei puts the cold bag on his forehead. He hisses at the uncomfortable sensation.

"Stay still. Also, the med I just gave you works with one dose every eight hours, so..." he pauses to check the time on his wrist watch, "you need to take the next one at two in the morning. Need me to set an alarm for you?"

He shakes his head, grabbing his phone to do it himself. He is quick with it, not wanting to miss a second of Mydei's gorgeous features. He smiles up at him. "Thank you a million, Mydei. You really didn't have to bother with all this."

He gives him a small smile back. "It's fine, Deliverer. Need anything else before I head out?"

Phainon purses his lips. Opens his mouth only to close it right after. Then, "Don't you want to stay?"

Mydei pauses for a moment, then shakes his head. "You must rest."

"I can rest. I just." He cuts himself off, and sheepishly looks away. "I'd appreciate the company, is all."

Phainon can't bring himself to meet Mydei's gaze, feeling very ridiculous. He's being selfish, yes, stupidly so. But he'd love to indulge in Mydei's presence for a little longer. For as long as he allows him, really. A few seconds pass —though it feels more like several minutes, in Phainon's opinion— before he feels the matress sinking by the edge.

"Alright. But you need to sleep."

Phainon finally dares to look at him. "I already slept. I'm not tired."

"That's what you think. Your body will give in eventually," is what Mydei says, folding his arms as he angles his torso to properly look at him. Great heavens. How he wishes to drown in those pecs.

Phainon tells himself that's the fever talking.

He's about to say something snarky, if only to occupy his treacherous mind with something else, but a thought suddenly hits him. He uselessly covers his mouth, eyebrows shooting up. "*Wait*. Am I not a walking biohazard right now?"

Mydei snorts. "If it's contagious, you probably already gave me your bug. But I very rarely get sick, if ever, so I think I'll survive."

Phainon gives him a concerned look, but lowers his hands with a defeated sigh when Mydei only blinks in response. "Don't jinx it. But in that case," he clears his throat, a proposition he might regret just in the tip of his tongue, "don't you wanna lay down with me? I mean, your back's gonna hurt in that position."

Mydei doesn't look creeped out, *thank God*, and only raises a curious brow. "With outside clothes?"

He smiles, half-relieved and half-triumphant, patting the empty space next to him. Getting a queen sized bed *was* a smart move after all. "I gotta change the sheets anyway."

Mydei seems to ponder for only a split second before ultimately taking off his shoes and climbing into the bed, sliding beneath the covers at a safe enough distance not to touch but enough for Phainon to feel the heat emanating from his body. He can unfortunately not really tilt his head to look at him due to the pack on his forehead, so he bores holes into the ceiling instead and mourns the sight he just lost. Next to him, Mydei does the same, sighing deeply.

Phainon smiles. "Something troubling you?"

A beat. "Not really."

"Oh. But there's something, then?"

Though Phainon can't see him, Mydei rolls his eyes. "How do you manage to be chirpy even when sick?" Phainon only laughs at the lighthearted comment, not pushing.

He says nothing, even though he'd love to run his tongue about whatever subject comes to mind— then again, nothing can possibly come to mind with Mydei so close to him: if it didn't feel so strangely warm, Phainon may even describe the feeling as intoxicating. And perhaps it's the sickness messing up his senses, but he craves for more. He wants to hold him closer, even if he knows that could very well push him further away.

Funny, how vulnerability gives him courage that lacks foundation.

So, not for the first nor last time, Phainon listens to Cyrene's voice in his head: he moves his hand tentatively over the matress, trailing slowly until his pinky brushes with Mydei's cold one. He keeps it there, a question speaking through the lingering until the answer comes in the form of Mydei's own hand coming closer to his, pinkies intertwining in an almost silly manner— so, Phainon sucks in a breath before lacing their hands together, palm to palm. He wishes he could see Mydei's expression, the flush on his face.

It's stupid. Phainon feels as nervous as he was back in high school when he had his first kiss, except now he's a grown man and he's not doing anything but innocent hand holding. And yet, his heartbeat rings loudly in his hears, his pulse so erratic he feels it in every limb. Can Mydei feel it too? He really hopes he doesn't, for the sake of his dignity. This is embarrassing enough.

Unaware of his inner turmoil, though, Mydei's thumb slowly caresses his skin in such a soothing manner it grounds his breathing.

It's intimate. It maybe shouldn't be. But Phainon indulges anyway: he feels Mydei's hand on his own, squeezes gently only to immediately loosen his grip. He feels his skin, every callus and every inch he can possibly reach.

Mydei doesn't shy away, either, his hold keeping his hand firm in place. God. Phainon feels dizzy. So dizzy.

They remain still for several minutes (that Phainon doesn't bother counting), and though the silence feels like an embrace, he doesn't trust himself not to fall asleep as soon as he closes his eyes for far too long— so he doesn't. Instead, he finally tilts his neck: the frozen pack falls off his forehead and his skin immediately misses the cold, but he couldn't care less. Not when he's now facing Mydei, blond hair protecting his eyes like sacred courtains.

Though his brows twitch, caught in his own staring, Mydei holds his gaze as unbothered as he can. "I told you to stay still."

Phainon snorts. "It was starting to melt anyway. Who cares."

"Want me to fetch another one?" Mydei asks.

Phainon's answer comes embarrassingly fast, his grip tightening. "No, thank you. I'm fine."

Mydei's eyes wander to where their hands are locked together under the blanket, and an amused smile tugs at his lips. "Alright, then. But how do you feel?"

"Pretty okay. Ran over by a bike instead of a truck, I'd say." He figuratively pats himself on the back when Mydei lets out a short laugh, one of those so rare he wishes he could save for his ears only.

Ah. Phainon forces the urge to grimace. *Just since when is he so corny?*

Mydei's free hand once again goes up to Phainon's forehead. He nods approvingly. "It's gone down, but you're still warm."

"Told you. I'll be up and running in a day."

"You better." He flicks his nose playfully, and his smirk is enough for Phainon to swallow down any protest he was about to utter. "Can't go dying yet when you still owe me so many matches."

Phainon angles his body sideways, leaning on his elbow. "Of what, exactly?"

Mydei rolls his eyes. He looks so unfairly handsome. "Everything we've tied at."

"Now that's a long list, no?"

"Yes. Except for the arm wrestling. So, technically, I'm winning."

Phainon swallows at the memory. Yeah. Technically. If he hadn't gotten... *distracted*, he might've won. Not like it really matters. "You brag about that all you want."

"Will do. Should I brag about my cooking skills too when you publicly embarrass yourself?"

He bites down a laugh. "Hey. That would be like kicking a dog when it's down."

"Right. I should teach you a thing or two," Mydei hums, bringing their locked hands higher, just beside his head. Phainon stares at their laced fingers with something akin to awe. "My arm was falling asleep," he offers as explanation.

Phainon raises a curious brow. "You could've just let go."

"Given your clinginess, I was afraid you'd collapse if I did." It's a lame excuse. Phainon doesn't mind it in the slightest.

So he lets his smile grow bigger. "Couldn't it be that you're just as clingy?"

Mydei's horrified expression is priceless. Phainon bursts out laughing.

"Either the fever killed your few remaining braincells or you get very stupid when sick. But I'm never taking care of you again," he deadpans.

"Ah, there you go with the threats. You're so full of lies, Mydeimos." He sighs very deeply, shaking his head as if disappointed. Mydei's mature

response is to pinch the tender skin between his knuckles, hands very much still threaded together. Phainon hisses. "This is *no* way to treat a sick person."

"You don't look very sick to me."

Phainon pouts for dramatic effect. "My bones ache. My nose is stuffy. My throat is sore. And my eyes sting. I'm *very* sick."

Mydei rolls his eyes with no real venom. "Sounds like you should be sleeping, then."

"I don't want you to go yet."

"I can stay until you fall asleep," Mydei offers, checking the time on his own phone. He sighs. "But then I have to go. Early shift tomorrow."

The butterflies inside his belly don't miss a beat, making him feel almost nauseous.

Phainon wishes he could school his face, wipe the potentially dumb smile he's wearing off his face.

He kind of wants to kiss Mydei right now.

His hand involuntarily clenches at the realization that he has, in fact, wanted to do it for a while.

He won't.

He can't. Not *yet*.

So he forces his eyes shut and relaxes into the pillow. "Deal."

Phainon feels Mydei's body moving against the sheets by his side. He feels incredibly disappointed when his hand suddenly lacks the touch of Mydei's, but before he can even begin to complain, his head is forcibly lifted from the pillow, and his cheeks instead fall onto something ten times more

comfortable and soft. Only when this newly discovered pillow slowly rises and falls, he realizes he's pressed against Mydei's chest.

Oh, God.

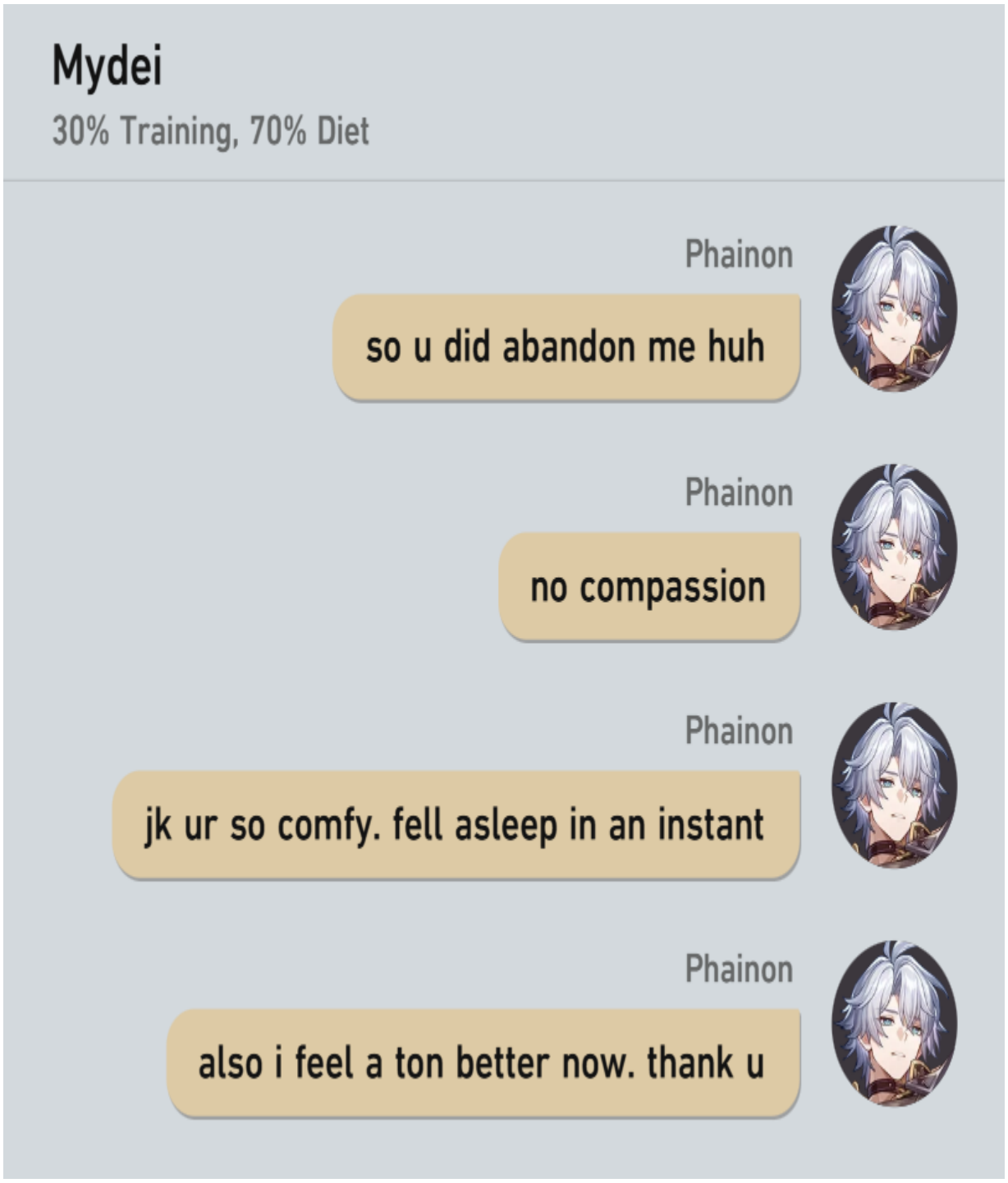
One of Mydei's hands then moves up to his hair, massaging his scalp with gentle movements. "Now you better rest. Your body needs it."

Phainon says nothing, huddling as close as possible. Mydei lets him.

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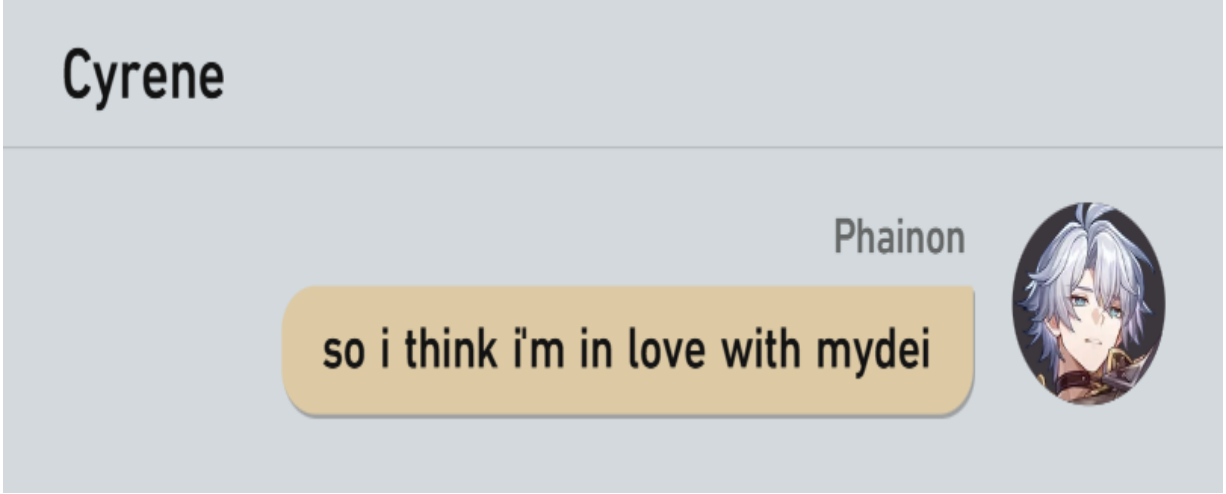
Phainon fell asleep before he could reel in the feeling of Mydei's touch. So, when he wakes up to his alarm beeping annoyingly and the first sun rays sneaking through the gaps of his blinds, he notices with great letdown that there's no longer a warm body laying next to his own. Still, he positively notes that he's no longer feeling ill. Just a bit sick, but not concerningly awful. So great.

He unplugs his phone from the charger —though he doesn't remember connecting it, he assumes Mydei did before leaving— and immediately opens said man's contact.



▶

Of course, he knows Mydei must just be clocking in for another day of work. So, instead of idly waiting for an answer, he opens his sister's chat.



▶

The admission is incredibly embarrassing, even for his standards, but well.

His message is marked as read in a matter of seconds. Then, an incoming call.

Phainon begrudgingly picks up, even if he was the one to hit her up first. "You really have nothing better to do than to scroll in your phone?"

She promptly ignores his uncalled comment. "Okay, first of all, what happened to your voice? My, Phainon. Have you been doing... stuff?"

He grimaces, only now realizing how raspy he sounds. "You're nasty. No. I catched a cold."

An unconvinced hum. "Is that so?"

"Yep. Matter of fact, Mydei is the one that took care of me. You know, in case you want to talk about that."

"Do you?"

"That's why I texted you, no?" He puts his phone on speaker and places it somewhere above the matress before giving his body a well needed stretch.

"I don't understand you, you know. You keep everything locked up like your life depends on it, yet you're willing to share such important information like it's nothing." Phainon recognizes her tone as the one she uses when she's deeply confused about something.

He purses his lips. "I just don't know how to proceed."

"You make a move, that's how," she says, like it's the obvious course of action.

But Phainon disagrees. "I'm not sure he feels the same way."

"But you don't discard it, do you?"

Phainon bites his inner cheek, and ponders. He thinks of Mydei's never subtle staring that's almost as bold as his own. He thinks about how easily flustered he gets whenever Phainon utters mild praises. He thinks about the trust he's placed in him, enough for him to open up without Phainon even asking. He thinks about the way he held him, how his hand never really left his body. His coy yet challenging gaze. How strangely natural it all feels.

Phainon finds it hard to confidently deny it.

"He likes me as a close friend, at the very least," he mumbles, not quite liking that possibility. Maybe he's become greedy. "But I do want to think I have a shot."

Cyrene giggles on the other end. "You'll have to find out, then."

He frowns. "I don't want to be too straightforward."

"I'm not saying you jump him. Just test the waters, Phainon. Make a subtle advance, see his reaction. Maybe try asking Cas." When he says nothing, she sighs. "Or, get really drunk, ask him, and blame your curiosity on alcohol."

"Not doing the latter, but thanks. I'll... test the waters."

"Sure. And do tell your friends. It will help you gain perspective."

The prospect of telling, *say*, Cifera, makes his hairs stand. He would never see the end of it. But she might be right.

"I'll think about it, yeah."

"Well then. Take care, Phainon. Watch your temperature," she says, gently. "And if you need to talk, whatever it is, just ring me up."

He lets out a deep breath, and smiles with relief. "'Course."

"And so, the prophesied day arrives," Phainon suddenly says in that overly loud voice of his.

Mydei shakes his head as he scans the grocery list once again. He's sure he has most of the ingredients in his home already, but double checking does no harm. Plus, Phainon had insisted on buying some extra —and quite unnecessary, if Mydei were to be asked— ingredients. Of course, Mydei said nothing: he was paying anyways.

"What are you aiming for, Deliverer?" he asks, very slowly. When Phainon barely looks up from the package of chocolate glaze he's holding, he elaborates: "You don't know to bake a thing. Are you entirely sure you need all this?" He gives a pointed look to their cart, now full of non essentials and stuff that he's sure will expire in his pantry.

Unaware, Phainon smiles and shrugs. "This is a special occasion. I want to add my special touch."

Mydei can only snort. That's such a Phainon thing to say, after all. So he complies and adds a second bag of heart-shaped sprinkles.

"I'll let you know that we already have the basics. Is there anything else you want to check out before paying?" he asks, crumpling the now useless paper and throwing it into his pocket.

Phainon checks his wristwatch and twists his mouth. "We're kind of tight. Better to get going."

"You sure? My home is not far from here."

"I need to set everything up before we stream, which might take me a while. So yeah."

With that, they quickly make their way to the self-checkout, and are met with a handful of people already in line.

Phainon groans. "It's barely three in the afternoon."

"And a week before christmas. We didn't pick the best date for this, I'm afraid," Mydei says, leaning into the cart. It's not *that* many people, but it'll take them at least fifteen minutes.

"Fair, I guess."

They fall into silence when Phainon, surprisingly, has nothing else to say. Mydei doesn't want to get ahead of himself, but he has been acting unquestionably unlike himself— less chirpy, and perhaps even a little closed-off. And he hasn't wanted to ask just in case he's just imagining things, but with the way Phainon is blatantly pretending to be occupied with his social media, Mydei highly doubts it's just that.

Something akin to worry suddenly fills his chest in an unpleasant manner. Since the last time he saw him, sleeping peacefully against his chest in an almost feverish state, Mydei wonders if perhaps he crossed a line. Phainon never expressed discomfort— quite the opposite. But that doesn't lessen his unease, the feeling that there's a certain topic floating in the air that neither of them dares to breathe in.

But, as his teacher many times said, there's no word for fear in the Kremnoan language.

He clears his throat loudly. "Deliverer. Is everything alright?"

Phainon almost drops his phone, barely catching it. He visibly swallows, tilting his head. "What?"

Mydei frowns. "You heard me the first time."

"Yeah, I did." He laughs awkwardly, scratching the back of his neck. "I'm fine. Don't worry."

"You're acting weird."

"Am I? Sorry about that." He doesn't look apologetic in the slightest. Mydei folds his arms. So he quickly corrects himself: "I mean, for giving you the wrong idea. I'm fine, but. Stuff."

Mydei hums. "Stuff."

Phainon waves him off. "It's dumb."

"Tell me."

"Man, this line sure is taking its sweet time, huh?" A lame attempt to change the topic. Mydei rolls his eyes.

"Speak, Deliverer." Exasperation taints his voice, so he urges himself to have patience. "You can talk to me."

Phainon looks away like a scolded child. "It's nothing serious. I just get really homesick around these holidays." He takes a deep breath. Mydei only stares, hoping his gaze can transmit some comfort. "Cyrene always comes visit, but this year she won't be able to. Schedules and all."

Mydei wants to ask about his parents, but he can already more or less guess the response. "Will you be alone?" he asks instead. A second passes before Phainon ultimately nods, pursing his lips. Mydei sighs with understanding. "I see."

"Not the end of the world, of course. We'll probably facetime or something. But it'll feel weird."

Mydei steels himself. "Don't you wanna come over, then?"

Phainon blinks. "Me? On christmas?"

He holds back the urge to mock him. "Yes, you."

"Are you sure?" Phainon finally looks at him, almost coily. "I mean, won't you have company? Like, *I don't know*, a girlfriend or something."

To the *very* poorly disguised question, Mydei laughs. "You take me for an exhibitionist?"

"I don't know. Are you?"

"No, I am not. And anyway, don't you think I would've told you if I had a partner?"

Phainon folds his arms. He looks very flustered, but also quite pleased. Mydei gives it no thought. "Maybe. Maybe not. But are you sure you wouldn't mind having me?"

"Well, no. That's why I'm inviting you, dumbass."

Much to Mydei's relief, Phainon lights up back to his usual self. "Oh, great! I'll make it worth your while. Gift exchange?"

Mydei smiles openly, not even bothering to bite it down. "Sure. Send me recipes you'd like to try."

"We could cook together!" He's beaming with enthusiasm now.

But to this, Mydei *has* to object. "No. After today, you stay out of my kitchen."

Phainon raises his eyebrows, greatly offended. "Why?"

"First, I don't like other people using my equipment. Just a pet peeve of mine. Second, it would be unpolite to have you cooking when I'm hosting."

He looks like he wants to protest, but doesn't push. "Your rules. But I don't want to arrive empty-handed either."

"Just bring yourself and your best wine."

Motivation regained, Phainon grins.

They end up arriving at his condo well past schedule: though Phainon made sure to let his followers know through his socials, he still hurried to set everything up as quick as possible while Mydei arranged the cooking equipment.

Now, with everything properly set in place, all that remains is to start the livestream.

Mydei grimaces at Phainon's apron when he finally turns around. "Seriously."

Phainon wiggles his eyebrows, pointing at the cursive letters embroidered on the fabric: *kiss the cook*. "Feeling tempted yet?"

Hm. *Maybe*.

Mydei doesn't verbalize it, of course.

"If anything, that titles belongs to me," he says instead, folding his arms. "Just when I thought you couldn't be cornier."

Phainon laughs, taking no offense. "A bit of fanservice doesn't hurt anybody."

To that, Mydei cocks a curious brow. "You do it for the audience?"

"They like it. I find it amusing. I believe it's mutually beneficial," he offers, shrugging.

"Couldn't hope to get it," he mumbles, leaning on the counter. "Gonna start it or what?"

Phainon playfully rolls his eyes and clicks on the bright, red button. When the small screen of Phainon's laptop —that for this one time will have to suffice as a monitor— finally displays the scene, he talks into the mic attached to his apron. "Can you guys hear me? You talk as well, Mydei."

Mydei reluctantly does so. "Hello."

@DeliveringDawn

CastoMiss: Hi, guys :) We hear you.

whimsicalthief: loud n clear

thetwilightsky: COOKING STREAM YAY

thetwilightsky: ica just came lay down with me LOL



| In reply to @thetwilightsky: ica just came lay...
King_Bartholos: of course he did...

Send a message Chat

"Little Ica's appetite still going strong, huh? Prayers for your wallet, Hyacine," Phainon jokes, giggling. Mydei doesn't understand. He'll ask, later. "Now, as you can see, the scenario is quite different. It's quite obvious, no? Mydei and I finally got together for the cooking showdown I've been teasing for a while now. I do have reasons to believe Mydei will take the lead here, so why not let him explain the rules?"

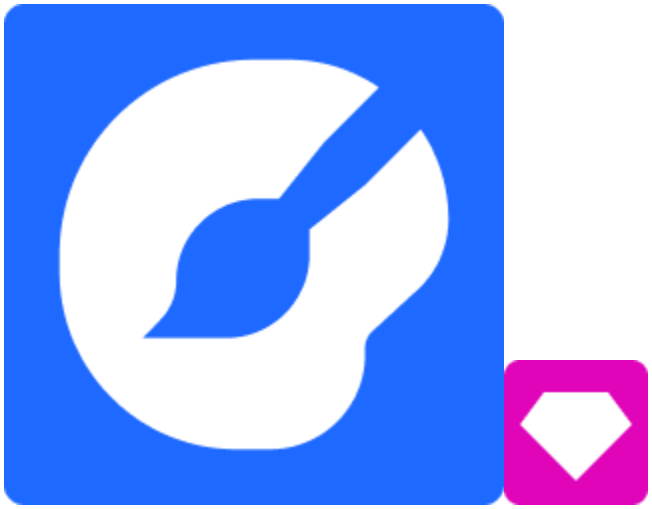
Mydei blinks, processing that he now has the hot potato, and clears his throat. "Yes. See, I don't know if calling it a showdown is fair, but we *will* be cooking. Maybe you don't know this, but Castorice is actually a twin," he says, smiling to the camera. "Their birthday is in a couple of days. And Phainon proposed the idea of giving them an early gift. So," he turns to face his companion, and gives him a stern look, "don't fuck this up."

Phainon raises his hands in innocence. "That goes unsaid. Cas and Pollie's cake will be otherworldly."

@DeliveringDawn

CastoMiss: Counting on it. You know how picky she is.

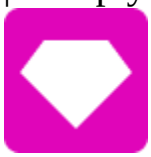
whimsicalthief: i mean if they dont want it im happy to obligue



neikoslove: awww thats so sweet

caeluswasHere: if my man isnt like this i dont want him

| In reply to @caeluswasHere: if my man isnt...

 reavingflames: i second that !!!!

Send a message Chat

Mydei manages to catch some of it, and has to stifle a laugh. "Alright, well. Since Phainon isn't what you'd call a baker, we're doing the first tier together. I'll guide him through it and make sure he grasps the basics. Then, we'll do one tier each: I'll do the mid-tier and he'll do the top one. Of course, we'll do an extra portion to properly sample it. Then comes the decoration, which we'll do, evidently, in halves. I trust that under the guidance of a pastry chef, this won't be a mess and we'll actually be able to *deliver* something to the twins."

Phainon snorts. "I can be sure of it. Hearing you talk in that knowing bossy voice of yours already has me pumped."

He raises a brow, redirecting his eyes to him. "Is that a compliment?"

"Yes. I find it quite endearing."

Mydei doesn't know what to do with that, so he turns in an attempt to play it cool.

"Are we clear, everyone?" Phainon asks then, rubbing his hands together in a comical manner. Like he has seen many times before, the chatbox floods with affirmative messages and stickers of similar kind. Phainon gives one final nod and turns to Mydei. "Great. Enlightenment time, Mydeimos."

Mydei shifts his weight uncomfortably. He's not used to doing prep on the aisle —it feels unreasonably wrong—, but he must accommodate for the sake of the viewers. "The first step, in theory, would be to preheat the oven. But given this... tutorial, we can skip that for now. So, what do you think comes first?"

Phainon twists his lips. "When my sister made stuff for us, I believe she always mixed the dry ingredients first."

Mydei nods, a mildly proud smile on his lips. "Correct. Which would be..."

"Flour, sugar... the baking stuff and salt, I guess," he mumbles, pointing at each bowl as he speaks.

"Baking powder and soda, yes." Mydei pours each ingredient —that he measured beforehand in various cups, as he found this to be far more practical for the context— into one big bowl, his favorite.

"You know, I never understood why the salt," Phainon asks casually, his eyes following Mydei's every motion.

"So the sugar stands out. Just how a candlelight will be more visible in the dark, your tastebuds will be far more receptive to sweetness if there's a mild salty flavor. You can't consciously taste the salt in a cake, no, but you'd notice its absence if you removed it. Food science," he explains, slowly.

Phainon looks genuinely impressed. "That's really cool."

"It is," Mydei agrees, giving a gentle tap to the bowl. "Now what?"

"Milk?" he offers.

Mydei tilts his head to the side. "Yeah, I suppose you could say that. But before that you need to mix this. Then goes the butter. And," his hand stops Phainon's, that's already reaching out for the whisk, "before working with the butter, we add oil into one portion of milk and leave it to rest."

Phainon's brows knit together, confusion written all over his face. "Is that why you split the milk into two different cups? And, why the oil, if you already have the butter?"

"Firstly, yes. Now, the butter is used for both flavor and texture. The oil, in this case, adds to the moisture." He pours a moderate amount of oil into the cup of milk, and sets it aside. "Mix. Make sure to do so evenly."

Phainon nods, unsure, and begins moving around the ingredients with the whisk, spinning it around throughout the bowl. This one step doesn't involve much skill, really, which is why he lets Phainon do it.

After about a minute, Mydei leans closer to properly scan the mix. He nods with approval, and Phainon immediatly beams. "Nice work. Now we add the butter. Care to do the honors?"

"You're leaving the easy stuff to me," Phainon says, seeing right through his method, but complies nevertheless.

"Because I'm teaching you. To learn to ride a bike, you first move around with your legs. Then you start to pedal. Only once you have that mastered, you take out the training wheels, but even then you have to learn to move without them to affirm you know how to ride a bike, no?"

"Ah. Your analogies are actually making you sound like a pro teacher. But don't let prof Anaxa know I said that," Phainon says, mimicking a cry. Mydei also doesn't know what this means, so he folds his arms and watches intently as Phainon drops the warm butter into the bowl. He stares at it for a moment before turning back to Mydei. "I presume I have to mix this now?"

"Quick learner."

Phainon smiles satisfied and does as told. Manually mixing butter with dry ingredients only is really awkward, Mydei knows, so he's not surprised when it keeps sticking to the whisk. It's just a matter of practice. Thankfully, though, Phainon doesn't struggle with it as much as he thought he would —based on his various experiences with rookies—. and once the texture is visually to Mydei's liking, he takes the whisk out of Phainon's hand.

He turns to the camera and slightly angles the bowl so the mix is visible. "If I were to advice you all on something, it would be to add the butter in small portions, so it's easier to integrate. Other than that, very good." His eyes return to Phainon's face. "Now, I want you to mix this with the milk and oil. You need to make sure you're mixing everything well, or you'll have nasty lumps in there, yes?"

Phainon nods, brows furrowed in utter focus. "Gotcha."

Mydei takes the other cup of milk and adds the eggs and vanilla to it. "While he works on that, I'll take care of this. A simple enough of a mix to speed things up. Now, I'm not sure if you guys care all that much about the technical stuff, but I can share the recipe with Phainon so he shares it with you all, in case anyone is interested."

@DeliveringDawn

stellewasHere: of course my king. i am very interested.

King_Bartholos: see how he doesn't gatekeep his recipes?

caeluswasHere: handsome, tall, funny, gentle and patient ... can phainon handle allat???

 whimsicalthief: LMFAOO no he cant

| In reply to @whimsicalthief: LMFAOO no...
 CastoMiss: He can.

whimsicalthief: ???



Send a message Chat

Phainon lets out a soft laugh next to him, urging him to look up. "You know, it's kinda funny how the roles are being reversed. I don't think you've ever talked so much in a stream before."

"Don't think you've ever been so quiet either," he mumbles.

"Miss my voice that much? Sorry, I'm just really focused over here."

"Yeah, yeah. Speaking of which, are you done?"

Phainon scratches the back of his neck. "I think?"

Mydei shoots a quick look to the mix and nods. "It's good enough. Now to finish the batter, I'm going to slowly add this while you mix. Gently."

"You're so cruel, Mydei. My shoulder hurts already. Are you trying to sabotage me?"

He snorts, adding a bit of the mixture into the bowl. "Stop being such a baby. This is the way you learn."

Despite the defeat on his face, Phainon begins moving around the whisk. "Is this how you treat your rookies too?"

"I tend to be more merciful."

"Ah. So you just hate me, then."

"You're just realizing now?"

"And here I thought we had something special."

Mydei rolls his eyes, but he knows he's smiling. "Alright, that's all. Keep mixing until I tell you to stop."

"Yes, boss."

He quickly rinses the dirty cups, and folds his arms. "Did you get it? Need me to go over something again?"

Phainon shakes his head. "I think I got it. Thanks. You're actually a super good teacher, Mydei."

"What, were you expecting me not to be?"

"No, not that. You just keep surprising me, that's all."

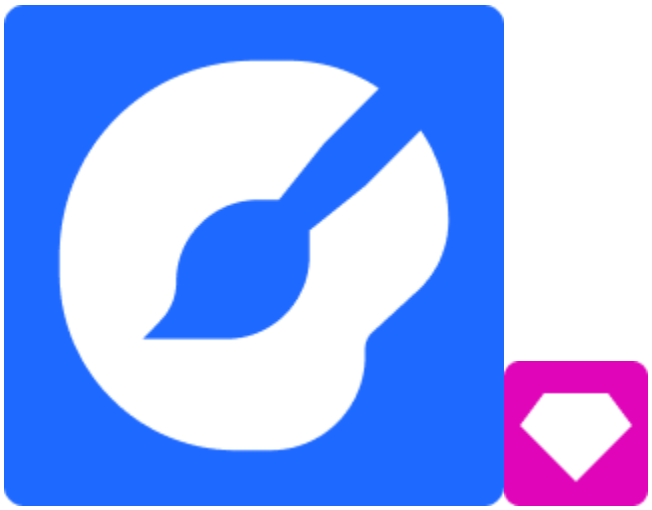
Mydei feels his cheeks running hot, but chooses to ignore it. "Being a kiss ass won't score you points."

"Really? It's just harmless praise, Mydeimos. I know you appreciate it."

With that, he resumes his task. Mydei pretends to be unaffected as he starts preheating the oven, boring holes into the stove.

@DeliveringDawn

 reavingflames: why does phainon actually have game ...

 neikoslove: I'VE BEEN TRYING TO TELL Y'ALL... his game is off the charts...

caeluswasHere: why we all thirdweeling

 whimsicalthief: @CastoMiss REF DO SOMETHING ??

| In reply to @whimsicalthief: @CastoMiss REF...
 CastoMiss: Can't. They're right.

Send a message Chat

"Alright, I think that's good," Mydei says, taking the bowl into his hands. The consistency looks fine, in his opinion. "Nice work. Keep it like that, alright?"

Phainon smiles, a little awkward, and looks away. "Yep. Got it. What now?"

"Taste test," he replies plainly, grabbing a clean spoon out of a cabinet and taking only a little batter into his mouth. "Ready to go. We'll send it into the oven with the other two tiers."

Phainon nods apprehensively. "What is it supposed to taste like?"

Mydei just grabs another clean spoon, repeats the motion and offers it to Phainon. Though the latter looks taken aback for a moment, he quickly leans in to lick the drops of batter on the metal. His brows furrow. "So, not good."

Mydei laughs low, dropping the spoon into the sink next to his. "Odd. People usually like the taste." He then turns to the camera. "Disclaimer: this is not me advicing you to taste raw batter. This is just my way to kill him."

He looks concerned for a split second before the joke lands. "Wouldn't that make two of us six feet under?"

"I suppose that even in the afterlife, someone has to keep you in check," is what he offers. Phainon laughs. Mydei smiles.

"Alright, alright. This is supposed to go into pans, right?"

"Precisely. This batter goes into the bigger one." He takes the stacked cake pans, all different in size, and hands the smaller one to Phainon. "Your batter goes here. I already gave you the measurements, right?"

"You did," Phainon says, showing the small paper to the camera.

"Good. Remember that you must not fill it to the top. Leave at least three fingers. Just for transparency, I'll let you all know that we are going to be working with the exact same ingredients and equipment. Even the scales we'll be using to weight the ingredients are from the same brand, both bought just today. The only difference is the amount of batter we'll be making. Yes?" He turns to Phainon for confirmation, and he nods. "Very well. Ready to begin?"

Phainon grins eagerly. "Hell yes. I'll surprise you, you'll see."

Mydei scoffs, but says nothing else as they each take place on their respective side of the aisle. For him, of course, this isn't anything new: he feels at ease and works methodically as he measures all the dry ingredients at a fast pace, almost in a robotic manner. But, well, that is just to be expected given that baking is what he does for a living.

He steals a glance to Phainon: though he is working considerably slower, still weighting the sugar, he's not doing terrible yet. He's quiet, lips pressing together tightly and brows drawn together in concentration. At least, he's taking this seriously. Mydei smiles and continues to crack the eggs.

While he works, Mydei occasionally lets his eyes wander towards the chatbox, but he doesn't allow himself to get too caught up on it. Still, it is a good source of entertainment.

@DeliveringDawn

King_Bartholos: the way phainon only locks in with mydei is kinda funny ngl

| In reply to @King_Bartholos: the way phainon...
 whimsicalthief: took u a while to see the vision huh

 thetwilightsky: haha they're so in the zone !! cute

neikoslove: in phainon we trust



CastoMiss: Polyxia is here with me, by the way. She says hi.

Send a message Chat

Mydei smiles. "Polyxia sends her regards, Deliverer."

Phainon looks up, crate of milk in hand, and waves to the camera. "Hi, Pollie! Working my ass off for you two." Mydei shakes his head.

By the time Phainon finally begins mixing his dry ingredients, Mydei is already adding the milk. And by the time Phainon adds the milk, Mydei has finished his batter. Mydei quietly pours the mixture into the greased cake pan, and proceeds to patiently wait for Phainon to be ready. His mind is tempted to use the adjective cute, even if he believes handsome is more accurate— he's slowly adding the milk with one hand, just like he instructed him to, while he moves the whisk around with the other. Mydei can't help but feel a tinge of pride.

He folds his arms. "You seem quite a lot more eager than most of the newbies at the bakery."

Without tearing his gaze away from his bowl, Phainon lets out a short laugh. "I'm taking that as a compliment."

"It is. I frankly thought this would be far messier."

"Don't jinx me just yet. I still can fuck this up somehow," he says, setting aside the empty cup.

"Maybe you'll best me in decoration. How are you with arts and crafts?"

Phainon gives him an incredulous look. "You've felt these hands. Not exactly cut for things that require precision."

Mydei lifts a brow and raises a hand. "You've felt mine as well. I manage just fine."

"But I have the same pulse as a teen that drowns in energetic drinks." Mydei rolls his eyes, and Phainon snorts. "Plus, you're a pro. But the thought is what counts, right? I'll try to make it as cute as possible."

"I don't doubt that."

Phainon smiles. "Anyway, I think I'm done. Do I just pour it?"

"Add a little oil and spread it through the pan. Then you pour it."

"Heard." Phainon does just that, and, as expected, there's some leftover mixture. "This is for us, right?"

Mydei nods. "I think a cupcake mold will suffice. Again, don't fill it up to the top."

In a matter of minutes, they have the three cake pans and two cupcake molds in display, set in front of the camera so the viewers can properly see them. Phainon is shifting his weight, perhaps anxiously. Mydei lifts a questioning brow in his direction, and he grins. "I want you to try it already."

Mydei hums. "You did well. I'm expecting something decent, at the very least." Phainon nods enthusiastically, and he turns his eyes to the camera. "While this bakes, we'll work on the frosting. You better use all the stuff you bought, Deliverer."

⋯⋯ • ୨ ✦ ୧ • ⋯⋯

"Careful not to drop it."

Mydei swears he sees a sweat drop run down Phainon's face as he very gently places the smallest tier on top of the other two.

Once he's made sure it's centered he immediatly steps back, as if his mere presence might throw it off balance. "You're so evil. What if I *did* drop it?"

The corner of his lips twitches a bit, but he schools his face flawlessly as he slides one of the dowels right through the middle of the now assembled cake. "It's tricky, yes, but you did just fine, and now you know how to stack a tiered cake. Are you interested in working for me?"

Phainon folds his arms and gives him an unimpressed look. "No thanks. Lady Aglaea treats me wonderfully. I fear you would just exploit my great

talents."

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "Great talents?"

"Hey, you still haven't tried my cake. Don't talk so big yet."

Mydei gives a sideways look towards the cupcake molds that still sit atop the counter, that long cooled out while they frosted the cake. "Alright. Let's eat then."

Phainon quickly grabs his 'cupcake' and offers it to Mydei. "I know yours will be amazing, so mine first."

Mydei snorts, but takes it into his hands. Phainon is giving him that same eager look, shifting his weight from one leg to another as he rubs his hands together. If he had a tail, Mydei is certain it would be waggling like crazy.

He takes one big chunk to stifle a laugh.

The first thing he notes is that is a little bit dry. He guesses Phainon didn't mix things as evenly, but well. Common rookie mistake. Other than that, the texture is alright. It's far from being an ideal consistency, but the flavor is actually pretty good.

So he nods approvingly. "To be your first cake, I'd say it's a passing grade. Well done."

Phainon grins and takes the cake back, biting into the same place Mydei did —and he tries really hard not to ponder about the implications of that—. "I think I'm allowed a pat in the back for this."

Mydei says nothing as he hands him his own, satisfied grin on his face. "Now mine." Phainon takes it and, with no further ado, shoves the entire thing into his mouth. Mydei blinks, lips parted in awe. Then he flicks him in the forehead. "You *idiot*, where are your manners?"

Phainon giggles, chewing with some difficulty. Once he's done, he swallows with a pleased sigh. "So sorry, but I was looking forward to it. Boy, I'm kinda jealous of the twins right now. That was delicious."

@DeliveringDawn

CastoMiss: That looks really appetizing.

CastoMiss: By the way, Phainon, we can share some with you guys. It's too much for just the two of us anyway.

whimsicalthief: does that include me as well?

CastoMiss: No.

Send a message Chat

"Dumbass. I can bake for you whenever you want," Mydei says, shaking his head.

Phainon leans closer and whispers into his ear, "Would it be okay for me to swing by the bakery to buy stuff?"

Mydei looks at him like he just grew a second head. "Obviously. And why are you whispering?"

"It's kind of personal information, no?" Phainon offers, shrugging. Mydei only lifts a brow. "You know the rules. Anyways," he turns to the camera, and frames Mydei's face with his hands, "I hereby declare Mydeimos the winner of this competition! Surprising nobody."

@DeliveringDawn

neikoslove: WHAT DID HE SAY



reavingflames: rude... i want to listen too



caeluswasHere: whatever personal info means ig

stellewasHere: keep fucking my girl bro i dont even care anymore

| In reply to @stellewasHere: keep fucking my...
StreamServices: You have been timed out for 180 seconds.

thetwilightsky: congrats mydei !! but yes it's not really surprising haha

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In the second leg of the livestream, they follow the plan and decorate the cake with the various bags of frosting, each one taking care of one half of it. And the product is... something.

Mydei's half is, of course, flawless: he opted for the route of sculpting various flowers and butterflies in shades of purple and pink —given the twins' preferred aesthetic— with black details to contrast with the white layer that covers the three tiers of the cake.

Phainon's, on the other hand, is a mess.

Mydei supposes he too attempted to make some shapes, if the clusters of frosting are anything to go by, but it's evident that he gave up halfway. Upon reaching that veredict, it seems like he ultimately decided to make random, uneven and shapeless figures on the top of each tier. Worst thing is, he did so with every color available, no harmony between them or whatsoever.

Maybe they should've picked a color palette beforehand, Mydei thinks.

Phainon scratches his chin. "You know... it's not that bad."

"Really."

"It's like. Abstract art. Like those paintings you see at modern art museums."

Mydei places a hand on his shoulder and shakes his head. "It's okay, Deliverer. Decorating a cake can be hard. It's the thought that counts."

To that, he sighs defeated. "Yeah, alright. It looks like shit. I get it."

"Well, yeah. Everyone's first cake is like that. Mine wasn't exactly a piece of art either," he offers.

Phainon pouts, and Mydei swears he's attempting puppy eyes. "Are you comforting me?"

He grimaces. "I highly regret it."

Phainon only shoots him a smirk before he grabs the cake box Mydei brought from the bakery. "Anyhow, time to pack this up so we *deliver* it as soon as possible. Terribly sorry about the design, Cas. Try to focus on the flavor."

@DeliveringDawn

 CastoMiss: No, it's okay. Don't worry. We really appreciate the gesture.

whimsicalthief: "no no its nice" ahh castorice

caeluswasHere: that cake look like a fucking lizard

| In reply to @caeluswasHere: that cake look...
vidyadharatouch: that doesn't make sense + there's nothing wrong with lizards ??

thetwilightsky: you know ica would eat it either way ? if that helps

King_Bartholos: and of course he would...

Send a message Chat

"Mydei, do you mind?" Phainon says, eyeing the cake.

He rolls his eyes, but carefully slides the cake into the box with the help of a pair of spatulas, only because he knows Phainon's shaky hands wouldn't be able to handle it. He neatly ties the ribbon on top to seal the box closed, giving a few taps as he appreciates his —and Phainon's— work. Sure, he may do this every day, but this one is special.

He sets it aside when Phainon speaks up again. "So, we made it! This is an absolute one hundred and eighty compared to my content, but I had a lot of fun. I hope you guys did as well! I know you love Mydei, so hopefully having him talk throughout the whole thing was worth it." He winks at him, and he suddenly feels very self conscious.

He clears his throat. "I too had fun. And if you enjoyed it as well, I'm open to giving him some more cooking lessons," he says.

The chat fills with affirmations, praises and affectionate stickers. Mydei smiles.

Unable to keep his hands to himself, Phainon starts to idly play with the open flour bag. "That's it, then. How about we turn this into a cooking channel, Mydeimos? Or, no, why don't you open your own account to share recipes and stuff? You'd do great!"

Mydei eyes the bag with mild concern when Phainon lifts it into the air, supporting it in one hand. "That's not really my style. I'm not as chirpy as you."

He moves his hand around dangerously. "C'mon, there's a bunch of silent live streamers out there! You just put some background music and let your hands do the talking."

He purses his lips, eyes trailing to the chat where people are encouraging him, promising to support him. So he sighs. "I could think about it."

Phainon smiles wide. "Great, see—"

The bag falls from his hand.

Thankfully, it lands right on top of the aisle, but that doesn't prevent a considerable amount of flour from flying out of the bag, staining the air with white powder. Mydei's only instinct is to bat it away from his face, stepping back unharmed.

However Phainon, whose face met directly with the flour, has to blink repeatedly to remove the powder from his eyelashes —not that you could tell, anyway, as they mixed with his own white lashes—.

When he turns, with his face full of flour, Mydei has to bite down a laugh. "I saw that happening."

Instead of cracking up like he thought he would, Phainon gives him a sly smirk and opens his arms. "Sorry, Mydei."

Mydei realizes far too late what he's going to do. Only when he's caged against the counter, restrained by an awkward hug, he reacts. "Asshole, don't you *dare*—"

But his protests fall on deaf ears. Phainon gives him a barely apologetic look before he starts to *literally* rub his face against Mydei's, making even more of a mess and dragging Mydei down with him.

He can't help the laugh that escapes him as he punches him in the shoulder. "You *dog*— I'm going to fucking *murder* you—"

Phainon mimics his own laughter, giggling stupidly as his cheek clashes with Mydei's. "You could, yeah."

Mydei, of course, fights him, practically headbutting him when their foreheads meet for a moment. He takes the opening and grabs a fistful of white hair, pulling his head back— Phainon barely reacts, face still beaming with pure giddiness and, *God*, Mydei hates that he can't supress his own smile either.

He tries to look stern, but knows that he fails miserably. "What was that about?"

Phainon feigns innocence as he leans into Mydei's touch. "Divine calling. Impulsive thought."

Mydei doesn't retort. Losing himself in Phainon's eyes is far too easy when he's this close— so close. *Too* close. He can trace every one of his features, his stupidly beautiful crooked nose and irises that any sailor could rightfully mistake for the bright, stormy ocean. His flushed cheeks and the long eyelashes that rest on them. His plump lips.

He has such pretty lips. And it's so unfair he can't kiss them.

Mydei swallows as he catches Phainon's eyes trailing down to his own. His mind very *loudly* calls for some composure, so he tries. He loosens his grip on Phainon's hair and instead ruffles the top of his head, flour falling off his bangs like the snow that falls outside. "You really need a bath right now."

Phainon snorts, finally leaning back. Mydei misses the warmth of his body, stupidly so. "And you really need to wash your face."

Mydei is about to say something snarky, when his gaze inevitably falls on the camera.

Ah.

Right.

They are still live.

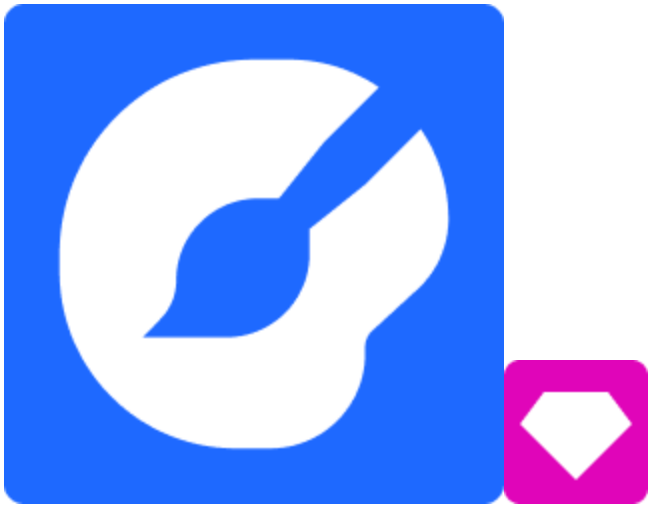
@DeliveringDawn

caeluswasHere: ok what the FUCKKK

King_Bartholos: this is either shameless fanservice or they genuinely have something going on...

CastoMiss: im so normal about this

stellewasHere: alr thats wild

 neikoslove: im so single

whimsicalthief: #phaidei #real ????

| In reply to @whimsicalthief: #phaidei #re...
CastoMiss: im not even gonna ban you for that

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Showing his fluster is not a possibility. He does his best to ignore the heat on his face and folds his arms. "Get your manners in check."

Phainon smiles awkwardly —having the same realization as him, Mydei guesses— and bores holes into the camera. "And it's a wrap! As always,

thanks for being here, everyone. And stay tuned for the next stream!"

The goodbye is rushed, clumsy, and he quickly shuts everything down.

They clean in utter silence.

It's surprisingly not uncomfortable, Mydei notes.

Castorice

Writing as we speak



Castorice

Thank you for the cake, Mydei.



Castorice

Polyxia and I loved it. It was very good.



Castorice

Mind sharing the bakery you work at? We'd like to go someday.

[Location Attached]

Mydei

I'm glad to hear that.



Mydei

Just let me know should you need everything.





Castorice

Of course.



Castorice

Same goes for you. You can confide in me.



Castorice

If you were to need it, I mean.



Castorice



Castorice

Writing as we speak



Castorice

Be honest



Castorice

Are you in love with Mydei

Phainon

idk are u in love with cipher???





Castorice

Oh you totally are omg

Phainon

ok



Phainon

as much as i hate to thirdwheel, how about we meet up tomorrow?



Phainon

the three of us



Phainon

i actually need help with something





Castorice

I'll be there



Castorice

Cipher too, I'll drag her along



Castorice

You're not off the hook, BTW

Phainon

im aware



▶

"So what's this about? I know princess homebody out of all people wouldn't be so eager to go out just to drink some coffee."

Castorice gives her a look, taking a sip of her latte. "Rude, but okay."

Phainon sighs, moving around the spoon inside his mocha. "Before we talk about anything, I need help finding a gift for Mydei."

Cipher barely moves as she raises her brows. "A gift?"

"For christmas, yes. I'm thinking on jewelry, since I know for a fact that he likes it. I need your insight for it, though."

"Are we getting a present too?"

Castorice kicks her under the table, not so subtly. "Focus, Cifera. This is important."

Phainon laughs awkwardly. "I'll get something for you two before the break is over, I promise. But this is urgent. I'm spending christmas at his place."

As if that caught her interest, Cipher finally straightens in her seat. "What did you say?"

"He's spending christmas with Mydei," Castorice answers in his stead, eyes open wide as if she just heard world-changing news.

Cipher rolls her eyes. "I was being rethorical, but yes. *Why* are you spending christmas with him, again?"

He feels himself blushing already and gulps down what remains of his coffee. "Cyrene won't come this year. He took pity on me when he knew I was going to be alone, I guess, and told me to come over. So there's that. And I still don't have a present."

Cipher tuts and shakes her head. "Shame on you. How come you still don't have a gift for your boyfriend?"

Phainon grimaces. "He's not my boyfriend."

"Do you want him to be?"

"*Cifera*."

The woman in question gives Castorice a look at her stern tone. "Don't be meek, you're as curious as me."

"Wait, you actually care?" Phainon asks, genuinely confused at Cipher's apparent interest.

She folds her arms. "Gee, don't sound so flabbergasted. We're friends, aren't we?"

He dramatically places a hand on his chest. "I'm actually moved."

"Point being," Castorice cuts in, giving an exasperated look to the two, "you need us to help you pick something for Mydei. So what do you want it to mean?"

Phainon purses his lips in thought. "I'm not sure. Gratitude, I guess?"

"Boring," Cipher chimes in, and Castorice sighs.

"We can't help you if you don't know what is it that you want to transmit," she says.

"Does it need to be that deep? What if I just want to do something nice for a friend?" The word is bitter, very much so.

"That's the thing, Phainoob, is it *just* for a friend?"

He frowns. "Well—"

"Are you in love with him, *yes or no*?"

Cipher looks at him straight in the eye, with that sharp and knowing glint of hers that always makes him pause. He holds her gaze for what feel like hours, as he recalls Cyrene's advice and his own conclusions.

She squints her eyes menacingly and he folds, sllumping in his seat. "Yes."

Next to him, Castorice lets out a breath that she was apparently holding. Cipher scoffs and leans back on her chair. "Wasn't that hard, was it? Now we know what to look for."

"Something that speaks *love*," Castorice mumbles, a little too dreamy.

Phainon flusters and tries to make himself small, which proves impossible given the tiny chair. So instead he just stares at his empty cup. "Yeah, right, sure. Whatever that means."

"Is he silver or gold inclined?" Cipher asks before gulping down what remains of her smoothie.

"Gold, I'm sure."

"Then I have just the place.

He pays the bill and soon enough they are walking out, with Phainon trailing behind them like a lost kid as they walk through the cold streets of Okhema. He can't help but stare at their joint hands —are they friends? girlfriends? dating? Phainon has no idea— and he can almost picture himself and Mydei in such scenario, knowing well how warm his hand feels against his.

His mind urges him to school his face when a dumb smile threatens his lips.

When they stop abruptly in front of a rather fancy store, he follows suit.

Cipher finally turns to him. "You okay with a high budget, yeah?"

Phainon nods without thinking twice. He may not be rich, but he does have double income.

So they go through the revolving door. The place is absolutely massive, and Phainon can't help but think that is a *little* bit ridiculous, given that it (seemingly) only sells jewelry, but well. He's no expert on the matter, and he silences those thoughts lest Aglaea somehow reads his mind from afar and fires him for his crassness.

He pictures her stern look and suddenly feels very out of place with his purple shirt and mustard pants —which in his college teacher's words, was an utterly radioactive mix of colors—, but what can he even do now? He just hopes his black jacket is enough to cover some of it and that the vendors take him at least a little bit serious.

He just follows Cipher as she walks around the place like she owns it. "What are you thinking about, Deliverer?"

Phainon frowns. Perhaps he's gotten used to Mydei's voice saying it, but the nickname sounds odd.

He says none of that. "A pair of earrings and a necklace. Maybe a ring as well?"

Castorice's brows go up, her grip around her phone tightening. "A ring?"

"Is that too much?"

Cipher starts walking backwards to face them, cocky as always. "Perhaps a little bit too intimate. You think he'd be okay with that?"

"Could be a good confession device," Castorice mumbles, more for herself than for them.

Still, he catches it and raises his hands. "Easy there. Why do you think I'm confessing?"

They both frown at him and say in unison, "*You're not?* "

He lets out an incredulous laugh after a brief pause. "What— are you *crazy*? I don't even know if he feels the same."

Cipher suddenly cracks up and exchanges a look with Castorice as if saying, *are you seeing this shit?*

Phainon is about to defend himself, greatly offended, when Castorice grabs him by the shoulders —*and why on earth is she so strong?*— with her eyes very wide. He bites down his tongue.

"Phainon," she starts, tone firm. He only raises a brow. "Did you watch the compilation I did of saturday's stream?"

Though she doesn't say it explicitly, he knows which moment she's refering to specifically. He shifts his weight awkwardly and does his best not to look away. "I did, yeah."

"Okay. Did you catch the way he was looking at you?"

Truth be told, he couldn't watch it until the end. The self awareness just became too much, especially after that embarrassing stunt he pulled.

He trembles just at the memory. "What way?"

"Lovingly," she replies, squeezing his arms tighter as if to emphasize her point. "It was *The Look*, Phainon, and I believe the only reason you didn't realize it's because you were probably just as awestruck."

"Or because he's as dense as a pile of cement," Cipher says, casually sliding an arm around Castorice. "If you want my opinion—"

"I don't."

"—I think you're both equally and stupidly in love with one another," she finishes anyway and, for only a split second, her confident facade falters and Phainon swears he sees some vulnerability behind her eyes. She recovers just as fast, though, and clears her throat. "Point being: don't fuck this up."

Castorice nods, mustering a gentle smile. "And I *know* risking can be scary, but what has always been your answer?"

He sighs. "Better to lose while trying than to not try at all."

"Precisely. And if you ask me, your odds are looking very good." She finally lets him go and he forces his shoulders to relax.

"And if we are wrong, *which we are not*, you can count on us to help you heal a little heartbreak. Always." Cipher shoots him a thumbs up alongside a surprisingly kind smirk.

He takes a deep breath. "Alright. Alright. I'll tell him. Somehow. I'll try. But if anything goes wrong, I'm holding you two responsible," he jokes.

Cipher rolls her eyes while Castorice giggles, and with that the conversation is deemed finished.

They drag him throughout the store, where vendors very kindly show him all kinds of jewelry, from very flashy pieces to subtle, barely noticeable ones. He ultimately picks a pair of inverted triangle earrings that are big enough to be visible through his mane, without being uncomfortably heavy — alongside it, he chooses a very distinctive chain necklace consisting in various rhomboid shapes with little sapphire stones inbetween. Just picturing Mydei wearing it convinces him of his decision.

As for the ring, he has the perfect one in sight— it's just mildly thick and in its center rests a square-shaped sapphire, matching perfectly with the earrings and necklace. It's the cherry on top.

But.

"Did you measure her ring size, sir?"

Phainon blinks at the vendor. *Ring size?*

The woman must notice his confusion, as she smiles in understading. "Don't worry, this happens a lot. It's the diameter and circumference of the finger, basically, so the ring fits comfortably."

He nods. "Oh. Well, I don't have the exact measurement, but I believe my own finger should do."

She tilts her head. "Are you certain?" Before he can answer, Cipher clears her throat louder than possibly necessary. The woman's eyes widen in realization, and she flushes. "Ah. My apologies."

Phainon smiles and waves her off. "It's fine."

She quickly gets to work, surrounding his finger with a short measuring tape. Once she's done, she excuses herself for a mere minute before she comes back with a small box in hand. "Here it is. Please, do check any imperfection."

He doesn't even get to open the box before Cipher snatches it out of his hands. "You have a terrible eye with this type of stuff, Phainon. Let the expert take care of it," comes her explanation.

When he turns to look at Castorice for support, she only shrugs with a dreamy smile on her lips.

Alright then.

The vendor looks at him kindly. "So, engagement ring?"

Phainon chokes on nothing and shakes his head concerningly fast. "Oh, no. It's just a gift. Not— not there, no."

"Yet," Cipher chimes in, unhelpful.

The woman giggles softly. "I see. Well, in any case, he's a very lucky man."

"... Thank you, ma'am," he mumbles, sheepish.

After Cipher approves the ring's quality, they soon pay and head out onto Okhema's busy streets once again. Just holding the fancy bag makes him feel anxious about the implications of it.

"Remember what we just talked about," Castorice says, as if reading his thoughts.

He nods. "I know. I'm just a bit nervous."

"That's what the thrill of love is all about, Deliverer boy," Cipher says, taking Castorice's hand into her own in cue. Castorice doesn't even startle, just accepting it with a faint blush on her cheeks. "Let's walk back to the station now, because my legs are *killing* me."

"Actually, I have something else to do," Phainon quickly replies. It's a lie, of course, but he's done thirdwheeling. "Go ahead without me, and text me once you're home."

Cipher looks fine with it, if anything. Castorice, however, shoots him daggers with her eyes and silently mouths the word *traitor*.

Phainon shrugs and smiles innocently.

As the elevator goes up, Phainon begins to worry he maybe did too much. Cyrene had very much approved of his outfit when they facetimed earlier in the evening, saying he gave off charming vibes and that, surprisingly, the color palette was far from horrifying. He did however *not* say that he actually texted Aglaea for some help, to which she enthusiastically answered with various suggestions that he followed as best as he could considering the state of his wardrobe. Still, he knows his sister probably guessed as much.

The final product of hours of putting on, taking off, and putting on again pieces of clothing in an attempt to create something harmonious stares back at him in the mirror: first, he decided he needed to do something about his hair, and thought it would be a good idea to comb it back. And while it's weird to see his forehead so exposed, it looks pretty good. As Cyrene said, "*it makes him look straight out of a book!* " (whatever that's supposed to mean, of course; he long gave up trying to understand his sister's odd comparisons). After trying countless combinations, he's dressed in a black turtleneck and white pants, along with a blue coat to combat the evening chill. So, in short, he looks stylish.

He just hopes the intention behind looking so presentable isn't as blatant as he thinks.

With his gift in one hand and the wine he promised to bring in the other, he slowly makes his way towards Mydei's condo. Is he trying to delay it as much as possible? Perhaps.

After his talk with Cipher and Castorice, plus five more late-night heart to hearts with Cyrene, his mind is much clearer. He's not as scared as he probably should be, maybe even a little bit confident, but a part of his brain still keeps him anchored to the ground. He's still walking on eggshells, after all. At the very least, he still has a couple hours to think about how to lay his feelings to Mydei.

When he knocks, the door swings open immediately. And in a silly contrast, Mydei couldn't look more casual: his hair is tamed inside a bun, ears free of jewelry as well as his neck, and he's wearing an apron with the words *go fork yourself* engraved in it.

Phainon can't help but smile. "Hey."

Mydei sighs. "The one time you dress up, I look like an absolute mess."

"I think you still look very gorgeous," he says before he can bite his tongue. Oh well.

Thankfully, Mydei looks far from minding it. What he does is oggle him quite shamelessly before humming appreciatively. "You don't look so bad yourself. Come in."

Phainon does as told, unable to say something else, and follows Mydei to the kitchen. Once there, he leaves the wine atop the counter and stands awkwardly in place as Mydei walks around moving plates and cutting boards.

"Is there anything I can help you with?"

Too focused on the steaming pot in front of him, he barely looks up when he answers: "No, thank you. I'm almost done here anyway."

Phainon slides his hands in his pockets, smiling fondly. "You're in the zone."

To that, Mydei snorts, faint smirk on his lips. "And you'll taste why. Go sit, scoot."

He can't think of anything smart, so he just makes himself comfortable at the dining table after taking off his coat. Both the cutlery and plates are already sitting on it, alongside some salads that look absolutely delicious. As for the remaining half of the table, it is mostly empty with the exception of a pair of covered baking and frying pans. His curiosity makes him want to lift the lids to take a peek, but he supresses that urge for the sake of politeness and plays with his fancy glass instead.

Soon, Mydei is walking out of the kitchen with one big pot in hand, no longer wearing his apron. "What would you like to drink?" he asks.

"Whatever you're having."

He lifts a brow, a glint of amusement in his eyes. "I'm having pomegranate juice. Freshly squeezed. No milk, no sugar."

Phainon recalls the bitter taste of the one he tried with Mydei and grimaces. "On second thought. Just water is fine."

Mydei laughs short and goes back to the kitchen after leaving the pot. God, it all smells *heavenly*. Phainon already knows this will be the most filling dinner of his life. When he comes back, he's holding a jar of reddish juice and another with iced water.

"I prepared a lot of stuff, so eat whatever rocks your boat," he starts, taking off the lids. Phainon eyes everything with great interest. As he goes over each dish, he moves his finger around: "First, I grilled some octopus as appetizzer. This here is moussaka, so in short, meat with eggplants, potatoes and bechamel. And this is stifado, or, meat and onion stew with a sweet touch. *And* since you liked it so much last time, I prepared some pastitsio as well." He finally sits down, taking a deep breath. "Not much to say about the salads. These are just some of my favorite."

Phainon blinks, a little stunned. "This is all looks delicious, Mydei. Thank you so much."

"Don't sweat it. Feel free to eat as much as you want. And if there's anything you don't like, don't force it. I take no offense in such things."

"I highly doubt that's possible, but thank you. So. Can I dig in?" he asks, maybe a little too eager.

But Mydei only smiles. "Go on."

Because he's a starved caveman, Phainon takes a bit of everything until filling his plate. Cyrene always used to scold him for his lack of modesty at family buffets, but he always ate everything, so was it really a problem? If anything, Mydei looks pretty content with himself as he adds some salad to his own plate.
He loses no time stuffing his mouth with moussaka, letting out a pleased moan as the flavor reaches his tastebuds. "You outdid yourself this time. Holy shit."

"Glad you like it. It's a favorite recipe of mine."

"I can tell. Mydei. Mind cooking for me forever?" Phainon asks, not caring about the implications of that. Whatever. He'll just speak his mind.

Mydei pauses for a moment, taking a long sip of juice. Then, "Won't you get tired of it?"

And Phainon feels incredibly sure when he answers, "That's highly impossible."

Mydei only hums, faint blush on his cheeks. Phainon keeps on mindlessly tasting and swallowing food like there's no tomorrow, his concerns from earlier far forgotten with the raw delight that fills his being. Happy stomach, happy heart, he supposes. Mydei does pretty much the same, eating quietly and giving short answers when Phainon chimes in with one question or another. And Phainon couldn't ask for more.

It's not long until they're both finished, with barely any leftovers. Mydei wipes some sauce off the corner of his lips —Phainon had been so *tempted* to do so with his own— and starts piling up the dirty dishes. "Do you have room for dessert?"

Phainon pats his belly. He's full. *So* full. "Sure."

"Alright. I'll go fetch it. You stay put."

But he stands up anyway. "I feel like an useless slug. Let me at least help you with these," he says, extending hands.

Mydei purses his lips for a moment, but ultimately hands him the plates. "Thank you. Just leave them in the sink."

He ends up making two trips to the kitchen, and when he sits back down, Mydei is already cutting what looks like the most scrumptious cake in the world.

"What's that?"

"Galaktoboureko."

Phainon smiles awkwardly. "That answered nothing."

Mydei laughs short and puts one serving in the plate he hands to Phainon. "Try it yourself."

Not like he needs to be asked twice. He takes a small bite, and his eyes go wide in surprise. "Okay. It's super delicious."

"I know. It's a classic for a reason," Mydei says plainly, also indulging in his work of art. He nods approvingly, like he always does when trying his own food. Phainon can't stop the tenderness that overcomes his senses.

Because he's full, he eats slower. And that gives him more time to talk. "I can't thank you enough for having me. This has been amazing so far, and we're only getting started."

Mydei leans in a little closer, supporting his chin on his hand. "Really? Then what are you gonna do to keep us entertained?"

Phainon swallows and laughs awkwardly. "I can actually think about a couple of things," he replies, perhaps a little too confident given that he's not yet free of rejection. Mydei snorts and he clears his throat. "But, seriously. I thought I'd still be angsty and stuff, not being with my sister and all. But I feel just as at home as ever. I don't know. You're just great, Mydei. So thanks for everything. For the food, and well, for being with me like this. You get me."

Mydei seems a little surprised by his sudden sincerity, as he looks away. "Don't thank me for that. I mean, I've gotten used to spending the holidays alone, with my friends being with their own families, so, well, having someone with me for a change is also a nice. Not to say just anyone would suffice."

"I know," Phainon says, smiling. "I want to give you your gift already."

"It's not even eleven yet," Mydei points out, raising a brow.

He pouts. "C'mon. Can't we bypass that rule?"

"No."

"I got you something *really* nice."

"So did I. Still no."

"Please?"

Mydei throws him a napkin ball. "Stop talking and eat."

Phainon lets out one last dramatic sigh before stuffing his mouth with cake which, to be fair, isn't much of a task when it tastes so good. Just as Cyrene used to say to their parents, everyone has a second belly for dessert. Phainon couldn't agree more, given that he doesn't feel like he's about to explode when he finishes his serving. However, that does not seem to be the case for Mydei, as he looks downright constipated as he takes his last bite.

Phainon tilts his head, mildly concerned at his sudden demeanor change. "Are you alright?"

Mydei nods far too quickly for it to be natural. "Yeah. Yeah, I'm good. Mind helping me fetch the wine?"

His brows come together in confusion, but stands up either way. As he helps him with the dishes, Phainon can't help but notice the way he's subtly fidgeting with his now loose hair. And he really wants to ask, but Mydei feigns normalcy just as quickly when he opens the bottle.

"This is one fine brand," Mydei notes.

He leans against the aisle as Mydei takes out one glass from the cupboard. "Is it? I don't know much about this stuff. I just picked the one with the nicest name," he explains.

Mydei hums. "Good eye, then." He says nothing else as he pours the wine into the glass, and Phainon can only but stare when he gulps down a sip, the bob of his adam's apple drying his mouth like cinnamon. "It's delicious."

Phainon snaps back to earth and manages a weak smile. "Don't mind me if I give it a try."

But before he can even reach for the cupboard, Mydei's hand grabs his arm and firmly keeps him in place. He looks at him with such intensity that Phainon cannot utter a word, his body limited to just admiring those fierce eyes.

For a moment, he looks unsure. And then, with a swift motion, he lifts the glass to within reach of his lips. "Drink."

The commanding tone goes straight to his crotch, embarrassingly so. That, and the fact that he still recalls their first conversation.

Special occasions.

Commemorating an alliance

Intimate gesture.

Oh.

He can barely think.

Mydei must hear his silent question, for he angles the glass. "I said, drink."

Phainon can't exactly refuse. Not when Mydei is looking at him like this. So he takes the glass in his hand. But Mydei doesn't let go of it either— no, his hand brushes with Phainon's just enough for him to feel drunk when a single drop of alcohol is yet to enter his system.

And he *can't* look away. He can't tear his eyes away from Mydei's, not even as the cold glass touches his lips, when he tastes the bitter liquid in his tongue, when the tame burn runs down his throat.

Mydei sets the glass aside and Phainon can do nothing but stupidly lick his lips as he loses himself in the dawn of his eyes. He recalls Cyrene's words, he recalls the the many ways he had planned to confess, the exact words he had memorized... none of which feel right in this moment.

An incessant flow of mixed up letters hits his brain, and yet he can only manage: "I'm in love with you."

Mydei opens his mouth, but the words get caught on his throat when Phainon moves quicker and cages him against the aisle.

"And, fuck, that actually feels like an understatement when I say it out loud. It's more. *So* much more." He can't bear to see Mydei's unreadable expression any longer, so he cowardly hides his face in the crook of his neck. "These feelings *drown* me— and each day I sink a little further, and it's like I can't go up for air. I don't want to."

He allows himself to take in his scent, a heavenly fruity aroma — pomegranate, he immediately guesses— and he feels his own breaths getting ragged. One of Mydei's hands go up to his hair and for a split second he fears he's going to push him away, but no: it pulls him closer,

impossibly so, and Phainon leaves a tentative kiss just below his ear just because he can.

"I don't know when I began to feel this way," he continues, because he doesn't know what else to do with himself, "but I knew it that day at the fair. Everything simply fell into place, I guess. I don't have to try. Neither do you. It just feels right. Natural. And maybe it sounds silly, but that's always how I thought love is supposed to be. Raw and efortless. Never understood the meaning of my own philosophy until you showed up, that is. I just. Ah, fuck, can I kiss you?"

Mydei lets his actions do the talking— his hand lifts his face and his lips finally, *finally* meet his own.

It's not chaste. It's not slow, nor it is tender. It's harsh, it's hungry, and it's everything Phainon could ever ask for. Because if tasting his dishes was delightful, tasting *him* is simply otherworldly— both their mouths reek of wine, yet Phainon can taste nothing but pure sweetness. He lets his tongue wander freely as it clashes against Mydei's while his hands occupy themselves with his ass, his waist, his chest, anything and everything they can possibly reach; Mydei is decisive, strikingly sure of his motions as he digs his fingers into his scalp, grabbing fists of hair and tugging just hard enough for Phainon to moan into the kiss.

Their lips move perfectly in sync as if they've done this a million times before, their angled heads fitting together like a divine puzzle. And fuck if doesn't it feel that way. Kissing Mydei is something Phainon now knows for sure he could get dangerously addicted to. Because it's both as intoxicating as it is defying, and Phainon can never deny a challenge.

Mydei places his knee just between Phainon's thighs and brushes his crotch with maddening intent, to which Phainon responds with a delighted groan. Mydei takes advantage of his parted mouth and his sharp teeth soon bite down on his lower lip, his hold on Phainon's hair tightening as he does.

Phainon whines in a twisted mixture of pain and pleasure, and digs his nails deeper into his waist in retaliation. He pulls back, if only to catch air, before his mouth wanders south to explore his neck, leaving a trail of wet kisses

as he does so. Mydei uselessly tugs at his sweater, but Phainon holds him in place.

"I need to hear it," he says, panting. "I need to hear you say it, Mydei."

Mydei grunts when Phainon bites down on the soft spot below his jaw, leaving no more than a faint kiss over it as lame compensation. So he cups his face with no tenderness to speak of, forcing his face up until their eyes meet. Mydei's pupils are blown in pure lust, and Phainon has to *plead* his body for some self control.

"I am in love with you, and I want you so badly it's infuriating," he utters, barely over a whisper.

Phainon can't supress the sudden, anticlimactic giggle that shakes him. "Really?"

Mydei sighs, but there's a smile on his lips. "Yes, really. Now can we go back to what we were doing? I was enjoying it."

Because he can't disobey, Phainon does just that. And he doesn't know how, but amidst kissing and *quite* a handful of groping, they successfully make it to Mydei's room without tripping. Their upper clothing is thrown away somewhere along the way —not like he can bring himself to care about such triviality when he's tangled up with Mydei, now can he?— and when Mydei's back hits the matress, Phainon throws himself at his chest rather unceremoniously.

He kisses, he bites, he sucks at one nipple like a man starved as his hand plays with the other one, supporting himself only with his free arm.

Mydei's hands roam all over his back as he lets barely audible moans. "You freak."

Phainon can't defend himself. If anything, he licks his skin even more intently. "I've been wanting to do this for some time now," he breathes out, grinding his crotch against Mydei's as if to make a point.

"I can— *fuck*, I can tell," is what he manages, his nails digging painfully into his shoulder blades. "But you're not getting us off this way."

To that, Phainon halts his mouth for a moment, looking up. There's that familiar *something* in Mydei's eyes, that shine that always makes his heart jump. He feels his lips twitching into a crooked smile. "Is that a challenge?"

Mydei hums, holding his unwavering gaze. "Perhaps."

And that's everything he needed to hear for his remaining restraint to be a bygone.

His hands quickly scramble down to Mydei's belt to remove the rather annoying pants that separate his hands from the flesh of his thighs. Under Mydei's sharp gaze, he uncaringly kicks them away before sliding his fingers beneath the waistband of his boxers, tugging the fabric all the way down to his ankles. Mydei can't help but hiss when his naked cock hits the cold air.

"Take yours off too," he says, cut short by his own moan when Phainon wraps his warm hand around him.

"Let me have you like this," is the only thing he replies.

Phainon wastes no more time resuming his assault on Mydei's chest, now tending to the neglected nipple with his tongue as he sets an achingly slow pace around his cock. And the reaction is delightful: Mydei's hips buck up as he chases the sweet friction of his hand, breathing out a curse when Phainon's free hand keeps him firmly anchored to the matress. He smiles with satisfaction against his skin, kissing the sore spot almost tenderly before his lips roam to his other pec.

Mydei surrounds his neck with his arms, pushing him further down against his chest. Phainon shows no resistance, if the way he groans is anything to go by. Just being like this, with his face pressed against Mydei's soft pecs, is enough to have his cock rock-hard and leaking. He lets his grip around Mydei tighten, and the latter sighs with exasperation.

"Move your damn hand," he commands, fighting his hold and rocking his hips upwards.

Phainon laughs short, rather fixated on sucking the skin all around his hard nipple. "Desperate. Move for me, then."

"Asshole," is what Mydei musters.

But he moves. He rocks his hips up and down, setting his own pace as he uses Phainon's hand as nothing but a tight, soft hole to bury himself into. And Phainon is too lost in his own desire to even mind it. Too lost in the flex of Mydei's abdomen beneath his hand, in the way his chest tenses alongside it; in the way brushstrokes of ink define the shape of his muscles, in the way his nipples stiffen under his lips. He can barely think, licking along the traces of red paint as if he were the artist himself.

"Mydei," he breathes out, kissing just inbetween his pecs. "Is this good?"

"Yes," he answers right away, stilling his hips. "Keep touching me."

So Phainon moves his hand, up and down, angling his face so he can properly watch Mydei's reaction. The strain of his neck is so worthy. "You're gorgeous." His thumb caresses his glans, and Mydei lets out a soundly groan in response.

"*Faster—*"

Phainon complies. He sets a quick pace, moving his fingers along his whole length in a tight grip. Mydei's hips buck involuntarily with each stroke, and Phainon is nothing but awestruck. So, so beautiful.

"C'mon, Mydei. Come for me. Please." He does not care about the desperation in his voice. No, all he cares about is the flush in Mydei's face, the way his brows knit together when Phainon speeds up the motion of his hand. Then, just like magic, he feels Mydei's whole body tensing beneath him, the lock of his arms around his neck keeping them glued together as he spills into his hand with one last moan.

Phainon kisses him through his high, tasting the pleasure in his lips. It's messy and uncoordinated, but neither of them cares. Mydei pants against his mouth, a delightful sensation. "You should use that mouth of yours for other than talking more often," he jokes, tenderly stroking his hair.

Phainon smiles, leaving a chaste kiss just below his nose. "Really?"

"Really." He leans in once more, and quickly shifts positions: before Phainon can register it, Mydei pushes him against the bed and straddles him, mouth still hovering over his like a ghost. Phainon bites down an indecent sound when Mydei's naked ass grinds against his still clothed erection. He sits up just as Mydei pulls back, chasing his mouth like a magnet, and Mydei mercifully allows him one kiss before his plump lips brush his neck tattoo, his clavicle, his chest; he keeps making his way down, trailing his path with small kisses until he finally settles between his legs, sitting on his heels. Phainon can only stare in awe as the zipper of his pants is pulled down. "You're clean, right?"

Phainon nods, eyes glued to Mydei as his hands hold onto the edge of the mattress. "Yeah. Yeah, I'm clean."

Mydei smiles. "Good. So am I." He says nothing else as he lowers Phainon's pants down to his thighs, and only glances up at him when he moves his boxers out of the way. Phainon lets out a shaky breath when both of Mydei's hands come up to wrap around his length, his eyes filled with intensity. He gives him a few short, tentative pumps before saying, "Relax."

He swallows, but does just that: he cups Mydei's face with one hand, pushing back a few strands of hair as he gently strokes his cheek. Then, Mydei lowers his head to place a short kiss just over his tip, and Phainon swears he loses it a little; and Mydei must notice, for he shoots him a quick smirk before parting his lips and sliding his cock into the dangerous warmth of his mouth, slowly, *so slowly*. Phainon doesn't cover his mouth fast enough before a lustful moan leaves him, making Mydei's already hardening dick twitch with interest.

He goes down until his nose meets the base of his cock, holding his gaze in such a challenging manner it has Phainon struggling against the urge to fuck

his mouth senseless. He takes a deep breath in a futile attempt of steadying his senses and Mydei pulls away just as slow, with an obscene sound echoing in his ears when his lips leave his flesh. "Touch me," he orders, taking Phainon's hand and placing it atop his head.

Phainon bites his inner cheek. "Are you sure?"

"I am sure," Mydei replies, nuzzling his cheek against his dick. "I won't break."

He takes another breath, shakier, and grabs a fist of blond hair as gently as he can. "If you're uncomfortable, just bite me."

Mydei laughs, deep and rough. Phainon twitches just at the sound. "Gladly."

He takes him again, bobbing his head up and down as his tongue circles around his length doing absolute wonders. Phainon holds him firmly, guiding him along his cock as he shuts his eyes in a poor attempt of delaying his orgasm. But he knows he won't last much longer, not when Mydei is sucking him off like this. And sure as hell not when he looks so good doing it. Like he was *made* for it. Phainon doesn't even bother biting down a grunt when Mydei presses his lips tighter around him.

He dares to open his eyes. And it's a mistake, he knows, because there's tears pricking his eyes, a flush on his face that makes him look somehow even more ethereal, and he's stroking his own member as he sucks on his just as eagerly. So Phainon pulls him by the hair to separate him from his dick, earning a deep moan that sends delicious vibrations along it. "Just stop me if it's too much."

Mydei nods and keeps his lips parted as Phainon holds him place, sliding his cock into his mouth, inch by inch. He starts slow, but when Mydei attempts to speed up the pace himself, Phainon finally forgoes any resemblance of restraint and bucks his hips into his throat, groaning in raw pleasure when its warmth envelopes him in just the perfect way. He repeats the motion and quickly sets his own pace as his cock goes in and out, sweet lips wrapped around him with no intention of letting go; Mydei holds onto his muscled thighs for support, only letting out muffled moans each time

Phainon hits the back of his throat and showing no signs of resistance or whatsoever.

"Close," he breathes out, loosening his grip on Mydei's hair; but far from pulling away, he bows his head further down until there's nothing else for him to take in. And that does it for Phainon— the sensation of being inside Mydei's mouth, his half lidded eyes and wet eyelashes, his naked body and angled chest, it's all *too much*. With nothing but Mydei's name on his lips he lets go, shooting his load inside as Mydei milks him until the very last drop, eyes fluttering shut.

When his legs finally relax from what was probably the most intense orgasm he's had in *years*, Mydei lets him go, visibly swallowing his release. He takes a couple of deep breaths, and Phainon gently wipes away the wetness in the corner of his eyes.

"Are you alright?"

Mydei leans into his touch, nodding. "Very much so. I just need a moment."

"Do you need water? I can bring you some." He attempts to stand up, but Mydei holds him in place, looking at him sternly.

"I'm not done with you yet," he says.

Phainon blinks and tilts his head. "Oh?"

Mydei gets up from the floor and makes himself comfortable on his lap, his hard cock brushing against Phainon's abs. "What, you didn't think all I had stamina for was the gym?" His hands make their way down to Phainon's own member, giving it a gentle pump. Phainon hisses, still sensitive from his orgasm, and wraps his arms around Mydei's waist. "Speaking of. We still have a score to settle, don't we?"

Phainon arches a brow with interest, gently stroking the small of Mydei's back. "We have plenty."

Mydei kisses him slow and short. "Yes. Remember when we went to the gym together?" A kiss on his cheek and another pump. "We tied in everything. Said we could settle it some other day." A kiss on his jaw and a pump that has Phainon's cock finally twitching back to life. "How about now?"

Phainon lets out a shaky breath when Mydei's lips go back to his own, brushing but not touching. "Feeling creative?"

He snorts, grinding his length against Phainon's. "Are you backing down?"

"So unfair. You know I can't say no to that," he responds, but he knows as well as Mydei that he perfectly can.

Mydei smiles into his lips before he kisses him again, stroking his dick to get him hard again; and Phainon knows it won't take him long with the way he's kissing him— slow, but decisive. Phainon lets him do as he pleases with his mouth, lets him force his lips open with his tongue, lets him tilt his jaw with his free hand. The simple idea of Mydei touching him like this is enough for Phainon to be rock hard already, but when Mydei grabs both their cocks into his hand and begins stroking them together, Phainon feels lightheaded.

"That— that feels good," he mumbles, pulling away to catch his breath. But then Mydei stops, and before Phainon can begin to protest, he's pushed back until his back hits the matress. Mydei straddles him once more, supporting his weight on his knees, and Phainon swallows. "Where's your lube?"

Mydei nods to the nightstand. "Fetch," he orders.

Phainon feels he might be discovering something about himself, with the way he gets impossibly harder at his commanding tone.

He stretches awkwardly as his arm reaches for the little cabinet and (somehow) manages to succesfully grab the half-full bottle. The mental image of Mydei fucking himself in this very same bed is far too good for him not to indulge, but he pushes the thought away as the picture in front of him is way better.

When Mydei takes it out his hands, he's smiling with mild amusement. "It would've been easier for me to get it."

Phainon tilts his head. "But you told me to get it," he says.

"Yeah, I know," is all Mydei offers back. Alright then.

When he sinks two of his fingers into the bottle, Phainon raises a brow. "Shouldn't I help you with that?"

Mydei only gives him a look. "No touching."

He huffs, hands laid uselessly by his side. "That's something hard you're asking out of me."

But of course, Mydei only gives him a shit-eating grin. "What, too hard to keep your hands to yourself?" He finally lines up his fingers with his hole, hissing in discomfort when he slowly slides them inside.

Phainon swallows. "A little, yeah."

He places his free hand over Phainon's torso for support as his fingers slowly go deeper, scissoring their way in. "You'll have to settle with watching, then."

Phainon cannot believe this man. Perhaps he's still unaware of the effects his mere presence has on him. "Not complaining, but. Are you sure you don't need a hand?"

"This isn't new to me," he breathes. Phainon does not want to imagine someone else getting to see this view, so he forbids his mind from ever suggesting it again. Still, he can't help but clench his hands, feeling stupidly restless. He wants to touch him. Badly. He *needs* to touch him. Mydei seems to read his thoughts, for he scoffs. "And I'm the impatient one."

"And can you blame me?"

Mydei's only response is silence —if you don't count the occasional grunt as noise, that is— and Phainon is obligated to just observe. And, sure, this

is a view he would appreciate with no complaints any other time, but *now*, with his cock stiff as a pillar, he can't really *just* admire it. He wants to be part of it. He'd like to be the one fingering Mydei open and the one to make him gasp a little when hitting that sweet spot.

Ah. Is he really so desperate?

Phainon is too focused on the subtle expressions on Mydei's face to notice when he finally pulls his fingers away —after what feel like plenty of long and tortuous minutes, if you were to ask Phainon— and angles his entrance just above his cock; he only realizes when Mydei wraps a hand around him, and just as quickly he snaps out of his reverie.

He finally decides to do something with his hands and moves them up to stroke the hard flesh of Mydei's thighs, almost tenderly. "Take it slow."

But, of course, Mydei is anything if not stubborn.

Just as the words leave his mouth, Mydei takes his entire length at once, impaling himself on his cock in one swift motion. They both let out a shameless moan at the feeling, with Phainon's fingers digging almost painfully into his skin and Mydei's own hands pressing hard against his chest.

Phainon blinks at him, both concerned and ridiculously turned on. "I told you to take it slow."

Mydei keeps his hips still as he adjusts to his size —that is *by no means* small—, breathing in and out sharply. "I like it this way."

"Are you sure?"

"Absolutely." And if to make a point, he tentatively moves his hips up just to drop his weight back down on Phainon's crotch, moaning roughly as he does so. "Ah, fuck, it's good."

So Phainon indulges a bit, letting his hands wander up to his waist, urging him to move. And Mydei does just that: he repeats the motion, slowly, as

his walls welcome the intrusion. Phainon feels feverish. Incredibly so. Because Mydei's warmth tightens around him like nothing has before— it's such an overwhelming sensation, he's not sure he could've ever even imagined it had he not experienced it first hand.

As Mydei begins setting a mild pace, Phainon is barely able to think. "You take me so well." The praise seems to do *something*, if the way Mydei clenches around his cock and groans softly is anything to go by. Phainon lets out a strangled noise at the feeling. "So well, fuck. *You*— you feel so good. Just for me."

"Just for you," he echoes, words that go straight to his twitching dick. He rocks his hips up and down, fucking himself into Phainon's cock under his lustful eyes that trail every one of his movements and expressions: the contraction of his quads and the tensing of his glutes, the way his lips remain parted with every gasp that escapes him, how his hands keep him pressed firmly against the matress like an anchor, how his brows knit together as his eyes fight not to shut close. Phainon's hips buck up involuntarily just as Mydei's ass comes down to meet him halfway— and when he brushes that tender spot, he hears the most delightful moan he's ever heard: "*Phainon*."

Phainon can't bite down a moan of his own at the sweet sound of his name coming out of Mydei's honeyed lips. It's enough to make him spiral. He cups Mydei's face with a hand and pulls him down into a messy, wet kiss. "You're perfect, Mydei."

Mydei grunts into his mouth when Phainon's free hand guides his ass down as he brings his own hips upwards, penetrating him so deep it leaves little to no space left in his mind to think about anything that isn't *him*. "Phainon," he cries out once more, much to his pleasure. "*Phainon*."

Mydei's movements become weaker with each trust, his body rocking in all directions as he chases his high; Phainon takes his chance and switches their positions, leaving Mydei pinned beneath him instead. And though Mydei could very well resist, he does not: he locks his legs around Phainon's waist in an attempt to pull him closer, such a simple act that's nevertheless enough to drive him insane. Phainon sets an unrelenting pace

as he ruts into Mydei's warmth over and over again, fueled only by Mydei's sweet mewls and his own pleasure that threatens to consume every last fiber of his body.

He hides his face in the crook of his neck, biting harshly on his tender skin. "I'm close," he musters, groaning shamelessly when Mydei throws his arms around his neck, his muscles squeezing his face in a way he has fantasized far too many times for it not to be considered embarrassing.

"Inside," comes Mydei's half-answer, a mixture of words and breathless sounds.

And Phainon has never chased an orgasm so desperately before: he hugs Mydei's waist tightly, pressing their bodies impossibly closer as his thrusts keep on hitting Mydei's prostate in a way that has him singing obscene melodies right into his ear. Phainon wraps his hand around Mydei's neglected cock and gives him a couple of firm strokes which do work as intended— Mydei chants his name as he comes, his walls clenching around him as his body trembles in utter pleasure.

Phainon follows immediately, spilling his seed copiously inside of Mydei's welcoming hole, his own limbs shaking as the electricity runs through him. He rests his weight on top of Mydei until emptying himself, with strong hands massaging his scalp in a soothing manner as he slowly comes back to his senses.

He stays very still, the warmth around his softening cock far too inviting for him to decline. "That was. Intense," he sighs, nuzzling his cheek against Mydei's rather comfortable chest.

"That's one way to put it, yes." Mydei's voice is rough, Phainon can tell. Knowing he's the cause of it has him feeling stupidly giddy.

But then he remembers something, and his head snaps up like that of a dog who hears a knock on the door. "Hey. Does this mean I won?" Mydei blinks at him and his mouth twists into a disgruntled grimace. Phainon laughs, placing a chaste kiss atop his lips. "Such a sore loser. Literally."

Mydei hums. "Wanna go another?"

Phainon raises his brows, an incredulous smile on his lips. "Aren't you tired?"

He squints his eyes, defyingly. "Are you?"

To that he laughs short, supporting himself on his elbow to have a better view of Mydei's flushed face. "You're a bit insane, Mydeimos."

Mydei smiles with satisfaction, cupping his face with both hands as he pulls him closer. "Is that a yes?"

"It is," Phainon answers plainly, leaning in to kiss him once more. "You're seriously altering my brain chemistry," he says, voice muffled against his mouth. Mydei only scoffs, his lips moving slowly against Phainon's. And it's not intense nor it is eager, but Phainon drowns in the sensation either way. Just having him like this, so close to him, so trusting, makes him feel fuzzy all over. "I feel like the luckiest man alive." He momentarily pulls back so he can properly look into his eyes, that golden gaze he's learned to love. "Because, I mean. I *really* like you."

"You've made it very clear, yes," he responds, lips quirking up. Then, he places a peck on his nose. "So sappy."

Phainon returns his smile and buries his face in the flesh of Mydei's chest, tempted to leave yet another batch of marks. "Mydei," he breathes him in, letting his hands roam freely along his thighs, feeling every line of muscle with his fingers. "How do you want me? Just tell me and I'll do it."

Mydei tilts his head back with a pleased hum as Phainon kisses his jaw, sucking on the skin lightly. "Like you mean it."

"Like I mean it?" He goes lower, tongue tracing the hard bone of his clavicle.

"Yes. Like you truly mean wanting to fuck me."

His words, naturally, do wonders for Phainon's growing erection— that, and the way Mydei's wall clench around him, only add to his arousal. Phainon pulls out if only to unceremoniously flip Mydei onto his stomach; and far from minding being manhandled, Mydei understands his intention and properly supports his weight on his arms, lifting his ass up. The sight alone is enough to have Phainon rock hard, giving himself a few strokes. He takes some time to admire the absolute artwork that is Mydei's naked body: the red lines caressing his skin, all the way from his shoulder blades down to the small of his back; his beautifully defined muscles that rival those of the old gods.

Mydei moves his hips backwards, his ass brushing Phainon's sensitive cock. "Hurry up," he demands.

Phainon laughs sheepishly, despite the pleasure that hits him upon grinding his dick alongside the curve of Mydei's sculpted ass. He believes he could get off just like this. "Too easy to get mesmerized by you," he offers in apology, grabbing his cock in one hand as the other holds Mydei firmly by the waist. "Just relax."

He lines up his tip with his hole before slowly going in, his come lubed cock sliding with ease; he takes in every last pulse as he moves, the way Mydei slighly arches his back as he fully sinks himself inside. Phainon tightens his grip around his waist when Mydei attempts to rock his hips, the latter huffing in annoyance.

"What is it?" he asks between quick breaths.

Phainon smiles and leans forward to kiss his cheek. "We are doing this my way. Is that okay with you?"

Mydei turns his head to properly kiss him, short but sweet. "Better make it worth my while."

Phainon leaves his mouth to kiss the back of his shoulder, right where red ink makes a trail. He takes his time going down, admiring and praising with his lips every inch of skin highlighted with crimson, the hard lines of muscle and the way he shivers with every brush of his tongue. Phainon

stops right in the middle of his back when a loud groan suddenly escapes Mydei's throat. He smiles, teeth brushing with the very same spot. "Sensitive here?"

"Seems like it," he whispers, pressing his face against the pillow.

Of course, Phainon has to test it. He places another kiss before gently sucking on the skin, and the effect is immediate: Mydei clenches around him with a moan, throwing his ass back until their hips meet again. Phainon hisses at the sensation, nails digging deeper into the curve of his waist. "Interesting," is all he manages, and gives one final suck before continuing his way down. Mydei seeks friction, but Phainon denies him, keeping him firmly in place.

"Quit the teasing and *move*," he says, sounding a little desperate.

Though any other time he'd take enough pleasure out of teasing him alone, Phainon can't deny he himself is growing just as impatient— so he only snorts and straightens himself instead. While a hand stays anchored to Mydei's skin, the other goes further to grab a fist of blond mane, with Mydei hissing —out of pleasure, Phainon concludes when his walls tighten around him— when he yanks his head backwards rather harshly. "Like I mean it, right?"

Mydei scoffs back at him, perhaps too confident for someone that's just about to get railed. "Like you mean it."

So he complies. Phainon moves his hips backwards until nothing but his tip is embraced by Mydei's insides before he thrusts back in, supporting himself with his grasp on Mydei's waist. Mydei whines when he repeats the same motion, hitting his sensitive spot once more; Phainon wants to take it slow, wants to savour every reaction he elicits in Mydei and take in every last sensation that shakes up his body. Yet despite his own wishes, his body acts on its own accord: he moves fast, rutting against Mydei like nothing but the desperate animal he is. Mydei only moans in delight, loud enough for the creaking sound of the bed not to be heard.

Ah. If he wasn't so deep inside him, perhaps Phainon would even dare to feel an ounce of pity for the neighbors.

But he does not, and if anything, the thought only manages to turn him on even more. He leans forward to kiss his neck, fist tightening around his hair.

"You feel amazing," he whispers, sucking and biting his painted skin like he's going to eat him. *God*, he really wants to.

Mydei only hums as his hips meet Phainon's, tilting his head back to give him a bigger area to place his lips on. Phainon complies and lets go of his scalp to properly hold him down, both hands firmly holding onto his waist as he sinks deeper and deeper. It's like heaven, truly. Being tightly pressed against Mydei's hard back, engulfed by nothing but his heat, his scent, his presence, is far too good. And really, Phainon is just a man. He doesn't repress the bashful sounds that leave him with every erratic thrust, lips wide open as he sings praises into his ear. Mydei only but leans into his every touch, kissing him rather clumsily and interrupted by his and Phainon's moans.

But it's all too good. Phainon wants nothing but keep holding him, to relish in the overwhelming, countless sensations Mydei triggers in his body—alas, there's only so much pleasure man can bear before having to let go. The climax hits him unannounced, tensing his thighs as Mydei's insides pump him to the end, his own orgasm coming after almost in perfect sync.

Phainon stays motionless, lips pressed softly against Mydei's flushed cheeks. "Need me to bring us towels?"

Mydei smiles, still catching his breath. "Please. There's clean ones inside the bathroom's drawer."

He gives him one final kiss before he slowly pulls out, wincing as his sensitive cock hits the air. Mydei stretches his whole body right after, in such a cat-like manner that Phainon can't help but giggle to himself. Mydei only gives him a look before plopping on his back, his whole body relaxing.

Phainon is quick fetching the towels before he returns to the bedroom — after giving himself a proper clean-up—, where Mydei is smiling at his phone with amusement. It's such a genuine grin that Phainon really, really wants to capture the moment. But they're both still butt ass naked, so he'll pass this time. He sits right between his legs and gently swipes the towel over his groin, some of his load slipping out.

He can't help but feel a little embarrassed, now. So he focus on his task.

Mydei raises a brow. "I can do that myself."

"I don't mind it. Let me take care of you, yeah?"

To that, Mydei doesn't protest. He puts his phone on the nightstand and leans back into the pillows. "My friends say hi."

His hand stops for a split second before resuming, a smirk drawing itself on his lips. "They know about me?"

He gives him his signature eyeroll. "Of course they know about you."

"Oh? Were you fanboying over me with them?"

Mydei takes a deep breath, and Phainon bites down a laugh. "Perhaps. Were you not?"

Phainon grimaces. "Well, I *might* have talked my sister's ear off. Which, by the way, Cyrene really wants to meet you. She sent her regards and thanks for *taking in her stray little brother*. Her words."

Mydei snorts. "She's funny. Are you sure you're related?"

Now it's Phainon's turn to roll his eyes. "Yeah, yeah. And *you* like *me*. So who's the loser?"

"Well, you *just* lost," he points out.

Phainon folds the towel once he's done and leaves it by the edge of the bed, leaning in to place a short kiss atop Mydei's lips. "Really? But you lost

first."

"Still a tie," Mydei says, flicking his nose affectionately.

Phainon laughs and suddenly remembers something very important at the sight of Mydei's bare chest. He practically jumps out of bed, earning a frown from Mydei. "I haven't given you your gift yet," he explains.

Mydei blinks in realization. Then, when Phainon is just about to walk out, he replies: "Put some pants on. I don't want you walking around with your dick out."

"How crass, Mydeimos," he teases, but does just as told. They both hurry to pick up their clothes from the floor, heading to the bathroom right after. Phainon waits for him in the couch, right by the small christmas tree Mydei set up. So cute.

When Mydei walks in, he's holding a big box wrapped in a pretty blue. Phainon grins in excitement, his fingers fidgeting with the edge of the bag.

At the sight, Mydei shakes his head with a fond smile of his own. "Wanna go first?" he asks.

"*Yes*," comes Phainon's immediate response. Mydei sits right by his side, gently placing the gift on the floor. Phainon loses no time as he hands him the bag. "I really hope you like it. I think you will. But if you don't, that's fine, you can always—"

Mydei cuts him off with a kiss —something that Phainon with *no doubt* knows will now be a regular occurence— and carefully undoes the ribbon. Phainon watches with nervousness as he slowly takes out the box with the earrings, his leg bouncing up and down; he scans Mydei's face as he opens it and does his best to read his thoughts, but naturally, he can't.

So he begins talking. "I saw them and thought that they were really you. You use gold, right? I swear I've only seen you with gold, but maybe I saw wrong? You use gold, right?"

Mydei laughs softly, nodding his head. "Yes, I use gold. These are beautiful, Phainon. Thank you." As if to prove his point, he lightly tilts his neck to throw his hair back, sliding in the earrings with ease. "How does it look?"

Phainon sighs. "Well, you look absolutely stunning, obviously."

"Good," he answers, smiling almost bashfully. And Phainon wants to kiss him *really* badly, but he doesn't want him to accidentally drop the necklace, so he stays put. Mydei's lips part in mild surprise as he holds the piece in both hands. "It's a set."

Phainon scratches the back of his neck. "Yep. It was the plan from the beggining, but Cas and Cipher helped me out. You know. Do you like it?"

"Very much so. Mind helping me out?" Mydei moves his hair forward and Phainon takes it as the invitation he is: he very carefully places the necklace over his chest, sliding the chain to properly lock it by his nape. When he turns back to face him, Phainon feels as mesmerized as he felt at the coffee shop. Mydei strokes the little sapphires, gently. "Thank you. I love it."

He sighs in relief. "I'm so glad you do. And, uh, there's one other thing." Mydei quickly takes a peek inside the bag before he takes out the small black box. Phainon suddenly feels very self aware. "It's, well. I thought it was pretty and all. But now that I think about it, it might come off as weird." After Mydei lifts the lid and says nothing for a moment, he swallows. "I know that rings are kind of a big deal? I mean, not really, but I get the implicances and all. But I swear I'm not trying to be weird here. I was actually going to confess with it, real cheesy, but now that we are dating— I mean, are we? Sorry if I'm getting ahead of myself, but—"

"I'd hope we're dating," is all Mydei says, taking out the ring and sliding it along his finger: much to Phainon's relief, it's a perfect fit. Then, Mydei gently cups his face and pulls him closer for a kiss. Phainon allows himself to melt into his touch. "Stop overthinking so much, idiot. It's very pretty indeed. So thank you."
Phainon urges his shoulders to relax. "Okay. That's good to hear. I was kinda worried it wouldn't be your style."

Mydei smiles and leans back to pick up the box from the floor. Phainon feels a different type of excitement when it's placed over his thighs, just like the buzz he used to get whenever he was handed a square shaped gift as a kid. "I'm not sure if I'm good at gifts, but at the very least this should be of use," he says, folding his arms. "So I hope you like it."

Phainon shakes his head. "Whatever comes from you, I'll love it. And anyway, that dinner was more than enough of a gift. Thanks a million for that." He tries not to look too eager as he tears the paper as carefully as he manages, but he knows he fails miserably. He gives Mydei an apologetic smile, to which he only waves him off.

When Phainon finally sees what's inside, his mouth opens in surprise. Mydei clears his throat, a little flushed. "I know it's simple, maybe. But, I understand you really enjoy livestreaming and all, so I thought this would be a nice addition to your set. Hopefully."

Phainon fully frees the box from the envelope: it's a monitor that comes with a high resolution camera included, from a brand that he had been particularly interested in checking out at that. He's grinning like an idiot, he knows. "This is *incredibly* great, you have no idea. Thank you so, so much. I love it."

Mydei nods, faint relief plastered on his face. "Glad to hear that. If there's anything wrong with it, there's an insurance that covers for it."

"Got it. I'll set it up as soon as I get home. Thank you." He carefully leaves the box on the floor and finally kisses Mydei once more, being reciprocated with the same tenderness. "Can I say something super corny right now?"

Mydei opens an eye and immediately closes it, sighing into his mouth. "No."

Phainon smiles against his lips. "You're the best gift I could've ever asked for."

He hums. "Could've been worse."

"I *can* do worse."

Mydei grimaces, and leans back just to make sure Phainon sees it. "Please don't."

Phainon bites down every last word on his tongue when Mydei straddles his lap and shuts him up with a kiss, because really, that's all he wants.

"Merry christmas to you too, Mydeimos," he jokes inbetween, his hands sliding underneath his shirt for warmth.

Mydei pinches his cheek. "Merry christmas, Phainon."

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beauties and phainon

Castorice, Cipher, Phainon

Phainon

chat...

Phainon

i did it

Cipher

u didn't chicken out????

Castorice

omg!

Castorice

how did it go?????

Cipher

do we buy confetti or tissues

Phainon

well...

Phainon

he's sleeping next to me rn

Cipher



Castorice



Cipher

spill EVERYTHING.

Castorice

Writing as we speak



Castorice

Good morning, Mydei.



Castorice

I hope you had a great christmas.



Castorice

I don't mean to intrude, but Phainon told us the news.



Castorice

So congrats. Happy to know you two stopped dancing around each other like headless idiots.



Castorice



Mydei

I guessed he would. Thank you, Castorice.



Mydei

And for introducing us too. You do realize your matchmaking was spot-on, right?





Castorice

That was not my intention, really, but I'm glad it all turned well either way.

Mydei

So am I.





Castorice

See you next stream, Mydei.

▶

Mydei leans back in the chair, already missing Phainon's lips on his own. But. "Okay, enough. Your viewers are waiting."

His boyfriend pouts —despite knowing he's *usually* immune to such gesture — and drags his hand along the small of Mydei's back. "But I can't kiss you while we're live. Let me indulge while I can," his greedy self says, as if they haven't been making out for the past ten minutes.

It's a good thing their crotches are hidden under the desk, or else.

Mydei rolls his eyes. "You can kiss me plenty after," he answers and gives him a short kiss before pushing him back into his chair.

Phainon huffs in protest, but clicks the start button anyway. As the camera loads, Mydei quickly makes sure his hoodie is properly covering the bruises all over his neck; he catches Phainon doing the same with his turtleneck, and they smile in amusement at each other before facing the monitor: it's just slightly bigger than the old one, but the camera's improvement is really noticeable.

As always, Phainon greets the public with great enthusiasm while Mydei settles with a small wave.

"Did everyone have a nice christmas?" Phainon asks as he plugs in the controllers. "We— ah, *I* had a very memorable christmas. What about you, Mydei?"

Mydei wants to send daggers in his direction, but instead glues his eyes to the camera to avoid suspicion. "Cool. It was cool."

Phainon laughs softly and shakes his head. "Anyway. Before I tell you all what we're doing today, did you notice the image quality? Amazing, right? See, Mydei gave me a really nice camera. Everyone thank him."

Mydei sinks a little in his seat, face flushing. "There's no need for that. It was a christmas gift."

He realizes his mistake as soon as Phainon opens his mouth again. "*Ohh*, right. Why don't you show my gift?"

"Really?"

"Pretty please? Just to engage a little with our audience as we wait for more people to join," he says, pressing his palms together.

Mydei only sighs before brushing his hair away so the earrings can be properly seen. Truth is, he's worn them every day since he got them. Better for Phainon not to know that, though. "It's a set, but I don't have the necklace with me right now." He doesn't mention the ring for obvious reasons.

@DeliveringDawn

whimsicalthief: oh phainon YOU have such a GREAT TASTE picking jewelry. for REAL.

CastoMiss: You look stunning!


reavingflames: and when i thought this man couldn't look more gorgeous

thetwilightsky: woahh those are so pretty !!



caeluswasHere: huhh they gifting each other stuff now...

stellewasHere:



Send a message Chat

Phainon clears his throat after he reads over a couple *suggestive* messages. "So. In case you didn't understand the cryptic title, we're playing *Amphorean Chronicles* today. By your request! I'm always doing polls on my social media, so remember to check them out. If you weren't here for the last stream, worry not. All you need to know is that it's a combat game that both Mydei and I are experts at."

As Phainon starts the game, Mydei grabs his controller. "And the fact that we tied in all ten rounds. Today we settle that score," he says.

"Sure. And if not..." He lets the sentence hang dangerously in the air. When Mydei dares to look at him, he's giving him that same cocky smile he wears when he succesfully rails him up. So he decides to be the bigger person and ignores him, quickly selecting his character. By his side, Phainon only

snorts and does the same. "As always, in Kephale we trust. Now, if you guys are interested in checking the specifics, Cas attached a link to the game's site. There you can find all the mechanics!"

Truth is, Mydei isn't really expecting to win —or lose, for that matter— given that playing against Phainon is pretty much like playing against a mirror: just as sharp, just as skilled. He's a pain in the ass, really, but Mydei likes not having it easy. Somehow. It forces him to actually put some effort. Plus, he quite enjoys himself: he laughs openly whenever Phainon lamely misses a combo and doesn't miss a beat when he teases him, with Phainon answering in equal pettiness.

Based on their records, no one is particularly surprised about them still being tied halfway through.

@DeliveringDawn

 PhaiBot: FIFTH ROUND— zero to zero.

 whimsicalthief: u two ain't getting any better that's for sure

 thetwilightsky: this feels like deja vu ... but they seem so much more comfortable around each other now :) it's cute to see



neikoslove: yeah. like did anyone else realize mydei called him phainon. for like the first time ever





| In reply to @neikoslove: yeah. like did any...

reavingflames: ohhh pause ur right actually,, they've actually grown closer aw

caeluswasHere:



stellewasHere:



Send a message Chat

Mydei catches some messages in the passing, but he pays them no mind. He's too focused trying to beat Phainon's ass to really care— alas, all the attempts on both parties are evidently futile.

When they finish the seventh round, they briefly pause to drink some water.

"I was hoping to catch you off guard today," Phainon says, licking his lips.

Mydei tries not to let his eyes linger on the motion and snatches the bottle out of his hands instead, gulping down some liquid himself. "You play dirty like that?"

Phainon smirks at him, and Mydei immediately regrets his choice of words. "You tell me." Mydei only squints, hoping to dissuade him, but no. Phainon

leans a bit closer and lets his hand travel towards his ribs, and Mydei's body embarrassingly jerks up at the touch. "See, I know you're ticklish here," he says pointedly, raising his brows. "Should I take advantage of this weakness next round?"

"I'm going to break your nose." An empty threat.

"Okay, okay," Phainon's smile turns almost innocent, but Mydei knows him far too well by now to see the intent behind it. They idly stare at each other for only a split second before Phainon's fingers quickly begin attacking his sides in relentless succession. Mydei tenses his abdomen by instinct, folding over himself as he miserably fails supressing the laughter that overcomes him; and Phainon chuckles just as he does, the mere brush of his fingertips working as a weapon against him.

Ultimately, Mydei manages to catch his wrists, grasping them tight as he pulls them up. He's panting a bit in attempts to catch his breath, a stupid smile plastered on his lips. "You're an idiot, Phainon."

Far from being offended, Phainon's grin only grows wider, his hands relaxing into Mydei's touch. "And you like me."

Mydei only stares. It's hard to think about anything but the man in front of him when he's this close, really. So when he leans in to place a chaste kiss atop his lips, he does not care about the camera, nor the audience. It's short, no more than a humble brush, but enough for Mydei to taste him. Sweet and loving, as always. "I might, yeah."

Phainon giggles against his mouth. "I'm not against this at all, but you're aware of the fact we're still live, right?"

Mydei blinks at the reminder. He slowly leans back to angle his neck, only to be met with their own reflections in the monitor and a chatbox that flows so fast it bugs a little.

@DeliveringDawn

CastoMiss: I love them as much as they love each other. I DID THIS.

| In reply to @CastoMiss: I love them as...
 whimsicalthief: i'm madly in love with you

 thetwilightsky: oh okay !

neikoslove:







reavingflames: i knew the vibe was off ...



caeluswasHere: oh i've known what u are



stellewasHere: called it

King_Bartholos: i'm surprisingly not surprised



CyreneLvsMem:







Send a message Chat

... But, well. Mydei finds himself not caring at all. And Phainon doesn't either, for he pulls him close to kiss him one more time.

End Notes

not gonna lie. i feel in cloud 9. this is my longest work so far, and i enjoyed the process SO MUCH you have no idea. even the coding... which was admittedly super hard to get the hang of so to all programmers and people that do this in a daily basis: i really, REALLY admire you.

anyways ... i'm so excited to be posting this! and i'm truly hoping you enjoyed it as well. feel free to tell me your thoughts! criticism is always welcome :] (NOTE: i'm sorry if the smut was messy. this was my first time writing a full-on sex scene so i kinda went all yeehaw)

ok. too much yapping. i'm just very happy.

some other links:

> all the chats were made with HSR chat

> the recipe mydei & phainon used for the cake HERE

that's it from me. thanks for reading !!! <333

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!